Friends For Benefits

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/31197482.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Razz (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Fake/Pretend Relationship, Childhood Friends, Pining, Mutual Pining, Past Character Death, Human Catra (She-Ra), Sibling Rivalry, Adopted Sibling Relationship, Friends to Lovers, Fluff and Angst, Eventual Smut, CEO catradora, They're not FWB the benefits are work related lmao, Useless Lesbians, Lots of yearning and stupidity yay

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She-Ra Big Bang 2021, Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables, Top Shelf Fic

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by tpwkorra

Summary

“What?” Adora’s progressed to full on visible disgust now. There is no way in hell that’s true, and even if it is, there’s no way in hell she’s just going to roll over and surrender for an estranged sister and her complete stranger of a fiancé.

“They left it to both of us, yeah, until one of us marries. At which point, Bright Moon is to be led by the sister in that family unit, to someday be passed on to their children in the same fashion,” Glimmer says.

It’s Adora’s turn to take a moment to absorb.

If that does happen to be true, it’s the most ridiculous, bullshit of a deal she’s ever heard.

She’ll have to have their lawyers confirm first thing in the morning, but for now, the edges of her vision begin to seethe red.

~

Adora and her best friend slash business partner, Catra, attempt to fake an engagement in order to claim rightful ownership of the successful tech company they’ve been running for the past five years in Glimmer's absence.

Notes

Hi and welcome! This is not my first fic, but it is my first catradora work so please be nice.

Rated for smut, alcohol, cursing, sexuality, etc., as well as a healthy amount of reflection on parental death and estranged families. They're all adults so just don't be surprised when they act as such.

Many thanks to kirby for the wonderful movie poster work of art below!And for being so helpful and understanding throughout the whole Big Bang experience.

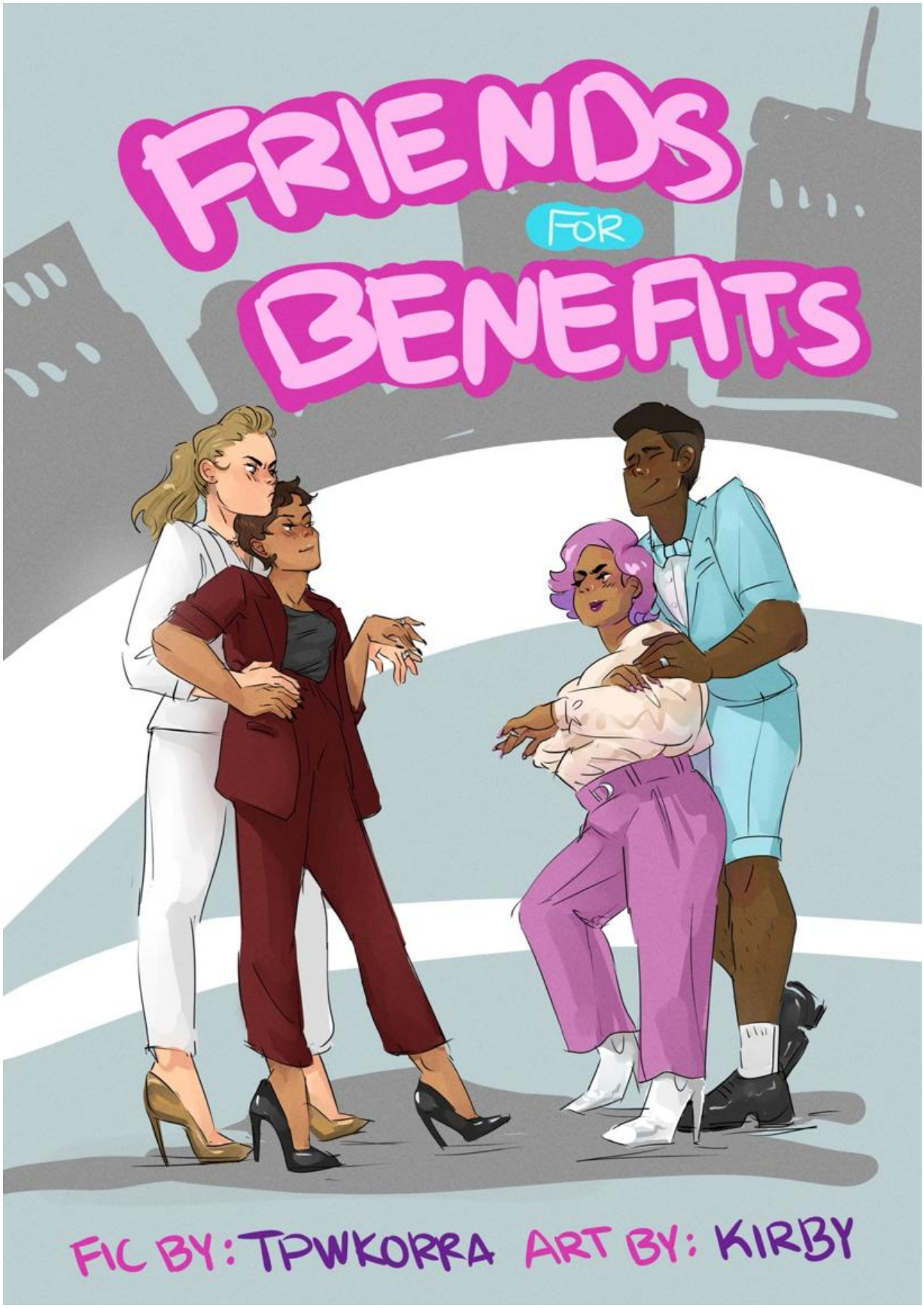
You can find me on Twitter as well.

That's all for now, enjoy!:)

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes


FRIENDS
FOR
BENEFITS
FIC BY: TPWKORRA
ART BY: KIRBY

A

True to form, Catra strolls into their shared office on Monday morning twenty minutes after Adora has already settled in at her own desk.

"Hey , Adora," she greets with a smile and a cof fee clutched in each hand.

Adora allows herself a moment of distraction from the open email on her laptop screen to admire the sight of her dearest friend. She always looks so nice in her business attire. Hell, she looks nice in a t-shirt and jeans too, but the loose-fit crimson blazer and slacks brings a more sophisticated sense of style to her form.

"Morning, Cold Brew—I mean, Catra," Adora smiles back as she stretches an arm towards the approaching drink, playfully grabbing at the air in anticipation.

"I always suspected you were only after one thing from me," Catra chuckles as she obliges the empty hand. Then she crosses the room to settle in at her own workspace, slinging the messenger bag off her shoulder and onto the desk as she plops down into her seat.

"I can't help it. I'm powerless to resist your sweet, sweet, caf feine," Adora jokes, converting back to business mode in the next instant when she asks, "Did you get a minute to look over the contract revisions Seamista's lawyers sent over?"

"You know I don't work after hours," Catra replies. She opens her laptop now, taking a sip of her own macchiato as she laxes against the back of her big cushioned chair in wait for it to boot up.

A frustrating, but necessary policy that Adora personally disagrees with on a visceral level. Catra swears her strict adherence to maintaining work/life balance is how she manages to keep her sanity and insists that it would do Adora some good to try it out.

That's just unrealistic, though. Making herself useful and being productive is what brings Adora her own sanity. Especially since Bright Moon has begun to skyrocket in the industry in recent years, there hasn't been a lack of work to keep her from being satisfied in that area anyway.

She sips her drink and busies herself with some other minor tasks in her inbox while she waits for Catra to get caught up.

"They want how much creative control and what percentage of profits?" Catra scoffs a moment later. "What do they even need us for, then?"

"Right?" Adora mirrors her affront, tearing her eyes from the screen to meet the blue-gold of Catra's. "I was hoping we could skip the formal meeting, but I guess that was an oversight on my part."

"It wasn't. The terms we sent over were perfectly reasonable," Catra says. "They're the ones playing hardball."

"You have no idea," Adora groans, "Just getting them on board to pioneer this project to begin with took a dozen calls and at least a fifty email exchange. Shall I send that your way for evidence?"

"I beg you not to," Catra waves it off in the next instant, "I'll just have Emily schedule something with them for next week."

"Assuming they're even open to negotiating to begin with," Adora says.

"We're one of the biggest VR brands on the market right now," Catra faithfully reminds her, "And the only one with the tech to entertain the idea of bringing an intimate live music experience right into people's

living rooms. They'd have to be one step away from the loony bin to pass this opportunity up."

"Are we entirely sure they're not?" Adora snorts.

*

The day passes in its usual blur of conference calls, meetings, and always an endless slew of scrolling through her email inbox. She doesn't get home until well after sunset, when the street is mostly quiet, but there's still plenty of lights on in her apartment building to indicate the other occupants settled in their homes for the evening.

The first thing both Adora and Catra did once Bright Moon began to carve out a real name for itself in the tech world is secure their own living spaces. Catra got herself a nice big house outside city limits, and Adora opted for a sleek penthouse apartment near the city center. It's a luxurious upgrade from their shared two bedroom an hour-long commute from the main office, but not one that wasn't earned without years of dedication.

The security of her building means that the doorman notifies Adora of an unexpected visitor before she actually sees the old familiar face waiting in the glistening marble lobby.

The short pink hair, though cut to about the same length as Adora remembers, is styled in a side sweep that ages her guest appropriately. She always had a plump figure, and the only thing time has changed about that is highlighting her cheekbones a little more than Adora remembers. She's dressed casually, in a purple shirt under a light blue cardigan sweater hung off one shoulder, with a fitting pair of jeans and pink high top Converses. It's a distinct clash in comparison to Adora's white blazer, tan slacks, and classic red pumps.

"Glimmer?" Adora feels the name fall off her lips like dust to be carried off in the wind of her utter disbelief.

"Adora," Glimmer smiles as she opens her arms for a hug.

Adora's body responds like a magnet, pulling her into the embrace without an ounce of hesitation despite the mountain of it building inside of her. As soon as she's warm against the softness of her sister's body, though, everything comes ripping through her in a violent rush of emotion.

Everything.

All the best and worst laughs and screaming arguments of their childhood, against each other and their parents. Their parents;oh, Micah and Angella and all the family vacations and game nights under the warm roof of their home. All the teenage rebellion of sneaking out, partying, the secrets they could never tell mom and dad, but always had a safe space to confide in each other. The Bright Moon tours as kids and that summer after college that Adora spent shadowing her father to learn the business while Glimmer chose to focus on her art instead.

The heart, gut, and entire soul wrenching ache of the funeral. And the added grief that colors the last memory she has of her sister from that same day.

"I—" Adora struggles to find the right words, any words, that could possibly make sense of this moment. "What are you…"

Her sister is *alive*. And she's back home, sort of. What even is home for the two of them anymore? Etheria City , sure, but this building, the new place she calls home, is all Adora's. Because Glimmer left. For a long fucking time.

"How about a hello?" Glimmer helps her along with a nervous chuckle in her tone, "Nice to see you again? W elcome back?"

Adora's not actually sure if it is nice to see her again just yet.

She has about a thousand thoughts and questions and frustrations zooming around her head, but the one that slips out first is, "Where have you been?"

"Kind of a long story," she gives a tiny, sheepish smile. "Can you invite me in?"

She nods her head towards the elevator and Adora snaps back into the reality of the moment. The bright and shiny lobby. The bright and shiny apartment. Her bright and shiny new life.

"Sure, yeah," she shakes her head clear before leading the way, keeping her gaze focused forward on nothing and yet hypersensitive to every little noise and motion around them. The click of her heels and shuffling of Glimmer's shoes across the floor, the whirr of the metal box descending, the ding of its arrival and the push of the top floor button. The shutting doors and the muted hum of their ascension.

The whole ride up is silent.

Adora's head is not.

How did you find me? Why are you here? Why now? Where have you been? How have you been? Why did you leave? Was it worth it? Are you happy with your choices? Are you happier without me?

Glimmer makes some comments about how nice the place is, how cool the view is. Standard stuff for near complete strangers upon their first entry. Adora remembers her first tour of this place all too well. The high ceilings, wide windows, and chic, modern furniture still inspire a humble gratitude within her under normal circumstances.

But tonight is anything but that, so Adora beelines for the liquor cart next to the kitchen island.

She's usually a beer girl, even in her flashy rich life, but the moment calls for something a bit stronger. Truthfully, she'd love to down a full bottle of cheap tequila and black the fuck out to escape the twisting in her gut, but she'll settle for a couple of peanut butter whiskey shots on the rocks. Sweet, smooth, strong.

"Want anything?" She asks, avoiding eye contact as she focuses on the pour.

"Sure. I'll have what you're having," Glimmer accepts.

So, Adora pours another and holds it out to welcome her sister into the glossy kitchen. She was just standing awkwardly by the door, which speaks to how nervous she is, too.

But Adora needs her to know that she isn't mad. Just shocked. Maybe the tiniest bit resentful, but still willing to listen. Most importantly, concerned. Because not a single day has gone by that Adora hasn't wondered what the fuck happened after she left.

"So," Adora leans an arm against the black granite countertop.

"You look great," Glimmer takes the opportunity to blurt out one of the thousand things probably clogging her brain the whole way here, "Amazing, even. It's just so nice to see you."

"Thanks," Adora purposely keeps it short, "You too."

She means it, though. Glimmer's skin has always had a beautiful warm tone, but Adora doesn't remember her glowing quite like this. Something about her demeanor, the sparkle behind her eyes, the tilt of her lips. whatever she's been up to all these years has made her happy. Truly happy in a way Adora didn't think to expect.

She hoped that her sister was alive and well, of course. But she also worried that may not have been the case.

"And this place is.wow!" Glimmer is once again looking around the open space of Adora's apartment, stalling. "Y ou've done so well for yourself."

"Thanks," Adora says again, taking another sip from her glass. "Catra and I.we've managed."

You could have, too. If you'd stayed.

"Catra," Glimmer 's face softens with a fond memory, "I'm so glad you guys are still friends."

"Of course," she decides on a whim to just rip the itchy bandage of f, "The idea of her ever not being in my life is almost as unbelievable as the idea of you showing up out of the blue is."

Because she couldn't have done any of it without Catra. Since her parents are dead and her sister left. Everything in her would've crumbled if not for Catra choosing to stay.

"Ouch, but fair ," Glimmer sighs, tipping her glass back to take a big gulp from her own drink before she speaks again. "Adora, I am so sorry. Deeply, truly, sorry."

"I'm sure you had your reasons, and I assume hurting me wasn't one of them," Adora attempts to shrug it of f, but it comes out sounding colder than even she expected.

She thought she worked through all this anger years ago, but apparently this little drop-in has stirred something wretched inside her.

"It wasn't, truly . God, if I could've spared you." Glimmer tries to explain, but catches herself. Possibly realizing there isn't a single thing she could say to justify it.

Maybe a tiny, horrible part of Adora kind of hoped something had happened to render Glimmer incapable of reaching out, because at

least then it would make sense why she hadn't called in five whole years. At least then, Adora couldn't be mad at her.

"But you didn't," Adora reminds her.

"But I didn't," she surrenders with ease, letting an enraging silence blanket the room for a moment.

"Why?" Adora just asks it. She hopes to high heavens it doesn't sound as desperate as she feels.

Glimmer takes her time. She gulps again, hard swallows, and lets out a breath.

"I just...needed time," is what she says. Her big brown eyes have always had a pinkish tint to them, and they sparkle now, just the same as Adora remembers. She holds her sister's gaze as she listens to the speech she imagined a hundred times over the years and yet never exactly like this.

"I felt so fragile back then. Like I would break if anybody even looked at me the wrong way. Especially you. And for that week between mom and dad's death and the funeral, I didn't even feel like a person. I just felt like this empty thing. I don't know how to explain it —"

"You don't have to," Adora interjects. She felt it too. That numbness, that disbelief, the feeling like your insides have been carved out and you wish you could peel your skin off too, because then there'd be absolutely nothing left and you wouldn't have to exist in the world anymore.

And then her sister added to it.

"Right," Glimmer nods, looking down at the ice cubes in her glass as she goes on, "You were always so much better at dealing with things than me. Part of me didn't want you to have to take care of me *and* yourself while grieving. But the other part just really wanted to run. I

didn’t know how to handle a world without mom and dad. Didn’t know how to handle myself.”

In their childhood, Glimmer had been anything but a coward. She was the first to learn to swim, ride her bike without the pedals, go sledding down the biggest hill in their neighborhood, the first to have her first kiss and first time and first beer and first everything. Adora wasn’t exactly shy either, but she admittedly drew a lot of that strength from her little sister’s bravery making her feel like she could be brave, too. And that trickled down into helping Adora know how to talk Catra up, too. Adora may have been the organizer, but Glimmer was always the true leader of their trio.

And then she left.

“Why didn’t you call?” Adora wonders. She takes another swig to brace herself for the answer.

I didn’t want to. I didn’t miss you. I’m happier without you. You’re not my real *sister anyway.*

Glimmer’s brows scrunch together in discomfort.

“I took too much time,” she says. “Before I knew it, three years had passed and I didn’t think you’d want to hear from me. I thought you’d be angry. I… don’t know… I worried. And then I worried for another two years before deciding to do anything about it.”

“Of course I wanted to hear from you,” Adora says it quickly enough that it could be misconstrued as vicious. “I mean… I… worried, too.”

“I know…,” Glimmer sighs again. “And I know I fucked up. And I know that all I can do now is apologize and hope you can find it in your heart to forgive me.”

Adora aches to her core.

She's angry, and yet somehow the compassion is able to coexist with it. She hates her sister, but she also loves her more than any living person on Earth next to Catra. They're all she has left. Aunt Casta and Grandma Razz and all of Adora's other friends, sure. But the love she has for them isn't comparable to a platonic soulmate or sisterly bond.

So it's like second nature to accept Glimmer back into her life. What would shutting her out after years apart accomplish for either of them, besides waste even more time?

"W ell, I hope your vacation helped," Adora says, resting her elbows on the counter to lean over it, relaxing. She doesn't try to force a smile, but she wants to make it clear that she is open to reconciliation. "I just hope you're okay now ."

"I am," Glimmer does smile. "And I hope you are, too. I mean, I know you've done wonders with Bright Moon, but are you personally alright?"

"Mhm," Adora nods as she gulps down the last of her glass, chuckling lightly, "Bright Moon basically is my life, so yeah. I'm great. I want to hear about you."

"I've hardly been up to anything as exciting," Glimmer shrugs. "I moved to Mystacor, which was cool at first, but eventually became more of the typical city stuff. I had four roommates, Adora. It was a nightmare."

"Oh no," Adora chuckles at the idea of being crowded in a house with that many strangers, and finally, finally, feels the storm cloud begin to lift.

"Y eah, do not recommend," she groans, "I worked at a cof fee shop for a while, and then scored a gig at this gallery downtown, which I loved. And then when I was finally established enough to live on my own, I met my fiancé."

She pauses to gauge Adora's reaction. It almost seems like she's trying to convey something, silently hinting as if her and Adora even still speak the same language. It's weird to confront the fact that they don't. Her stare is just an echo of the telepathy they used to share. Adora has no idea what she's trying to communicate, but maybe because her brain is fully stuck on one word.

"Fianc?" She repeats.

"Y es!" Glimmer grins from ear to ear as she holds out her arm, fingers spread for Adora to admire the ring. It's just a simple silver band with a decent sized diamond set between two tiny pearls, perfectly adorning her ring finger.

"V ery classy and timeless," she admires, nodding, "They did good!"

"Right?" She gushes, "His name is Bow . He's perfect, Adora, really. I think you're gonna love him."

"I get to meet him, then?" Adora smiles. Her sister is back and she' s getting married; holy shit.

The walls begin to crumble down as they talk more about wedding plans and naturally flow to other things. Glimmer tells the story of how they met and how she said the L word first so he popped the qestion. Adora doesn't have a single dating story to share, so instead fills Glimmer in on how she and Catra managed to transform Bright Moon from a way to pay the bills into Forbes' number one rising company of the year.

"I am so glad to see it doing so well," Glimmer settles into a warm smile, "Mom and dad would've been so proud of you both."

"Y ou think?" Adora replies, "Sometimes I wonder if they would've done things a bit differently."

"Oh, I'm assuming they had a million dif ferent plans that we'd have disagreed with," the two of them share a fond chuckle of

remembrance, "But the most important thing is that you've kept their legacy alive. Shit, you've practically built an empire! They'd be so proud of you for that, and just.you know , for the person you've become."

Their parents started the company as a computer repair shop back in the early nineties. Over the years, they acqired the expertise to build their own computers, where they were able to carve out a solid niche for the next ten years until Adora reluctantly took over in their absence. Catra wanted in too, and Adora was overwhelmed with how much responsibility she suddenly had, so she welcomed the help.

For the first couple of years, they followed Angella and Micah's five year plans. And it was sustainable, but felt a bit stagnant after they got the hang of the business themselves. It was hard to predict the future of technology from a grave, after all. So Catra suggested they start taking some creative risks, which after a series of failures and rejections that they consistently helped encourage each other through, eventually led to finding their footing in virtual reality tech.

It's not at all what they expected, but it's something to be proud of. It's affirming to hear that the only other person who knew their parents as well thinks they would be, too.

"Thank you for saying that, Glimmer ,"Adora reaches out to place a grounding hand on her forearm, "They'd be proud of you, too, you know."

Glimmer smiles back as they bask in the memory of their late parents.

"I just hope that Bow and I can fill your shoes when we step in,"she swirls her glass as she says it, "The only experience I have running a company is when dad let us play secretary that summer after senior year."

She laughs at the memory, but Adora gets stuck on the first part about her and her fiancé "stepping in."

"What?" She blinks.

"Come on, you remember!" Glimmer playfully nudges her, "You were so excited to follow him around and learn the business, but he just stuck us at the front desk to answer the phones all day. Catra used to bring us boba in the afternoons."

"No, no, I mean, what did you say about you and Bow?"

"Oh," Glimmer deflates a little, but ultimately still seems clueless when she clarifies, "About us taking Bright Moon off your hands?"

"Taking it off my hands?" Adora recoils, standing up straight again, "As if it's some kind of burden?"

"Well, I figured you'd probably welcome a break from it all," Glimmer shrugs like there's anything even in the realm of nonchalance about the completely plummeting turn this conversation has taken, "Knowing you, you've been working nonstop for half a decade at this point."

"Sure, because I love what I'm doing," Adora defends, "What on Earth makes you think I'd just step down for you and your fiancé to waltz in on a whim?"

Glimmer pauses as the depth of Adora's offense begins to register.

"Adora," her voice is more careful when she speaks again, "Mom and dad wanted this. It's in their will. You didn't know?"

"Know what?" Adora gawks. As far as she's aware, the company was to be passed on to their daughters in the event of their death. The only reason Adora's been running it with Catra is because Glimmer didn't want any part of it. And now she all of a sudden thinks her and Bow get all of it?

"Who they left the company to in the event of their early passing," Glimmer says it like it's the most basic fact, like how could Adora have missed it all these years?

"Their daughters. Plural," Adora says.

"Until whomever marries first," Glimmer adds.

"What?" Adora's progressed to full on visible disgust now. There is no way in hell that's true, and even if it is, there's no way in hell she's just going to roll over and surrender for an estranged sister and her complete stranger of a fiancé.

"They left it to both of us, yeah, until one of us marries. At which point, Bright Moon is to be led by the sister in that family unit, to someday be passed on to their children in the same fashion," Glimmer says.

It's Adora's turn to take a moment to absorb.

If that does happen to be true, it's the most ridiculous, bullshit of a deal she's ever heard.

She'll have to have their lawyers confirm first thing in the morning, but for now, the edges of her vision begin to seethe red.

"So you came back for Bright Moon," she concludes. "Not for me."

"Adora, no! Oh my god, I thought you knew," Glimmer swears, "That's why I said it so casually. I didn't realize it would be upsetting."

"Why didn't you think I'd be upset, Glimmer?" Adora's voice rises now, "You think you can just come back after five years of not even a single call, and I'll just sit here and fucking smile while you rip my life out from under my feet yet again? As if leaving me alone after the death of our parents wasn't enough of a backstabbing to last a lifetime?"

Glimmer blinks, finally realizing just how mistaken she was by coming here to dump all of this out at once. Adora is not a violent person, but this little piece of info has just dumped her back into the days of childhood wrestling over the tv remote or who gets to use the shower first. She could fucking leap at her throat right now.

"Adora, I'm sorry , I really didn't mean to upset you. But without this we have nothing," Glimmer 's voice is softer now, pleading, as if Adora owes her a single thing after her disappearing act, "Bow and I..I mean, we quit our jobs and sold our stuff to come home."

"Well, I'm sorry you didn't consider your options before doing something so stupid," Adora snaps. "Sorry you didn't think it pertinent to maybe, hm, I don't know, talk to me first? Sorry you think so little of me that you have the nerve just walk in and out at your convenience!"

"Oh, okay , like you're mom or something?" Glimmer fires back with a scoff, "I don't need your permission to live my own life, Adora!"

"No, Glimmer , like I'm your sister who deserves to be treated like I matter!" She's fully shouting now , unable to hold her erupting rage at bay any longer. "Or did you need time to forget me when you left, too?"

Glimmer's jaw hangs open in disbelief, her eyes widen with shock. She blinks a few times to maintain her composure when she replies.

"I wasn't trying to forget anything," she says, shaking her head for the sake of her own clarity as she heads towards the door, takes her sweater off the hook to shrug back over her shoulders. It all happens just as quickly as the first time she left. One minute she was there, and the next time Adora turned around, she wasn't.

The silence hangs thickly between them, chipping away against the bubbling volcano in Adora's chest with each tiny movement.

"And it doesn't really matter if you want to step down or not," Glimmer pauses to look over her shoulder and lock eyes with Adora for one more prolonged moment.

The threat in her tone is flooring. She's not asking for a spot in Bright Moon;she' s taking it. With their parents' blessing. And reminding Adora that there's nothing she can do about it.

Adora isn't sure who this person is, but it's not the Glimmer she remembers. She's always been a feisty spirit, but never malicious. And never aimed at Adora.

When she turns back around and shuts the door behind her, it feels cold and final.

*

"It' s complicated,"Adora sighs, leaning back in her chair as she watches Catra pace across their office in frustration the next morning.

"How is it complicated?"Catra throws her arms in the air as she rages, "W e're the CEOs of Bright Moon Inc. True or false?"

"T rue, but—

"Okay then, how is that complicated?"

"Because Glimmer is, too,"Adora explains, "I mean, she left, sure, but my parents did leave the company in our hands. She just didn't want it back then."

"So then she must have like, surrendered her claim or something, right?"

"Not legally ," Adora explains just as their lawyer did for her over the phone on the way here.

"And you never had anyone look into that until now?"

Adora squints at her friend. Her smart, sweet, supportive best friend who she loves and does not want to take her misdirected anger out on.

"You never did, either."

"I didn't think we needed to!"

"Well, neither did I!" She defends, "When our parents died, I just stepped up because someone had to, and it clearly wasn't going to be Glimmer. I didn't count on her ever coming back, let alone with the expectation of taking over!"

Catra's nostril's flare, but she ultimately comes to the same conclusion.

"I'm sorry . You're right," she admits it through gritted teeth.

"Unfortunately , Glimmer is too," Adora sighs. "I triple checked with the legal department for any sort of loopholes or way around this, but it's airtight."

"Sorry , but this whole thing is such bullshit!"

"I know!"

"What was their logic in that?" Catra rants on, still pacing back and forth animatedly as she processes out loud, "What if Glimmer ends up getting divorced? Then this random dude just weaseled his way into owning a multi-million dollar company he knows nothing about!"

"We don't divorce, Catra," Adora says;not defending her sister , but the sanctity of marriage their parents instilled in them that makes her

sure Glimmer wouldn't have chosen someone she couldn't trust with a lifelong future. "It's not how we were raised."

"More bullshit!" Catra scoffs, "This isn't the fucking fifties. On the off chance that you do end up miserable in a marriage, you should be able to call it quits. Not to mention, Sparkles clearly has a history of being a runner! What if this guy is a total scammer? Or God forbid, turns out to be abusive or unfaithful! Is she just stuck with him forever?"

"Our parents showed us what real love and commitment looks like," Adora sighs, remembering the purity of the way they used to look at each other, "Our whole lives, we watched them love each other. They always went on about how their bond made them a great team and that running this place brought them closer every day. So, infuriating as it is, it makes perfect sense that they would want that for us, too."

"One of you, at least," Catra quips, "The second to marry just gets left in the dust? Or what if neither of you ever got married?"

"They probably figured we wouldn't leave the other out completely," she works through it all out loud, "And of course I'd more than happy to have her on the board if she didn't want to completely rip this out from under me. If anyone's gonna get the lion's share of executive control, it should be me. I earned it!"

"Exactly!" Catra's voice rises in unison, "She doesn't even know the first thing about running a company!"

"I know!" Adora agrees.

"So what can we do?" Catra slams both her palms flat against Adora's desk as she leans in closer for the dramatics.

"Nothing," Adora groans, leaning back against her chair. "That was my first question, too. But at the end of the day, mom and dad have spoken. Bright Moon was never really ours to begin with."

"This is so unfair ," Catra growls.

"I know ," Adora groans again.

"No offense, but even in death, your parents are so"…

"Their rules," Adora rolls her eyes. It doesn't make grammatical sense, but the two of them understand anyway. Hell, Glimmer does too. Or did. They were always so by-the-book. Always concerned with authority and being proper and keeping up appearances. Adora can't even count the number of times the three of them had to sneak around in order to live with those two.

"Okay , so. Hear me out," Catra says after a minute, waiting for Adora's nod of approval to go on. "They wanted a married couple to run the business, right?"

"Yeah, Catra, we just went over that," Adora says.

"Okay , so, what if. I mean" Catra hesitates, holding Adora's gaze for a prolonged moment that feels far too heavy for Adora to bear on her own.

"What if what?" She nearly shrieks.

"It's gonna sound crazy," Catra sweats, removing herself to start pacing again. She looks like a mad scientist, so Adora braces for the reveal of a big, evil plan. "But try to stay with me. A couple is technically defined as a pair, right? It can be two people, sure, but you can also have a couple of cats or a couple of apples, etcetera… "

"Well, obviously," Adora isn't getting where this is going.

"You and I are two people," she says. "So by that logic, we're a couple. Technically."

"I mean, I guess," Adora's voice is straining now, but Catra just lets the words linger between them for a few beats, pausing her frantic

back and forth to look at Adora like she's waiting for something to click.

Adora just stares into blue-gold, still not understanding.

"So what if we got married?" Catra spells it out for her.

"Huh?" Adora quirks her head to one side. "Much as my parents loved you, they did not leave the company in your name. So even if you were married, that wouldn't count," she tries to process out loud, "And I'm not even seeing anyone, therefore nowhere near close to tying the knot before Glimmer and her new fiancé."

"No, you idiot," Catra lightly snorts, "To each other."

Adora can feel the spark of the short circuit in her brain.

Married? To Catra?

"What?"

"Like, not for real, of course," Catra explains, "But what if we just let it slip that we're engaged, too? That we've been engaged, before she showed up. If we just set the date before hers, we can make sure the company goes to you, as it rightfully should."

"You're suggesting we fake an engagement," Adora widens her eyes, "A whole marriage, even."

Even if it was a tiny semblance of a sane idea, how on Earth would they manage to pull something like that off?

"Yeah, true, we'd probably have to stay married for a while, to be convincing," Catra aimlessly waves her hands around as she sounds like she's still figuring out the details herself, "But after like, two years or so, we could say it isn't working out, we've decided to just be friends again, blah blah blah, whatever. By that point, the company is already officially ours anyway."

"Catra, there are so many flaws in this plan already ," Adora objects, "Nevermind that I can't act for shit, did you miss the part where I said we don't do divorce in my family? Dad would have my head for even letting this idea touch my eardrums!"

Not to mention the fact that it would be a complete sham of a marriage to begin with. Maybe that doesn't make the fake divorce as horrible of a concept? Or maybe that makes it a thousand times worse.

"I would take care of the storytelling to minimize your participation as much as possible," Catra rambles on anyway , "And it wouldn't be a real divorce because it's not a real marriage. Let's be honest, it's not like your parents would ever find out."

"Catra!" Adora can feel her heart pulsing in her throat now; maybe in part because some of this is starting to make logical sense. Maybe she's just that desperate for a solution.

But mom and dad would kill her for even daring to consider it. Murdered. Head on a fucking skewer. Worse than any of the other more minimal crimes she's committed against them over the years, including trashing their five, ten, and twenty year business plans in the name of modern innovation.

How you could even deign to entertain such a maniacal idea is far beyond me! We raised you better than that… her mother's voice shouts in the very forefront of her mind.

"My parents wanted a family to pass along their company . So I'd be going back on their death wish," she tries to rationalize the morality of it out loud.

"Oh, whatever!" Catra throws her arms in the air again, exasperated, "It' s not like you'll never have a kid to mentor someday; you're just not ready yet. And that wish probably came from a place of wanting the best for the family business in the first place, which we both know isn't Glimmer and some total stranger!"

Her arguments are completely valid.

It's not as if this would be the first time she and Catra have done something sneaky behind her parent's back, either. For much less important things than the fate of the company they've both dedicated every minute of the past five years of their lives to.

The plan isn't even to cut Glimmer out completely. She'd have a stable job, of course, which is probably more control than she deserves at this point.

"Say I actually agreed to this," Adora asks, slowly, still deliberating between what she knows is wrong and the need to protect her empire, as Glimmer so graciously put it last night, "You'd give up two years of your life just so I can stay in charge?"

"So *we* can stay in charge," Catra corrects. "You're an even bigger idiot than I thought if you think I'm signing a prenup."

Adora snorts. Catra is so...magical. She's a genius, really. A beautiful, ridiculous, completely unhinged genius.

And she's as worthy of a share in the Bright Moon name as Glimmer is. Moreso, even, because she's actually put the work into growing and maintaining it while Glimmer spent the past five years actively avoiding that responsibility.

"And then after the divorce, we'd just go back to running it as friends?" Adora has to work it out loud in order for her brain to fully absorb the concept. She doesn't actually hate the idea, and that in itself is disappointing, but only because she knows her parents wouldn't approve of this level of deception. She can't think of a better solution, though.

"I mean, it'd be a friendly marriage, too," Catra shrugs, "We'd have to act mushy around others, but obviously I wouldn't expect you to put out when we're alone."

Flustered by the fleeting flash of those implications, Adora huffs.

"You mean this isn't a convoluted ploy to get me into bed? Crap, I'm out, then," she quips.

Catra smirks. "As if I would even have to scheme for that."

She wouldn't. And she hasn't. Which is probably a good thing in the big picture, showing that she values their friendship just as much as Adora does.

"Anyway," Catra derails that before it can go further. "The real question is whether you think your atrocious acting abilities are up to the challenge?"

Adora sits with it for another minute. If there was any other option, she wouldn't even be considering it. But at this point it's either the fake marriage to her best friend, or stepping down and rearranging her entire work life to make room for Glimmer at the center of it.

"I guess I should start looking into some improv classes," she lamely jokes her confirmation.

How on Earth did she end up actually agreeing to this?

"This little stunt is gonna be the ultimate improv class," Catra laughs.

*

With all the stress of the past 24 hours, Adora throws herself into work as a distraction. The skyline outside the office window has gone dark save for the city lights when her desk phone beeps with a call from the downstairs lobby.

"Emily , I thought you'd gone home already," Adora pushes the speakerphone button to respond, instinctively looking across the room towards Catra.

"On my way out, miss," Emily says, "But um, you have a visitor . Says she's your sister? She wouldn't let me leave until I buzzed you."

Catra's brows raise in intrigue. Adora frets, eyes widening in panic.

They were going to plan out all the details of their fake engagement right after the agreement was made, but the work picked up quickly . New projects to approve, PR meetings and board briefings, and always an endless stream of emails. And since Adora hadn't planned on seeing Glimmer today, it was supposed to wait until they could sit down at a bar and decompress a little to devote their full attention to the matter. Going in unprepared was sure to be a colossal disaster.

She takes her finger off the button so Emily can't hear her freak out.

Catra's already a step ahead of it, though, "If you don't let her in, it'll be suspicious."

"No way , we had a fight last night! I've been ignoring her calls all day," Adora whisper-shouts even though it' s just the two of them in their office, "I'm not ready for this yet!"

"Shhh! Adora, it' s fine," Catra assures with a wave of her hand, "I've been working this out in my head. Just follow my lead."

"How do you have any room in there? I've been trying to think of anything besides this!"

"Because you suck at lying and I, on the other hand, know how to contrive a good story."

"I'm not sure if that' s more comforting or unsettling."

"Doesn't matter . Buzz her in, we've got this," Catra nods towards the phone.

Adora lets out a sigh, steadying her voice in stark contrast to her pulsing heart before she presses the front desk button again.

"W ould you mind escorting her to the office before you head out?"

"Sure thing," Emily says, then goes silent.

"Game face, baby ," Catra grins over at her .

There's about a sixty percent chance that Adora's nerves might cause her to wretch her dinner all over the floor before Glimmer even arrives.

She starts fiddling with the buttons of her blazer, adjusting the shoulders, smoothing the edges of her hair, tightening her ponytail, making sure everything on her desk is perfectly arranged as if her sister would know the difference anyway. She just has to do something to keep her hands and mind busy in the few short minutes it takes for the elevator down the hall to beep, indicating someone's arrival on their floor.

Then Emily's black bob and stocky stature stride into view on the other side of the glass walls, Glimmer in tow. Once she sees Adora, and then Catra, she's the one to speed past Emily and burst into the room first, something like apprehension and excitement on her face all at once.

"Scumbag!" She shouts with a smile;using their old childhood nickname for each other.

"Sparkles!" Catra grins, too, hopping up from her desk to actually embrace Glimmer as if no time at all has passed between them.

Starting off strong with the act, leaving some big footsteps for Adora to follow in.

"Is there anything I can get you all before I head out?" Emily directs her question towards Catra and Adora while simultaneously side-

eying the reunion happening before them. It occurs to Adora in that moment that their assistant probably didn't even know she had a sister.

"That's all, thank you, Emily. Enjoy the rest of your evening," Adora dismisses her, ignoring the excited buzz of chatter between Glimmer and Catra in the background.

"You too, thanks!" Emily nods, happily scurrying off before anything else can delay her departure again.

Catra plays dumb as soon as the three of them are alone. "What brings you here? Adora mentioned you were back in town, but I didn't expect to see you in the office!"

Okay, half-true. Neither of them expected she'd show up here. Like home, it's new. Significantly bigger, shinier, fancier than where their parents ran things from, and that becomes more glaringly obvious as Glimmer scans the room and the view in awe.

"Uh, about that," she starts, sheepishly, finally making eye contact with Adora for the first time since last night, "I just thought it might be better to apologize in person."

Catra quirks her head to one side.

"Apologize for what?"

"Oh, drop the act," Glimmer says, and Adora's heart jumps into her throat like they've been caught before they could even attempt to pull off their half-baked charade. "There's no way she didn't tell you how messy last night was."

"She didn't, actually," Catra says, looking towards Adora for her cue now.

Adora swallows the lump in her throat, mentally pep talking herself into actually saying something out loud to get the ball rolling on this

entire ruse.

"I, um, hadn't exactly processed it yet," she lies. Right to her unsuspecting sister's face. Every cell in her body fights the urge to twitch.

"Long story short, we got in a fight," Glimmer sighs, her shoulders falling with it. "So I came to tell you how sorry I am for dropping the bomb that started the whole thing. That is not how I pictured our reunion going at all."

She explicitly does not apologize for showing up out of the blue and expecting to take over Bright Moon with her shiny new fiancé, which reminds Adora of exactly why she agreed to this fake marriage in the first place.

"It's okay," Adora says. Lies. "I'm sorry, too. For reacting the way I did. I didn't plan on seeing you ever again, really," she chuckles, a bit deliriously, "But of course I'm glad you're back and I agree that fighting is not the best way to reconnect."

"Thank God," Glimmer chuckles along with her.

"It's just that you showing up here unannounced, after all this time, and with a fiancé. Wow. It was a lot, you know?" Adora stumbles through her made up lines, trying not to sound as fucking furious as the sun burning in her core would suggest, "And then all that stuff about mom and dad and the company, it just. You know, caught me off guard. Way off guard."

"That's totally understandable, Adora," Glimmer says, "I know it seems like it came out of nowhere, and we obviously have a lot of catching up to do. But it's time for me to come back, ya know? I've done my grieving, I've grown up a lot, and I feel ready to take on this responsibility now."

"I understand," Adora says, barely mumbling in the next breath, "I mean, a call would've been nice, but whatever. You're here now."

"Great," Catra interjects, gesturing ambiguously between the two of them, "Sisters, yadda yadda, love that for you. Did she say fiancé? As in, little Sparky is engaged?"

Glimmer rolls her eyes, but she's smiling.

"I am!" She beams, stretching out her left hand to show off the ring again. "Honestly, we all have Bow to thank for pushing me to reach out again. He knew it wouldn't be right without my family at the wedding. He really wants the best for me."

"Sounds like a keeper. Congrats," Catra swiftly looks over at Adora in a silent acknowledgement of their mutually triggered gag reflexes before she asks, "Have you set a date yet?"

"November first," she beams, "Gives us a little bit of room between both our birthdays. Thankfully, it was the only slot our dream venue had open for the next two years."

"Shut up!" Catra's jaw drops in feigned shock, "That's like two months after ours. What are the odds?"

Adora's lungs shrivel into raisins and fall into her feet with how hard she holds her breath after that line slips out. It's reality now; there's no going back. She and Catra are to be married two months before Glimmer and her mystery man, and it totally wasn't a last minute ploy devised with the intent of intercepting ownership of the family business. Nope. Not at all.

Glimmer pauses, scrunching her brows together in confusion. She looks over at Adora for confirmation, but Adora just sits, sweating in the hardened tension.

"Two months after your what?" Glimmer presses.

"Um, our wedding? Duh. What else would we be talking about?" Catra's response is so natural, like she expected Glimmer to have already known. "Did she not even tell you we're engaged?"

"We as in, the two of you? To each other?" Glimmer asks, pointing back and forth between them. "I think I would've remembered something as fucking huge as that."

"I didn't want to make things all about me," Adora quickly says. "I hadn't seen you in so long, ya know? I wanted to hear about you. And then that whole argument cropped up…"

"The argument about how mom and dad left the company to whichever daughter marries first," Glimmer reminds her, the strain clear in her voice as her eyes immediately lock onto Catra's naked hands, and then to examine Adora's crossed on top of her desk. "Where are the rings?"

Adora panics. Screams. All internally, of course, but she's at a complete loss for words.

"Resizing," Catra gracefully takes over. "Hopefully we'll have them back by next week, but that'd be the second time we were promised they'd be ready soon."

Glimmer squints, shifting to hold Catra's gaze again. "When did you say the date is?"

"I didn't, but September second," Catra says it automatically, before Adora can even begin to contemplate such a thing. It's a very convincing tactic. It even makes her wonder if there's some significance to that date, or if she just picked something roughly two months before November.

"Hm," Glimmer hums, looking back to glare at Adora dead in the eyes. "Well isn't that convenient."

"Sorry, did I miss something here?" Catra wonders like she's completely lost. "You two look really intense all of a sudden."

"It's just crazy how Adora seemed about ready to bash my face in when I reminded her of the will last night, and now the very next day

it comes out that she's suddenly in line to inherit Bright Moon before me? My bullshit alarm is blaring," Glimmer snaps.

"Wait, wait, wait," Catra is so good at this, it almost makes Adora wonder what else she's been faking about throughout the years. Almost; because at her core, she trusts that Catra wouldn't be putting on such an elaborate act around her of all people. "I'm officially lost."

Glimmer doesn't falter.

"Adora? Care to explain?"

Catra looks over at Adora, too, expectant in her feigned curiosity.

"It turns out that our parent's will declares that whichever sister gets married first inherits the company," she keeps it simple and sweet, seeing as everyone present already knows the full extent of it anyway.

Catra lets her jaw fall fully open in shock. "Adora, I swear to God if that's why you finally proposed, you'll be on the fucking couch for the rest of our lives."

Jesus Christ. How did she become so thoroughly involved in this? Now all of a sudden it's been established that Adora is the one who popped the question. If Glimmer asks about specifics, they're fucked. What if, in her suspicion, she makes Catra shut up and forces Adora to make up something on the spot? They're totally fucking fucked.

She could just nip this in the bud early. Throw it all out the window right now; apologize for the weak attempt at trying to pull it off in the first place. Glimmer would be mad, but they'd basically be even after the five years of cut contact, right?

She might actually have to barf.

"Of course not!" Adora finds herself objecting anyway, scoff sounding genuine as she can muster. "I didn't even know about the stupid thing until last night."

Catra squints. "That true, Sparkles? Don't let me walk off a cliff here."

"If it was, would you still marry her?" Glimmer fires back.

It's the first time Catra visibly falters. She hesitates, looking back and forth between the two of them, and in that fleeting moment, Adora senses an undertone of sincerity. She knows it's something different because Catra's focus is sharp when she's lying, but she becomes a little softer with her answer this time.

"I guess it wouldn't be the dumbest thing she's ever done," she finally shrugs.

"Hey!" Adora huffs. Also genuine. Agreeing to this fake engagement is indeed the dumbest thing she's ever done.

"You're right about that," Glimmer agrees with a pensive nod, "We also both know Adora's not a good enough actress to pull off the rage that I witnessed last night."

"Probably true," Catra nods, but she's squinting at Adora with feigned suspicion.

A silence tightens between them now, as the two of them hold their breath in wait for Glimmer to take the bait. Whether she actually buys it or not doesn't seem to matter, because she decides to play along regardless.

"Well, it's great news. I am happy for you guys," she processes out loud, laughing a bit nervously, "Honestly, Scumbag, I never thought you'd get your chance!"

She nudges a suggestive elbow towards Catra who widens her eyes in a response that's meant to stay for the two of them. And Adora

can tell that that is definitely a genuine reaction.

"What was that?" She asks.

"Nothi—

"She didn't tell you? That is so like her ," Glimmer practically cackles, tilting her limp wrist at the humor, "I guess some things never change."

"Tell me what?" Adora wonders, side-eying Catra. Just a moment ago, she was sure they didn't have secrets between each other.

"Catra's had a big, fat, stupid, crush on you since like, preschool," Glimmer smirks. "I can't believe you didn't know! You two are ridiculous."

She only met Catra in first grade, but Glimmer has been known to hyperbolize for the sake of dramatics. Adora shared her cookie with the new girl in class and they've been inseparable ever since. They used to race around the blacktop together and share their favorite stickers during study time. Catra did used to get upset whenever she saw Adora making other friends, but that was probably just because she didn't start making her own until several years later, in high school.

"Had!" Catra aggressively corrects. Her cheeks are kissed a rosy pink under her freckles all of a sudden, though. Is it even possible to fake a blush without the help of makeup? There must be some truth to it, otherwise Catra would just play it off like she just spent the past ten minutes doing with all the false information she wove between them.

And that means Catra has a crush on her. Or had.

"I *had* a crush on you, a long, long time ago," she emphasizes again, sparing Adora a single second of eye contact before she rolls them

all the way up to the ceiling. "But I didn't think it vital to mention because that's kid stuff, who cares?"

"Surely you do, because now you're fully in love!" Glimmer snorts, "It' s cute."

"Let it go, Glimmer ," Catra strains through gritted teeth. She only calls Glimmer by her real name when she means business. And if Adora knows her best friend at all, she can tell when Catra is two seconds away from wringing someone's neck with her bare hands.

Had or has? The dif ference is crucial.

"Y ou had a crush on me?" Adora teases, grinning now , too.

It might even be reciprocated on some level. Catra is hot and she knows it. Shit, there was a time back in the day when Adora would practically soak her panties every time Catra so much as said her name, but one can only take so many years of unreciprocated pining before it becomes pathetic enough to move the fuck on.

And Catra's right; it' s just kid stuf f. Adora has long since tucked those thoughts away somewhere they couldn't interfere with their very real and much more sustainable friendship.

"Y es, okay! Whatever! Can we move on now?" Catra grumbles, "Y ou know, back to what is apparently something about the legalities of who Bright Moon actually belongs to?"

"Right," Adora nods, snapping out of the fantasy and back into reality where it's time to address Glimmer again, "W ell, of course Catra and I can make room for you and Bow, and then you know, after you prove yourself you can—

"Prove myself?" Glimmer catches, "Like I'm not worthy to run my own parents company?"

"I didn't mean it like that," Adora sighs, "It's just that it's constant work, Glimmer. And not just that, but authority. Team management. Delegation. Decision-making. The industry changes all the time, and Catra and I have already shown that we're both reliable, but you—

"So now I'm not reliable?" Glimmer interjects again, seemingly looking to pick apart everything Adora says at this point. Like maybe she did come here to fight, after all.

So maybe Adora is just plain sick of her, after all.

"No, Glimmer, you're not!" She shouts, effectively throwing another blanket of pause out over the room. "You left. So no, you're not reliable and you do have to prove you're able to handle the business," Adora's voice grows firmer in that way it always does when she has to be a leader, because this is her element now. It's what she shines at, and that's a perfect reminder of why she agreed to do this little stunt with Catra in the first place. Because this is where she belongs.

She can't just go down without a fight.

"You haven't been here to keep things moving. You haven't helped us grow, perfect the image, discuss new projects, bring in fresh ideas, supervise production, build professional relationships, or any of the million little tasks that go into running this place on a daily basis! You don't deserve this and everyone in this room knows it."

"Bullshit, I don't deserve it," Glimmer raises her voice back, "I left because our parents died, Adora! They died! I was hurting and unstable, so I did what I needed to do to get my fucking head right. But I'm still a partial owner until your vows are final, which means I do deserve a chance to demonstrate what I know I'm capable of."

"I know why you left, Glimmer, but it doesn't change the facts," Adora says. "My parents died, too. But the difference between you and me is that I chose to stay and work through that by nourishing their legacy. And I intend to continue doing what's best for Bright Moon,

which means I have every right to be cautious about your long history of impulsivity."

"It sounds like you think you're the only one in charge," Glimmer says, "But for now , I still have just as much claim to this company as you do."

"For now ," Adora says, severing their connected gaze by looking back down to the stack of papers on her desk, dismissing her sister with an established lack of attention.

She doesn't actually see Glimmer leave, but the elevator's beep alerts her of when it's clear to look up again. Catra's just standing there, saturated with visible concern.

"That was brutal," she says.

"I feel like I hardly know her anymore," Adora sighs. She' s still talking to her desk, but once she presses her hands against the side of her forehead in frustration, it's like saying the words out loud destroyed the dam behind her eyes and the sobbing suddenly racks throughout her.

A soothing palm begins to drag from the top of her spine to her lower back in a steady, repeated motion.

"Well, we kind of don't," Catra empathizes. It' s nothing but relief that she doesn't try to stop Adora's tears, just lets her cry it out like she needs to. "A lot can change in five years."

"I always hated fighting with her ," Adora snif fles, "That hasn't changed at all."

"I loved it," Catra jokes. "But that' s because she's like, little and cute or whatever. It's funny how worked up she gets. Nothing funny about what just happened here, though."

Adora lets the tilt of her lips pull up, even through her hysterics. Catra and Glimmer always did have that instigative sort of relationship with each other;something else that hasn't changed yet anyway.

"Exactly ,"Adora agrees, lifting her head to wipe away the tears from her cheeks.

She should be ecstatic to finally have her sister back. Maybe a little resentful, but nothing that couldn't be mended. This tangible hostility between them is completely uncharted. It feels like they might be dancing in dangerous, irreparable territory.

But it's too late to take any of it back now. Maybe they can work on fixing things after the wedding.

Some horrible part of her wishes Glimmer would go back to Mystacor and just let the two of them be happy again.

"What if she does something crazy , like what if they elope?"Catra suddenly worries.

"I don't think she' s the type. At least, the sister I knew lived for ceremonies and formal events,"Adora says, "She' s like mom in that way."

"She could have the ceremony after the courthouse of ficialities."

"She won't, though,"Adora swears, "She' s always wanted a big wedding. And this isn't a game to her;she actually wants to marry this guy. We're the ones trying to rush things."

"W ell, what if we elope?"She suggests anyway , "just to make absolutely sure they can't beat us to it?"

"Catra, slow down,"Adora takes a breath;it' s her turn to be the rock again. "Y ou already picked a date only a few months away. I think

that's soon enough, considering we're talking about marriage. A lifelong commitment."

"A two year commitment for us," Catra reminds her. "And by then I'm sure your sister will have earned her spot, but until that happens, Bright Moon has to stay ours."

"But don't you feel kinda scummy about it all?" Adora sighs, "My parents really valued their marriage, and our family, and that's something they wanted us to learn too. I can't just barrel into this headfirst like you."

"I can do that because I know the difference between right and wrong, and it might sound crazy to you, but this feels right," Catra explains. "I mean, us running this place together. It's the only thing that makes sense to me."

Catra never had anyone else when she was young. There was Ms. Weaver, the adoptive mom who's husband left before Catra was old enough to even remember, and two other siblings who eventually found their solace somewhere else, too. For Catra, it took until she was around ten and began to spend all of her free time in the Bright's household instead. Ms. Weaver barely noticed or maybe just didn't care, so Angella and Micah became the closest things she had to parents. Glimmer was the sister she never had. And Adora was… well, Adora's never thought of Catra as her sister, that's for sure.

Besides the years of playful flirtation, Glimmer's taunting from earlier could be the evidence that Catra never considered her one, either.

"What about your crush on me?" She wonders.

"Oh come on, not you, too," Catra's hand shoots back to her own side in stiffened defense.

"I just want to make sure you're fully over it," Adora's words don't really match up with the internal voice wondering if she even wants Catra to be over it, so she buries that with even more words. "I don't

want this to complicate anything between us, you know? It feels like I'm losing my sister all over again. I can't lose you, too."

Catra huffs, crosses her arms, flicks a loose wisp of hair from her face, scrunches her nose. She looks Adora in the eyes when she's done stalling.

"I told you, it was just kid stuff," she swears. "I haven't felt that way about you since. Christ, I don't even know. It was fleeting and I grew out of it."

That's good news, right?

Right?

"So what, you're saying I'm not desirable anymore?" Adora jokes the icky feeling away, waiting for her friend to catch on and lighten the mood.

Catra cracks a smirk.

"As a life partner, you're my ideal match."

Chapter End Notes

I'm aiming to post at least weekly updates, probably more, but don't hold me too closely to those standards. I do have most of the story already planned and written out, so I promise not to leave you all hanging in WIP land when all's said and done.

Comments and kudos certainly couldn't hurt though :)

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Some rings, some dinner, some drama, some fun. Hehehe. Enjoy!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

C

"So, here we are," Adora's tone is full of apprehension as the two of them stand outside the jeweler's that weekend.

She's dressed down in a pair of knee-length denim shorts with the cuffs rolled and a red tee shirt tucked into the belt around her waist. She usually keeps her hair down on her days off, and it drapes over her shoulders now. Her gray-blue eyes are accentuated by the minimal mascara on her lashes, and nothing else but the natural blush of her cheeks to highlight her effortless beauty.

If only Catra could actually put a ring on it.

"Here we are," she says, turning to stare ahead, through the big, glass doors.

Under normal circumstances, Catra probably would've looked into hiring a personal jeweler. Maybe ordered something custom online. Could've even had Emily run this little errand in the middle of a workday, since the rings aren't an actual symbol of their loving commitment anyway. But neither of them are quite used to all the money and power yet, so Adora especially still prefers doing things for herself. Maybe she always will. In any case, Catra wasn't about

to let her have this adventure on her own. The least she could do is make sure they ended up browsing at the finest boutique in the city .

"And we're absolutely sure that this is the only way to keep Bright Moon?"

"If you have a better idea, I'm all ears."

Adora sighs. Catra knows it's just because of the internal conflict of ignoring her parent's last wish, but it still stings.

"Just think of it as a game," Catra suggests, "A fun little prank. You love pranks."

She chuckles. "A game where we win by fooling everyone into thinking we're in love."

Haha. Just a fun little prank.

"Exactly ."

"It's just so weird," Adora chuckles nervously , "I never thought I'd be shopping for engagement rings with you of all people."

"Well, don't say that like it's so insufferable," Catra teases.

"Oh come on, you pictured this? With me?"

Yes.

"I don't know ," she shrugs, adding another white lie, "Not under these circumstances, but I probably would have invited you along for a second opinion on my real fiancé's ring."

I'm in love with you, you idiot.

"Aww, you like me," Adora jokes.

"Oh, just shut up and hold my damn hand," she huffs, sticking her hand out, palm up, like some kind of retail transaction.

Adora pauses, stares at the offering, her face falling from a teasing grin into a look of bewilderment.

Is this that hard for her?

"Right, yeah," she nods and clears her throat once, before gently placing her hand on top of Catra's. Then she just looks back up to Catra's eyes and they stand there for a moment of silence. A breeze dances over them and carries a wisp of hair across Adora's forehead. Catra resists the urge to brush it away.

It's fine. She's fine. They're only holding hands. This isn't fucking middle school. She can be an adult about this.

"You're right, it's weird," she agrees, playing it as cool as she can muster, severing their eye contact again. "And it's about to get a hell of a lot weirder."

She takes a deep mental breath, laces their fingers together, and doesn't let herself even think about it. Just pushes the huge, glass door open and marches inside, preparing to have to shout over the pounding of her heart in her ears.

"Welcome," a salesperson greets them with a smile and a bell dings to indicate their entrance to the brightly lit store. "What brings you two in today?"

Showtime.

"We're getting married," Catra beams like she was born to say those words out loud.

"Well, congratulations to the happy couple!" The man smiles back, "So you'll be headed towards the wedding bands over this way, then."

“W ell,” Adora stretches her other arm out, empty fingers spread in the same fashion of an excited fiancé. “The proposal was kind of a spur of the moment thing, so we should probably start there first.”

It is beyond endearing to see her play the role so relaxed, without the pressured gaze of a suspicious sister breathing down their necks. Catra lives for messing with her, but really, Adora is more adaptable than even she gives herself credit for.

“Ah, I see,” the man nods, “The engagement section would be over here, then. Would you like me to walk you through some options?”

“W e prefer to browse alone, thank you,” Catra smiles.

“Of course. I’ll be right over here if you have any questions.”

Adora takes the lead in pulling her towards the nearest display, lit up inside with an array of glittering silver and diamonds. Her hands only sweat a little bit compared to the bubbling within her.

“How was that?” Adora asks between the two of them.

“Emmy nominated,” Catra breathes a little chuckle through her nose.

“Only a nomination? And for a TV role, no less?” Adora feigns offense, “Where’ s my Oscar?”

“Slow down, captain. Y ou delivered a one-liner without sweating your pants off,” she rolls her eyes, “Y ou get an Oscar when you give an Oscar-worthy performance.”

“Fair enough,” Adora laughs as they begin to peruse over the selection.

She never put much personal thought into details like this, though. What kind of ring does Adora like? What does she even want for herself?

So many of their options are so big, sparkly, and just.typical. Not to say that some of them aren't pretty, but nowhere near fit for her personal style.

"None of this will do," she groans.

"You hate the traditional look," Adora guesses.

"I do."

"Wedding pun! Nice!" Adora raises her hand for a high five that she instinctively returns. "Let's sweep the store and meet at the register in ten minutes?"

"Deal," they shake on it and break in opposite directions.

She skims over most of the cookie-cutter stuff, stopping to consider only the ones that really call to her.

When she initially suggested this arrangement, she was just thinking on the spot. Adora said that Bright Moon could only go to a married couple, so it seemed obvious that they'd have to get married.

Now that they're actually here though, it's intimidating. What was she thinking? How are they really going to pull this off? Glimmer's already suspicious. And what kind of emotional toll will it take for her to pretend to be in love with the actual love of her life, who she's been pretending *not* to be in love with for so long it's basically second nature?

If she lets it slip at all how nervous she is, Adora will surely back out. And it's not like they don't have other streams of income with stock and investments, but Catra genuinely likes going to work every day. She likes the innovation and the problem solving, likes getting to essentially hang out with her best friend in an office setting, likes being able to trust that they'll always be able to figure things out together.

She can't just let Glimmer storm back into town and mess everything up.

One of the worst parts is that she actually missed Glimmer. Part of her wasn't even acting during their reunion. It's only when she starts panicking about losing the company that the anger rises with it. Why does she have to make herself so easy to hate sometimes?

Eventually, a ring does snap her out of all her winding thoughts. It's a kite cut salt and pepper diamond with a V-shaped white diamond band. Thank God for the description card set into the display case, otherwise she would've just called it *the cool black one with the pointy edges*.

"Let me guess, you're eyeing the emo one," Adora sneaks up behind her, earning a surprised squeak and a smack on the arm.

"It's not emo!" She objects, making Adora laugh. "It's cool."

"It's very you," Adora agrees. "I like it."

Sold.

"You probably found something super classic," Catra guesses. "Plain band, probably gold. Decent sized gem, traditional cut. Nothing too flashy, but still a little dazzle."

"You calling me basic?"

"Am I right, though?" Catra hums fondly.

Adora just gets a little smirk on her face as she grabs Catra's wrist and drags her towards the other end, past the rings she'd already dismissed for herself.

"You've known me too long," she agrees, pointing to a big pear shaped ruby with two smaller side diamonds on a rose gold band. It's actually a little bit different in a way that perfectly complements her own. They may as well have picked them out together.

"Let me get it for you," Catra blurts before she can even consider the implications.

"What? No way! It's too much," she objects.

"It's barely half a day's work," Catra counters.

"I've got it, really," Adora insists. "If I'd have known you were buying I'd have picked something much more modest."

"I want to," Catra says, "Come on, I talked you into this deal in the first place, so it's the least I can do."

"You don't have to buy me off with a ring."

"I do, though," she says. "I want you to get something nicer out of this than just being chained down to me for the next two years."

"You seem to think of that as more of a burden than it actually is," Adora replies, though still with a slight hesitance.

"Are you saying you actually like me too?" Catra teases.

Adora just smirks like she has a secret.

"Fine," she finally gives in. "But I'm gonna do something nice for you as payback. I haven't figured out what yet, but you better watch out cause it'll come when you least expect it."

"Oh no, betrayal! Please, have mercy," Catra laughs.

Before the salesperson checks them out, he asks if they want anything engraved.

"Wedding date?" Adora raises her brows as she looks over at her.

"Nah," Catra decides, "I'm just ready to get that rock on you as soon as possible. I've waited long enough!"

Adora holds a hand to her heart and aims her soft little puppy-eyed melting face towards the sales person when she gushes, "Isn't she the sweetest?"

They are so good at this. Catra could burst into a cloud of confetti with how proud she is.

"You two are adorable," he smiles. "I see a lot of couples on a daily basis, but I have to say you make the list of favorites."

"Oh, I'm sure that's what you tell all your paying customers," she plays along.

He laughs as he begins to key in things on his register.

"I know how it sounds, but I can usually tell who's meant to be and who probably won't even make it down the aisle," he says. "So trust me when I say that the love oozing out of you two right now is a beacon of hope in this crazy world."

Catra swallows.

Sign it in, bitch. He's saying you're disgusting.

"That's a good sign, right babe?" Adora nudges her in the arm.

Holy shit.

Adora has never called her anything besides her name in all their years of friendship. Holy shit.

She might actually combust.

"We appreciate the vote of confidence," she smiles back.

"No problem. Good luck with everything," the man says as he stuffs a receipt and catalogue into their bag. He explains about the return policy anyway, and then gives them a friendly wave to send them on their way.

"Oh my God," Adora lets out a laugh as soon as they're outside in the breezy summer air again. "He really bought it! He didn't have a clue! Wow. Do I get my Oscar yet?"

"Shut up, you dummy," Catra joins in as they fall into step on the sidewalk. "You did great, don't get me wrong, but the real test is whether we can convince Glimmer to buy it or not."

"If that's what it takes for the Academy to recognize my achievements, I'm in it to win it," she grins.

They round the corner and walk a few more blocks and stop at some random ice cream spot, then sit on a bench nearby to admire their newly adorned ring fingers in the sunlight. She actually really likes the way hers looks in the sun especially. The main rock is actually a dark grey color with flecks of black inside it, which becomes clearer in the light. Never mind how it seems to blend with her sharp black nails, as if it was made specifically for her hand.

She reaches for Adora's hand again, this time to get a closer look at the bright red gem she picked for herself. Maybe partially trying to adjust to all the touching they'll have to do in the name of feigned romance. It's not that they've never cuddled or knocked knees when sitting next to each other, just never with such intimate undertones. Adora seems to stiffen as Catra leans closer into her personal bubble, but maybe she's just getting used to it, too.

Technically they even don't have to pretend when nobody else is around, though.

"Hey, I meant to ask, why September second?" Adora says as she takes her hand back and licks her tongue from the bottom of her Cherry Garcia scoop to the top. "It seemed so specific."

It's far too corny to admit that she remembers the first day Adora approached her, sitting at a table by herself in the elementary cafeteria room, literally over twenty years ago.

"Dunno," she shrugs, finally digging her spoon into her own hot fudge sundae, "I honestly pulled it out of my ass at the time, but now that you bring it up I think that's when kids go back to school."

"Huh," Adora hums, "Don't tell me you've got a bunch of fake babies planned for us, too."

Catra snorts.

"At least they wouldn't be an accident."

"Sure," Adora agrees, "I mean, that's unlikely to happen in any unconsummated relationship, but valid nonetheless."

Sometimes she swears Adora knows exactly what she's doing. Other times, she seems so oblivious about these kind of things that she wouldn't know an innuendo if it smacked her on the ass.

"Slow your roll, we're not even married yet," Catra chuckles.

"Bummer . I'm already having so much fun!" She smiles in a way that tugs on every string she has tied to Catra's heart. What a difference in her demeanor when she's free of the stress that comes with why they're doing this in the first place.

"Do you ever think about your real wedding day?" Catra wonders.

"Of course," Adora nods. "I think I just want something simple. I like the idea of a private ceremony, just the two of us and maybe a few witnesses. And then a huge reception where everyone's invited to celebrate afterwards."

Catra's heart flatlines at *the two of us*. She knows Adora is just imagining her future wife in abstract, but still her mind draws up an image of Scorpia and Entrapta in the witness stand, clapping as *the two of us* lean in for a kiss. And all their other mutual friends and associates, dancing and laughing the night away at the reception.

It's silly. She knows that.

And still she replies, "Sounds like the right idea. Quiet ceremony, big party, long honeymoon. I always wanted to take like a month off and just go travel around for a while. Hit parts of Europe and Asia, maybe end in New Zealand or something."

"Ugh, that sounds amazing," Adora agrees, "Did you know you can swim with whales in Australia? I've always wanted to try that. We should add it to the list if we're gonna be right there, ya know."

"Wait, are we planning our real or fake wedding slash honeymoon right now?" She wonders.

Adora blinks, contemplating for a quick second.

"I guess the fake one, yeah," she finally shrugs. "I mean, we both just agreed on what we want. And the act doesn't end after the ceremony, so why not celebrate the big heist with a big trip afterward?"

How on earth could it possibly get more real than planning her dream wedding with her dream woman, followed by a dream honeymoon to kick off her literal dream life?

Except it's not real at all. Just a real big mess.

"The big heist. Sweet," she chuckles anyway, swallowing the lump in her throat disguised as bits of banana and ice cream, "That was easy. Thought the wedding planning stage was supposed to be like poison for unstable couples."

"Those people clearly didn't choose to marry their best friends," Adora beams.

*

Contrary to popular belief, Catra does not spend every waking moment of her life with Adora.

It was an adjustment when they decided not to live together anymore, considering how often she spent the night in Adora's room when they were kids, then when she was finally of legal age to move out of Ms. Weaver's home and she had her very own room under Angella and Michah's roof though college, and then when Adora needed her to stick around after they passed and Glimmer abandoned her, too.

Only when Bright Moon began to really take off a few years ago did they decide it was time to put a little bit of space between them. Well, Adora's therapist did, anyway. And with time, Catra eventually came to realize that it was for the best. She kind of enjoys having her own home to herself now. Is it preferable to living with the wife and two kids she'd always dreamed she'd have by this point in her life? No. But complete independence is freeing in a way she never thought she'd get to experience either, so she doesn't intend to waste it.

For example, if she wants to have her friends over on a Wednesday evening for poker and darts in her rec room basement until three am, that's her business and hers alone.

"Oh. My . God. It's perfect!" Scorpia squeals, eyes sparkling nearly as much as the ring on Catra's finger. She tried to be subtle about it, but they noticed pretty much as soon as she started dealing their cards around the table.

"Very unique. I like it," Entrapta agrees, "I bet it could do some serious damage if you ever had to fight someone off."

"I thought so, too," Catra grins, recoiling her hand to make a couple fists and punch at the air.

"When would that ever happen?" Scorpia's jaw hangs open slightly in disbelief.

"Dunno," Catra shrugs, "This city's pretty big. Can't hurt to have some protection, just in case."

"So wait, wait," Entrapta pauses, "When did you guys start dating?"

"We've been keeping it private," is all she says. Gotta be careful not to give too many details that could conflict with each other later. "In case it didn't last, you know? We didn't want everybody making things weird between us."

Entrapta would probably see it as a fun social experiment and try to play along for the research potential, but Scorpia would definitely try to talk Catra out of it. And she doesn't want to be talked out of it. She wants to make sure the company stays in the hands of its rightful owners.

And marry Adora.

Fake marry.

"But this is like, your lifelong dream come true!" Scorpia beams. "How did you manage to keep it a secret for this long? I would've burst in with the news as soon as it happened if I were you!"

"Obviously," Catra and Entrapta both say at the same time.

"Didn't you and Perfuma literally FaceTime me as soon as she said yes?" Catra recalls, tilting the edge of a beer can against her lips.

"And then me," Entrapta raises hers in a solo cheer.

"And then you were married like two weeks later," Catra adds.

"Lesbian romance is truly a fascinating phenomena," Entrapta agrees.

"It was three weeks, actually," Scorpia says, "We could never have planned such a beautiful event in so little time."

"So many flowers," Catra shudders.

"If you need a florist, you know my wife would be more than happy to help out," Scorpia reminds her .

"Genuinely surprised you haven't my wife'd the woman to death yet," Catra rolls her eyes.

"Oh come on, you can't tell me you're not excited to call Adora your wife, too," Scorpia says, "It' s such a fun word. Wife! *My* wife! Because I'm married. To a beautiful woman who I love!"

"Gag," Catra says, but goddamn if she can't control the warmth blooming across her face or the stupid little smile tugging at the corner of her lips.

Even if it's all for show, she'll get to introduce Adora as her wife or partner or whatever, while the most beautiful, bright, and lovely person on the planet stands next to her and plays along.

It's absolute torture.

"It' s just gonna be a small thing with a few witnesses," she says a moment later, taking another big chug, "But tell your wife we'd be honored to pay double for her services."

"Y es! I can't wait to tell her!" Scorpia fist pumps the air .

"So, wait, does that mean you're getting rid of this place, then?" Entrapta wonders, "Converting to a summer home? Airbnb?"

"I'm keeping it," Catra says. She hadn't actually thought through as many of these details as she claimed. She's always been good at flying by the seat of her pants, but the deeper she digs into this hole, the more she realizes she missed. "I mean, I already stay at her place most nights, but it's still nice to have some independence, ya know?"

"How interesting," Entrapta hums. "It's like you're on completely opposite ends of the spectrum. Scorpia and Perfuma are a peak stereotype, where you and Adora are doing almost nothing by the book. I wonder why that is."

Maybe because we're not a real couple.

"I don't know, maybe because we're better than them?" Catra rolls her eyes.

"In your dreams, Wildcat!" Scorpia scoffs.

"Adora and I could definitely take you two in a match," Catra maintains.

"Of Smash Bros, maybe!" Her and Entrapta share a laugh.

She'll consider that a successful diversion.

*

After two rocky starts in a row, Glimmer is still trying to patch things up with Adora. Which is both annoying and admirable, because in the same situation Catra would have given up after the first botched attempt, let alone the second.

Maybe not with Adora, though.

In any case, Glimmer insisted on inviting them over for a double date with her new fiancé so they could all attempt a third fresh start. She's staying at their old family home, so Adora is in some kind of mood on the way there.

"Have you even been back since we left?" Catra asks, noticing the silence from the passenger's seat.

"No," Adora's answer is curt, and Catra can see the strain in her jaw. She reaches over to lay a hand on her shoulder, and feels the muscle soften underneath her touch, like she was sitting rigid before that simple gesture.

"Are you okay?" Catra asks, tentatively.

"I think I'll be fine," Adora says. She visibly swallows, but maintains her staring through the windshield.

Catra has to keep her focus on the road, but it doesn't mean she can't also watch Adora through her peripherals.

"I just miss them, you know? We'd never be fighting like this if they were still around," she eventually sighs.

"Sure, because there wouldn't be any company ownership to fight over if they were still running things to begin with," it's a lame attempt at lightening the mood, but Adora gladly takes the bait.

"Good point," she scoffs. "I could at least ask them what the fuck they were thinking when they came up with this stupidly unfair split, though."

"They'd probably just say something like *you'll understand when you're older*," Catra suggests.

"Ugh. Mom loved that one," Adora groans.

"You know, I used to think of you guys as some weird sitcom family, like Full House," Catra breathes a chuckle through her nose, tightens her grip on the wheel. "My place was always so empty, even when people were around, but at yours you were always helping each other and working things out. So warm and understanding."

That finally earns a little giggle. Mission accomplished.

"Oh my God, we were the sitcom family," she realizes. "I was just remembering how whenever Glimmer and I did end up fighting, dad

would come sit with me and say some corny thing about how family is all we've got, and he'd find the exact words to make me realize it's not worth it. Meanwhile, mom would be lecturing Glimmer's ears off in the next room, and when they were done we'd bond over how ridiculous their methods are"…

"And then the three of us would go get takeout like nothing ever happened," Catra laughs softly , reminiscing along with her.

She'll never be able to miss them as much as Adora does, but they were always there for her, too. They never questioned how much time she spent in their home, always set an extra plate for her at dinner, and consistently went out of their way to make sure she knew she wasn't alone. Who knows how she would've turned out without them?

Adora's tenseness has melted into the faintest of smiles by the time they pull into the driveway.

A

She didn't exactly have a specific image of him in mind, but the muscular, dark skinned guy with the kind brown eyes who answers the door next to Glimmer is certainly not who she expected.

He's dressed on the casual side of nice, with a patterned button down shirt tucked into his jeans, comfy brown boots, and his kinky black hair slicked back on both sides. The smile he flashes is perfectly straight and white, like he could be a mouth model or something.

"Hello and welcome," he says, extending his arm for a polite shake from each of them, "I mean, not that you haven't been here before, but uh, since we live here for the time being, I mean~~uh~~."

“Adora, Catra, this is Bow ,” Glimmer takes it away from the ball of nerves, “Come in, we just finished setting the table.”

“Hi,” Adora addresses Bow as she steps inside, savoring the old familiar smell of her parent’s things still furnishing the house.

She kind of ran in her own way, too. Once she and Catra had enough to move out, she all but forgot about everything in here. The important things, the memories, follow her everywhere anyway.

“Beau,” Catra asks, “Y ou French or something?”

“Uh, no, it’ s B-o-w, like a bow and arrow?” He explains with an inflection like he’s unsure of it himself, “One of my dads is super into archery.”

“Cool, you ever shoot an arrow?”

The two of them fall into casual conversation, which only fuels the tornado twisting around in Adora’s gut. How is Catra so good at acting like there’s nothing going on here besides a first meeting of two sisters and their fiancé?

She and Glimmer share an awkward look, like she’s trying just as hard to find something appropriate to say.

And that cuts deep, because this should be a happy moment. They should be thrilled to see two of their favorite people on the planet getting along.

She doesn’t like fighting with her sister, especially when all she’s wanted for the past five years is just to know her again.

And yet, her sister is a threat to her personal security. She can’t just ignore that.

She can tell that Glimmer is cycling through the exact same internal conflict, but she doesn’t know how to end it, so she just tears her

eyes away for the time being and follows the two of them into the dining room.

"So, is it Catra like an actual cat?" Bow is asking as he pulls out Catra's chair for her to take a seat.

Catra pauses, shoots a reassuring look over to Adora that communicates her disgust for the unwarranted kindness, then politely accepts the gesture anyway.

"It's short for something, but my adoptive mother just called me Catra," she explains, keeping it short and sweet.

Probably not the best idea to trauma-dump all over the dinner table, but only Adora knows how much she used to hate it. She has a vivid memory of the day that Catra stormed into her bedroom, clearly upset about something, and angrily announced that she decided to reclaim the name like a slur, the way Ms. Weaver always said it. She was always so determined not to let that woman see how deeply she affected her.

"Oh, adoptive," Bow nods, "That's cool, me too. I'm really blessed to have such amazing fathers, and I honestly think it's given us a chance to be much closer than most blood families. Are you close with your parents, too?"

"No," she says simply.

"Oh," Bow blinks uncomfortably. "Well, I'm sorry to hear that."

"It's okay, it's not as tragic as it sounds," Catra offers a soft smile as she looks over at Adora sliding in next to her, "Adora and her family have brought all the love to my life that I've ever needed."

She knows Catra is just playing the role of doting fiancé, but Adora still finds herself inwardly flattered. She can't help but wonder how much of the act is inspired by reality, especially since Catra's always

said that the best way to get away with lies is to keep them as close to the truth as possible.

"Honestly , I think that's why it's so weird to see you guys in love now!" Glimmer forces an awkward laugh as she enters the room with a platter of what looks like prime rib and sets it between the plate of crushed potatoes and the bowl of mixed veggies.

"Looks amazing," Catra comments, deliberately ignoring her to reach for the serving utensils.

Adora innocently quirks her head to one side. "How so?"

"It' s just like, we grew up together , ya know?" Glimmer explains, waving an ambiguous hand around as she slides into the seat Bow pulls out for her, "Catra' s like a sister to me. And you're my actual sister, but now you kiss each other. It's a little weird, right?"

Adora narrows her eyes slightly. Glimmer can be sneaky, and it would be naive to assume that she's completely over the viciousness of their last encounter. Even Adora isn't fully over it;she just thought they were playing nice for the sake of trying to reconnect. But if Glimmer wants to go the route of not-so-subtly trying to undermine their engagement, then she can also brace herself to fight back twice as hard.

Catra pounces before she can even think of how to respond to something so out of pocket.

"Guess what, Sparkles? W e also do other things, too," Catra lowers her voice to a whisper, cupping her hands around her mouth as she leans in to mouth her next words like it's a scandalous secret, "Like sex."

Adora snorts an awkward laugh. Haha. Yeah. Plenty of that going on behind closed doors.

"Not what I was getting at at all!" Glimmer cringes.

Bow just chuckles. "They are consenting adults, ya know."

"And so are you two," Catra winks. She's clearly trying to keep things from getting messy again, bless her.

"Okay, Jesus! I didn't mean to start a risqué conversation over dinner," Glimmer shuts it down, "I just mean the idea of you, Adora, my literal sister, and you, Catra, someone I also thought of as a sister... it's gonna take some getting used to."

Adora has never heard her call Catra a sister before, but it's not like she's the only one lying for an agenda.

"That is so inappropriate," it's Adora's turn to cringe.

"It's not really," Glimmer shrugs, "You two obviously feel very different about each other, so I'll probably just have to see it enough to get used to it."

She then holds Adora's gaze in wait, like a challenge. She brings her fork to her mouth to grab a bite off it, chewing expectantly.

There is no way she believes this engagement is the real deal.

"Glimmer," Bow's warning comes from under his breath, but Adora speaks nearly a second later.

"Are you asking us to put on a show or something?" She scoffs.

"Now that's inappropriate," Glimmer plays dumb all of sudden.

"Borderline homophobic," Adora bravely accuses.

"Oh, come on! That is so not what's going on here," Glimmer rolls her eyes, "I've always known you guys had a thing for each other. I do not care. I just didn't think either one of you would have the guts to act on it!"

She's never spoken a word of how she may or may not feel about Catra to anyone, so that's a bold assumption of her to make.

"Oh, Jesus Christ," Catra rolls her eyes, then leans over to plant her lips against Adora's cheek for a hot second before they're gone again. "Will you hop off it now? Can we all just act like we're actually happy to be around each other for once?"

This time Glimmer aims her accusatory glare at Catra, but at least she shuts up for the time being.

Adora's busy squirming in her seat. All Catra did was kiss her fucking cheek and suddenly she's fourteen again, staring at her best friend's lips while she talks, imagining what it would be like to taste them, wondering how weird it is to think that way about your girl best friend, tucking it away for the *Am I Gay?* quiz she'll go searching online for later that night when she's alone.

Except right now she's a grown woman who's feeling gay as fuck, which would be fine except it's the *for my best friend slash fake fiancé* part that's a problem.

And the fact that Glimmer just insinuated she knew about her crush all these years, in front of Catra.

"Aww, you still blush from just a little peck on the cheek?" Bow's eyes go all wide and soft as she gushes over the two of them, having not the faintest idea of the layers of complication blanketed over the table at the moment, "That is so cute! I love love!"

Glimmer fondly rolls her eyes like he does this all the time.

The night carries on a lot smoother once that's out of the way. They show off their rings, talk about wedding plans, skillfully avoid any discussion of work or future career plans, the three of them begin to reminisce on some of their happier times, and Bow finds his own ways to relate and include himself in the conversations as well.

He’s funny and smart, sensitive and kind but with an impeccable sense of self. Which seems like exactly what Glimmer needs to combat her own wild tendencies, but then he has a bunch of stories that make it sound like he’s the right amount of adventurous to compliment her, too. He was managing a T-Mobile before they moved home, so he’s also really tech savvy in a way that it seems like a legitimate interest for him, not just a way to pay the bills.

It makes it incredibly hard not to question whether she and Catra are still doing the right thing with their little marriage plot. Maybe Bright Moon wouldn’t be in such bad hands with someone like him in charge.

Maybe that was Glimmer’s motive all along.

Once their plates are cleared, she and Bow volunteer to clean up. They get all the leftovers put into containers in the fridge, then quickly fall into a system of Adora washing dishes while he dries and puts them away. They can hear Catra and Glimmer’s faded chattering and laughter from the living room. It starts to feel like maybe they’re headed in the right direction towards reconciliation.

“Please don’t take this the wrong way , but I gotta say, I really didn’t expect you to be so cool,” Bow says as he stacks something in the cupboard.

“Huh,” Adora hums, “I could say the same about you.”

“Has Glimmer been shit talking us to each other?” He chuckles.

“She’ s had nothing but good things to say about you,” Adora says, “But that makes me wonder what she’ s said about me?”

“Um, nothing too bad. Just that you’re a little bit obsessive in terms of work ethic.” he tries to frame it as inof fensively as possible, “So I assumed you’d be some uptight workaholic, I guess.”

It's not entirely untrue, but she can tell he's being delicate for the sake of politeness.

"Well," Adora chuckles, "I guess I can't blame you. I did make some of my own assumptions, too."

"Such as?"

"I just couldn't be sure whether you had ulterior motives or not until I actually met you."

"Ah," he says, "Your parent's will."

Adora's hands pause their soapy circling for a moment as she looks over at him questionably. It's the first time the subject has been broached all night. She braces herself for the worst.

"She told me why you guys were fighting," he explains, "And honestly, I had no idea when I proposed. I'm just in love with her, ya know? I hope you can see that now."

She holds his gaze for a brief second longer before responding, "I can."

Doesn't mean it's yours for the taking.

She can't tell if that thought is more of a warning for him or a reminder for herself.

"She's also told me...well," he clears his throat, "I mean, I know how she can be sometimes, believe me. But she's convinced that your engagement is a ruse so you two can keep the company in your name."

Her heart leaps into her chest and freezes there.

Bow doesn't miss a beat as he goes on, "I told her you'd both have to be nuts to commit to something like that, let alone a whole marriage, but she won't let it go."

It's clear in his tone that he has no idea the insider information he's delving out right now. He's simply the earnest fiancé, trying to make sense of the intangible dynamic between his love and her estranged sister. Maybe extending an olive branch to help mend the rift between them.

Adora laughs, hoping it doesn't sound as nervous as she feels. "I got the sense that's where her mind was at when we announced it, too."

Her mouth tastes like metal as she dances around the secret.

"Anyway , I just want to make it clear that family is super important to me," Bow assures her as he twists a glass to dry with the cloth in his hands, "In no way do I support or encourage that idea and I want to apologize on our behalf. You and Catra seem really happy and we'd be honored to stay here and work under you. I for one am excited to get to know you both better."

It doesn't sound like he has any idea of how persistent Glimmer's been about being put in charge. Is she keeping secrets from him? If Adora were to tell him, would he chew her out for it? W ould he make her back off?

Maybe he's just too nice. Or maybe he doesn't want to ruf fle any feathers. Maybe he and Glimmer are both in on this and it's just a huge hoax to get Adora to let her guard down and expose the truth so they can win after all.

She smiles. Regardless of the complications between them, it's completely genuine when she says, "Thank you for saying that. I'm glad the feeling is mutual."

He seems like an honest enough person. And either way, it might be beneficial to keep him in the mindset that what Catra and Adora are doing is too far-fetched to be real.

Oh God, how manipulative does that sound?

She’s going to need a lot of therapy if they end up pulling this off after all.

C

Emily is usually perfectly prompt in scheduling their client meetings at familiar restaurants and clubs they frequent, so what the hell was going through her mind when she booked a goddamn karaoke night for the Seamista contract negotiation?

Granted, it is a private room with a personal attendant and a sunset view of the city below, but it’s so unlike any business meeting they’ve ever had before.

“Are the accommodations to your liking?” Sea Hawk asks after the formal introductions are out of the way, “Your secretary suggested some boring old restaurant downtown, but I sold her on this place with my dazzling good looks and impeccably groomed facial hair.”

Mermista rolls her eyes. “You didn’t even speak to her personally.”

“I’m sure she’s seen my face before, darling. Knowing the request came from my own lips was clearly enough,” he replies.

“Okay, darling, whatever you say,” she agrees with an edge of sarcasm.

Catra likes her already. She’s not really a fan of their music, although they do have a couple singles she wouldn’t turn the station to avoid. Mermista in particular has such a cool air about her that it’s nearly impossible not to hang on her every word.

Her husband on the other hand, seems like he’ll take some getting used to. His entire personality seems to exist solely in hyperbole.

"Are you guys seeing the stache, though?" Bow gushes, "It *is* impeccably groomed."

Oh yeah, and the other half of Bright Moon's current ownership somehow managed to weasel their way into this backwards-ass meeting as well. The two of them were already waiting inside by the time Catra and Adora arrived, so the passive aggressive energy is sure to explode later on. For now, it's all side glances and thinly veiled remarks in an attempt to keep things calm on a surface level. They can't exactly risk causing a scene and losing the deal with the biggest musical act they've almost managed to snag for their single biggest project of the upcoming year.

"Thank you, kind sir!" Sea Hawk beams, "A man with taste!"

The two of them are the first to step up to the mic. They put on a rather eccentric performance, playing off each other as if they've been friends for ages. Then they prompt the rest of the group to join them, but everyone has their excuses. Catra wouldn't even consider doing karaoke on her worst day, Adora insists this is still a business meeting which should be kept as such, Mermista claims that she only performs during billable hours, and Glimmer says she's nowhere near drunk enough for it yet.

"Round of shots for the ladies, then!" Sea Hawk shouts as he waves their waitress over.

That happens a couple more times before Adora finally leans over to Catra after slamming her empty glass on the table.

"This is *so* unprofessional," she says, followed quickly by, "What should I sing?"

"I don't know," Catra grins, completely endeared by the flush of Adora's cheeks as her buzz sets in, "You love Miley Cyrus for some reason."

"She is a childhood icon," Adora sticks a defensive finger in her face, pouting her bottom lip slightly out in all seriousness. Her eyes are glossy and the club lights bounce off the gems of her ring. She smells like liquor and her favorite pear shampoo. Catra needs another shot or seven.

"Can't go wrong with ABBA," Glimmer counter-suggests.

"Could I really do Dancing Queen the justice it deserves, though?" Adora ponders out loud.

"Absolutely , babe," the pet name slips out far easier than she expected. She did intend to sprinkle some affection throughout the night, but the precise placing of how and when hadn't been determined yet. The fact that it feels so natural to call her that all of a sudden is what leads Catra to take another gulp.

Adora doesn't even seem to notice. She just nods, brows tightened together in their focus, and then she hops up and says, "You're right! I *am* young and sweet, only seventeen!" before dashing towards the duet to snatch the mic for herself.

She does it justice.

Catra doesn't really care about everyone getting along as much as Adora does, but it's always nice to see her unwind a bit. Not to mention with the added stress that Glimmer's return has brought into her life, she deserves a night to have some fun. She's wiggling and dancing and smiling, swinging her arms and pointing as she turns to sing a few lines directly at Catra, truly having the time of her life as she belts right along with the boys.

A

"Y a know, I'm not really into the whole soulmates thing, but you two are cute," Mermista shares her observation after the performance, sipping her drink and waving a finger between Catra and Adora.

"Uh, thanks," Adora half chuckles. "Aren't you and Sea Hawk married?"

"I guess so," she shrugs, "But you guys are like, the best of friends. What we have is nothing like that."

"It's far better, dear!" Sea Hawk insists, "I've never wanted to be just your friend."

Mermista rolls her eyes, but she's smiling.

"Catra and Adora go way back," an hour and a half into the night, Glimmer has a slight slur in her voice. "Practically sisters."

"Hon, you have got to stop putting it that way," Bow places a gentle hand on her knee.

"What? I'm just saying," she shrugs, taking another sip, "We did grow up together."

Adora knows she's only saying it to get under her skin, but thank God no one else is taking the bait.

"Lots of friends grow up together," Adora says through gritted teeth. Professionalism went out the door after the musical number with her sister's fiancé and half of their celebrity client. They're all basically the best of friends now.

"Just imagine someone calling us siblings," Bow piggybacks off her, bless him.

"That's so different," Glimmer waves him off.

"It's not. They're engaged, Glimmer. Would you marry Adora?" He counters.

"Don't be disgusting," Glimmer scoffs.

"You know, now that he mentions it, I can kinda see the resemblance," Catra quips, tapping one of her pointy black nails on the side of her glass as she studies the two of them. "Not a full blood relative, but like, same dad or something."

Adora laughs, interrupting it with her own snort. Catra is so fun.

"Well, this is taking an unexpected turn," Mermista's brows rise in intrigue as she looks back and forth between the two of them, waiting for the next jab.

"I know what you're doing, Scummy," Glimmer squints.

"Not weaponizing childhood nicknames, at least," she hums, happy to return the purposeful button pushing she excels at, "Didn't do as much growing up as you thought on that little extended vacation of yours, huh?"

This woman is her fiancé

This woman with the sexy voice and the sultry eyes and the vicious comebacks in defense of all the two of them have accomplished together.

It's not a real engagement, but still, holy shit. Adora is glowing with pride.

"Ooh, is that why they call you Catra?" Sea Hawk laughs, "Get her angry and the claws come out?"

"Okay, whatever this beef between you all is, I want more of it," Mermista says, "We'll sign whatever contract you have ready."

She almost forgot that's what this night was supposed to be about in the first place.

"Wait, really? You're in?" Catra double takes.

"Yeah, I mean, we were on board before tonight anyway. This virtual concert idea sounds like it's gonna be the next big thing," she nods. "Sea Hawk just likes to make friends with practically everybody we work with before accepting a deal, but I'm choosing to override his opinion because I love the drama you all are bringing to the table."

"I think you guys are quite the riot, too," Sea Hawk agrees, "Maybe Adora and I can even explore the idea of a future collaboration?"

"Adora? A pop star?" Catra jokes. "You haven't heard her sing in the shower."

"More like yell in the shower," Glimmer agrees, and the two of them share a look of amusement that squashes the squabble between them for now. Adora still kind of wants to fight her, but that's definitely the alcohol exacerbating the whole world around her right now.

"Hey! The professional thinks I've got potential!" She huffs.

"Oh no, we would definitely have to use an obscene amount of auto-tune," Sea Hawk agrees, "But singing isn't all about vocals, you know. It's about the performance, too! And Adora has the it factor."

"That, I can agree with. She's a star," Catra nudges her arm, catching her gaze and then melting into a smile.

She reaches up to push a stray lock of hair behind Adora's ear, the whisper of her fingertips searing a trail into Adora's skin. Then she just lingers there like she knows exactly what she's doing.

It's stupid. This is just Catra. Why is she all of a sudden losing her wits while her best fucking friend simply looks at her?

She's had one too many sips or shots or whatever.

The glinting gold and blue irises, the freckles scattered on her cheeks, the unfairly kissable lips, and the flimsy button down with the

top three left undone certainly don't help. Has her skin always been so bronze and smooth? Has she always smelled like sunshine and crisp autumn air?

Jesus Christ.

"Hey! Lovebirds!" Her sister's shrill call snaps her out of it. "We closing this deal or what?"

We. Ugh.

"Sorry," Catra finally says, tearing them apart to emerge back into the meeting at hand. "We'll have Emily send the documents first thing in the morning, and then—

Adora sucks down another long gulp.

She's officially incapacitated for the night. Catra can handle it from here anyway.

Chapter End Notes

I promise I actually love Glimmer. Just stay tuned for more development hahaha

Also love you all for coming back for more! x

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

A coup attempt. Adorabow date. Fancy party. Practice time.

Enjoy :)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A

The days pass quietly in a standard blur of meetings and calls, approvals and denials and constructive criticisms for this team and that one. Some tech magazine keeps bugging Emily for a good day to schedule a spread photoshoot and interview to promote the release of their new project, and it probably would be a smart idea to participate, but between the work that never seems to stop and the near-paralyzing stress of the hostile sister back in town, there doesn't seem to be a good day for it.

How would she even handle something like that? Now that the engagement has been public for a couple weeks, should she keep referring to Catra as her "partner" and just leave the implications of that up for interpretation, or would it be wise to slip in a "fiancé" somewhere next time the press inevitably gets ahold of her? Should she and Catra start showing up to events as a couple or just act as usual and pretend to be one of those private couples who doesn't show affection in public? And how many times are questions like this going to crop up over the next couple of years? Are they just supposed to turn on the act every time someone else besides the two of them is around?

Adora is snapped out of her buzzing head as she strolls into the office and Glimmer is standing over a third desk that's been newly set up between her and Catra's.

Her skin begins to prickle with rage.

Kyle, one of their top IT agents, is sitting behind the monitor, chatting excitedly about the mechanics of bringing Seamista's image to life in hologram form. Glimmer is nodding along and acting engaged like she actually understands a single word of all the technical jargon, but she looks up and her expression hardens as soon as she catches sight of Adora. Her choice of office wear;silk blouse, fuchsia slacks, white boots, and a touch of makeup indicate that she intends to stick around.

Rogelio, one of their lawyers, nods a greeting from behind her.

"Oh, good morning, Adora!" Kyle smiles. "I was just catching Ms. Glimmer up on our latest project while we wait for her laptop setup to finalize."

What?

Adora simply locks eyes with her sister, contemplating how to respond in a way that doesn't paint her out to be a totally unwarranted bitch.

"I know how busy you are around here, so I took matters into my own hands," Glimmer explains, serving a heaping pile of passive aggression along with her smile. "If you have any questions, I'm sure Rogelio would be happy to give you the rundown."

So she brought him along for legal protection, because she knew it was the only way Adora wouldn't be able to argue.

This is low. Dirty. Infuriating.

She thought this was meant to be kept between the two of them. And Catra. Isn't that why Glimmer didn't tell Bow that she wasn't satisfied with working for Bright Moon instead of running it? Adora didn't realize how far she was willing to take it for just a few measly weeks of power before she and Catra tie the knot and win this battle anyway.

Maybe this is meant to double as a clear communication that she's counting on them not to make it down the aisle.

She underestimated Adora's determination, though. Legalities be damned.

"Thank you, Kyle, excellent work as always," she chooses her words carefully, not daring to risk her own reputation for when things inevitably go back to normal. She simply heads to her own desk to have a seat and start combing through her email. Just a regular day.

"Ugh, you would not believe the line this morning," Catra complains her way in a few moments later with a coffee in each hand, freezing in the middle of the room when she sees how crowded the office is today.

"Oh," she pauses, looking back and forth between Glimmer and Adora. Her gaze lingers for a moment of silent communication, and then she follows Adora's lead in staying civil for their audience. She jokes, "I guess if I'd have known you all were coming I'd have gotten a tray."

"It's a surprise to everyone," Adora says, throwing Glimmer's snark right back at her.

"Okay, so, uh...correct me if I'm wrong, but it seems like neither of you knew she was going to be here today?" Kyle asks, swiveling in his chair to lower his voice in an attempt to whisper at Glimmer and Rogelio next, "You told me this was approved."

"I never said it was approved by them," Glimmer says.

"Ms. Bright is an equal owner and CEO of Bright Moon, until the date of September second, 2021, when the other Ms. Bright and Ms. Weaver are to be legally wed. Upon which event, full company ownership will then transfer to the happy couple," Rogelio explains, clearing his throat afterwards. "Congratulations, by the way ."

Adora has always liked him. He's prevented them from landing in some sticky situations before, and he even pre-emptively warned her that his hands would be tied if Glimmer decided to pursue legal action against them, but she never expected to actually see him stuck in the middle of this mess. Why does he have to be so damn good at what he does?

"Thanks," Catra laughs, but it' s thick with the sense of irony.

"Okay , well, now I'm uncomfortable," He says, nervously turning back to Catra and Adora, "I am so sorry you guys, I had no idea. Entrapta's not in yet so I couldn't ask her, but Rogelio had very specific directions, so I just assumed—W ow. I fucked up."

"No, no, He. Y ou're fine. You did exactly what you should have," Adora assures him. She'd never expect a manager from any department to reach out to one of the CEOs for confirmation on anything. Chain of command says it would be the CTO's responsibility, but even if she had been here, she wouldn't dare question a company lawyer . A fact that Glimmer counted on.

This is going to be the death of their sisterhood.

"Right, okay , well," He clears his throat, "This just has to finish uploading, then you should be able to log in with the credentials we created earlier. If you have any questions, just give me a call with the phone on your desk there."

He pushes his chair back from the new desk to stand up and dismiss himself with a quick goodbye to Catra and Adora as he ducks past.

"I think my work here is done as well," Rogelio says, looking at Glimmer for confirmation, then back at the real bosses. "Same thing Adora, Catra, Ms. Bright, if you have any questions, you know where to reach me."

"Thank you, Rogelio," Adora and Glimmer both say at the same time.

"You can call me Glimmer, by the way," she offers.

"Oh, for fuck's sake," Catra rolls her eyes dramatically.

"Oh. Um, sure, Ms. Glimmer." He sounds about as uncomfortable as everyone else, nodding once in acknowledgement as he waves on his way out the door.

Adora waits in the silent room until he's out of sight, then even longer for the ding of the elevator down the hall, and a handful of seconds more to make sure he's at least a few floors away before she allows herself to react.

"Alright, enough," slides her chair out to turn directly to her sister when she says, "Get out of my office."

"Our office," Glimmer is pushing it completely over the line today. "I have just as much right to be here as either of you."

"Don't insult us," Catra scoffs.

"*Our* office," Adora motions between her and Catra. That fuzzy, rage-colored vision thing is happening again. It's amazing how quickly Glimmer is able to inspire that in her all of a sudden. "Name one single thing you've done that gives you the right to be here."

"It doesn't matter what I've done, it matters what I plan to do," Glimmer maintains.

"What exactly do you plan to do, then?" Catra confronts her.

"—She stutters, pausing to assess the room. "I knew you'd be upset, but hear me out. I just thought this was the best way to help you guys see how serious I am about trying to learn the business."

"Really? *You* thought you could force your way into the office and we'd just hand over the materials to help you get settled?" Catra asks, a challenge in her tone. Adora sits back and lets her speak for the two of them, because she's saying exactly the right things with exactly the brazen delivery that she herself lacks. "You didn't actually manage to convince yourself we'd support this, did you?"

"No! I didn't think it would be that easy," Glimmer starts to sound panicked. "I can't just sit around and do nothing, but you won't let me in! I'm desperate!"

"Why won't we let you in, Glimmer?" Adora prompts, calmly in contrast to the flaring demons within her.

Maybe she's that dense, that spoiled, that entitled. Maybe she just doesn't care.

She looks frantic between her and Catra, then finally settles on Adora.

"Because you're still angry at me for leaving," she guesses.

"Oh no, I'm not angry at you for leaving. I'm angry at you for trying to slip back in like nothing happened," Adora snaps. "For thinking that you can just sit back and let Catra and I take care of business for years, and then deciding it's all yours just because you're bored with your new life all of a sudden. I'm angry at you for thinking that you deserve to take Bright Moon of f my hands' just because of some stupid thing that mom and dad decided back when we actually felt like a family."

Glimmer just purses her lips as it all comes erupting out.

"Maybe if you'd at least called me while you were gone, if we stayed in contact, if you came to visit, if you'd given me some kind of opportunity to even know who the fuck you are anymore, maybe I wouldn't be so mad! If you'd discussed this with me, if you'd asked how I felt about any of it, maybe we could've reached some kind of compromise!" Adora can hear how hysterical she sounds, but she can't keep stuffing it down anymore, "Because the thing is, I wasn't mad when you came back to town. I was happy to see you again! And then you told me you were getting married, and I was excited for you! The only thing I'm fucking pissed about is how you seem to think the whole world revolves around you all of a sudden!"

"I don't think the world revolves around me, Adora!" Glimmer shouts back, then recoils immediately after. She takes a breath and speaks more level when she explains, "I'm just trying to do what mom and dad wanted. I know it doesn't make sense to you and I'm sorry. I'm sorry it's hurting you so much. I just want to make them proud, and this is what they wanted, so I have to. I can't keep disappointing them. I have to at least try and do something to make them proud."

"You think they'd be proud of you for this?" Catra snarls, curling her top lip in disgust.

"I think it would make them proud to see me follow in their footsteps like you two have," she says.

"Didn't really think it through though, did you, princess?" Catra counters. "Even if this little stunt you tried to pull ended up working, you'd only have a few months to make them proud before Adora and I are in charge again."

"Oh, please. You guys aren't even a real couple," she finally says what they all knew she was thinking anyway. "You think mom and dad would be proud of you for *this*? Faking a whole relationship just so you can steal a company that you're mad isn't even technically yours?"

Adora bites her tongue once more, a show of self respect more than any shred of it she might have left for Glimmer.

"Catra and I are committed to spending the rest of our lives together," she finally says. It's not technically a lie, right? And we take that commitment seriously, unlike some people who choose to run when things get hard."

"I am not going to keep trying to justify myself to someone who's committed to misunderstanding me," Glimmer says, holding her gaze as a single tear escapes down her cheek and gives her away.

"Good. Then I'll say again, get out of my office and stop trying to take the company away from me. Because I swear to God if you succeed, you and I will never be able to come back from it," Adora turns back to her computer monitors now, dismissing her as usual, because she is the boss, whether Glimmer likes it or not. Her partial ownership is just an inconsequential detail that'll soon fade away after the *I do*'s are said. And they *will* be said.

She spares her one good hardened stare as a parting gift. Maybe Glimmer just doesn't understand how serious this actually is for her. Maybe she simply doesn't care. Adora holds her breath waiting to find out either way.

"Ugh!" Glimmer groans, stomping her foot down once in her frustration.

Catra snorts, and both of the sisters turn to look at her, horrified at the inappropriate reaction in the middle of such a thick moment.

"What? It's funny. She's like a child," Catra laughs again.

"I am not!" Glimmer stiffens her arms by her sides and puffs out her chest like that'll help her case at all.

Adora cracks a tiny smile, too.

"This is exactly why," Glimmer huffs, "You never take me seriously!"

"You know that's not true," Adora says.

"It's just ridiculous that we even have to keep having this conversation! Imagine if we stormed into your gallery one day with an armful of crayon scribbles, started hanging them up all over the real works of art, and then threw a tantrum when someone started taking them down," Catra paints a picture. "That's what you look like right now."

She can't even argue. Her face softens a little, like she might not be ready to laugh, but at least it's starting to make some semblance of sense to her.

"Give it up, Sparkles," Catra keeps talking her down, "Stick to what you're good at. Don't worry about what Adora and I are up to."

She pushes one more determined breath from her nose before storming out of the room.

C

They could both use some time to unwind after work, so it's popcorn and pajamas on Adora's couch while they watch bad scary movies in front of the digital fireplace that night. She had her feet in Catra's lap as she stretched out across the length of it, but she removes them to sit criss-cross instead when her phone pings with an apparently important notification.

"Bow just texted me," she says, reading from the screen. "He wants to know if we're free to go shopping with him this weekend."

She looks up with an inquisitive brow quirked. Her hair is a bird's nest from the pillows she was was just resting on, and it's far more

endearing than Catra will ever admit out loud.

"What?" She chuckles, "Glimmer 's fiance?"

"How many people named Bow do we know?"

"Just one, but what the fuck?"

"Right?" Adora agrees. "What do I say to that?"

"Uh, absolutely not." Catra suggests. "You won't catch me fraternizing with the enemy."

"Fraternizing with the enemy?" Adora snorts. "What are we, sixty year old war criminals?"

"Someday , maybe," she shrugs. "Don't tempt me."

"I think he's kinda cool, though," Adora mulls it over . "He told me he doesn't even support Glimmer's idea that we're faking this whole thing, and that he's fine with working under us. I don't think he'd be reaching out unless he meant it."

"Those sound exactly like things a double agent would say ," Catra maintains.

"He probably heard what happened and wants to apologize again," Adora insists. "He said he's big on family and sounded like he really wanted to get to know us."

They had one conversation in the kitchen of her parent's house, like a week and a half ago. Why is she suddenly defending him so hard?

"You can't seriously be considering this," Catra sits up straight now , too.

Adora purses her lips for a moment, but ultimately decides to admit it. "I guess I'm still hoping that this mess won't come between Glimmer and I forever. Maybe with some time, now that she seems

to have accepted that Bright Moon CEO is not going to happen for her, we can try again. So yeah, I want to befriend her future husband."

"Adora, no of fense, but you can be really gullible sometimes. Isn't there even a tiny part of your brain that thinks this could be a ploy to get one over on us?" Catra says. "I mean, first Glimmer tries to stage a hostile takeover, and now Bow wants to hang out with us all of a sudden? It' s suspicious."

"Or maybe it' s just a friendly gesture," Adora shrugs.

"Okay , but all it takes is one slip-up for you to admit this isn't real and blow our whole act," Catra counters. "Which is obviously more easily done if your guard is down on account of genuine friendship."

"I'm not gonna slip up. This is barely even an act," Adora lingers on that for a moment, Catra just blinking back at her in pause until she clarifies. "Like. W e're really best friends, we're really partners, so sprinkling the word fiancé in here and there isn't as big of a deal as you're making it seem."

"It' s a whole production," Catra argues, "I bet he naturally mentions the love of his life like 500 times a day. How often do you talk about me?"

"It consistently baf fles me how you seem to think you're just some random bystander in my life, when in reality it practically revolves around you," Adora rolls her eyes. "I'm marrying you, for Christ' s sake! Because I figured, what the hell, we already spend basically every waking moment of our time together, and I already talk about you all the time, so it's really not that far-fetched to believe we've secretly been dating. And people are buying it, Catra. Saying we're cute together, even! I swear the only reason Glimmer has a bug up her ass about it is because of the timing."

Catra is floored into silence. She really does tend to think of herself as just a little moon that orbits around Planet Adora, instead of the

other way around. Or even them being equal planets in each other's solar systems. It's fucking bizarre and completely incomprehensible that Adora could ever see herself as the moon to anyone's planet, let alone Catra's.

"Okay, jeez, I get it, you're in love with me," she mumbles the joke under her breath.

That earns her a playful kick in the leg, which leads her to catch Adora by the ankle.

"Sure you want to do that?" She hums, raising Adora's bare foot and lightly dragging the point of her nails down from the top of the sole to the bottom.

"No, no, okay, stop!" Adora laughs, kicking her foot and trying to wiggle free, "You win! I surrender!"

"Too easy," Catra grins as she releases her after the victory.

"You play dirty," Adora accuses. Catra just waggles her brows suggestively, earning her a roll of the eyes that rule her entire galaxy.

"I still can't in sound mind participate in this little hangout," she says, getting back to the subject at hand. "But I guess I trust you to be careful."

"Sounds like you think I'm on my way to upstaging you in the acting department," Adora says.

"Not even in your dreams," Catra scoffs.

A

"Hey!" Bow greets her with nothing but warmth as he waits outside her building that weekend. It's a hot summer afternoon, so he's in a pair of long shorts and a white crop top with an anatomical heart where his actual heart should be.

"Hi! Good to see you again," she spreads her arms for a hug that he eagerly accepts.

"You too. I'm really glad you came," he says.

"You kidding? I'm honored you invited me," she says when they pull apart.

"Well, I intended for it to be a double date, but..." he trails off, leaving the rest up for interpretation.

"Let me guess, Glimmer said something about fraternizing with the enemy?"

Bow chuckles. "You know her so well."

"She and Catra are more alike than either of them would admit without a gun to their heads," Adora laughs.

"Maybe someday I'll see for myself," Bow chuckles along with her as they fall into step down the sidewalk.

"How is she doing?" Adora wonders. They haven't spoken since the office, so Adora can only assume she's not taking the realization of her own absurdity very well.

"She's, um..." Bow hesitates, "Upset, but okay. You and Bright Moon is about all she's talked about for the past few months, so I guess she's just struggling to find some new direction."

Adora absorbs that. She doesn't feel bad exactly; her and Catra did what they had to, to protect something they care about. But she also never wanted to be a source of upset in her sister's life, either. She wishes she could reach out, but suspects she's probably the last

person Glimmer wants to hear from right now. And as friendly as her and Bow are trying to be, he's probably not ready to hear all of Adora's most intimate thoughts on his fiancé trying to steal her job away.

"Will you let her know she's welcome back whenever she's ready?" Adora sighs. "I never said she can't work with us. Just not, you know, head of the company."

"Believe me, I've tried," Bow sighs, too. "I think she just needs time to adjust her expectations."

They walk in silence for a few more beats before Adora has to think of something to say or else she'll explode from the awkwardness of it all.

"So, is this just a for fun shopping trip or did you need something in particular?"

"A suit for your wedding!" Bow perks up, "But I know nothing about suits. And since you and Catra always look so nice and professional, I figured you two would be the best sources to consult."

"Oh, super professional," she jokes, looking down at herself for dramatic effect. She's in a knee-length sundress split vertically down the middle, half red and half white. She didn't even bother styling her hair today, just put some big shades on her forehead and pushed them up to use as a headband. And the shoes are just her boring brown ankle boots.

"Well, no one expects you to keep it that way outside the office," Bow rolls his eyes. "But you still look nice, anyway."

"Thank you," she chuckles, "I can't take any of the credit, though. I pay someone to redesign my entire wardrobe every now and then."

"So all that isn't even your doing? Crap, I fucked up," he jokes.

"On the contrary , you did exactly the right thing by calling me," Adora grins.

She figures that on the off chance that this is some kind of scheme to get her to open up about her and Catra's relationship, the best way to combat that is to get Bow to really like her. And the failsafe way to do that is to share the wealth.

Half an hour later, they're being escorted by car to one of the finest wedding boutiques in the city .

"Phew ," Bow hums as he strokes the pristine white cashmere couch in the viewing room. "I feel like a criminal even looking at a glass of champagne on this thing."

Adora laughs, taking a sip from her own flute of bubbly.

"I guarantee a little spill wouldn't even be the dirtiest thing to happen in this room."

"And just like that, I'm less impressed," he makes a face that inspires them both to laugh it off. "A little uncomfortable, if I'm being honest? I can't afford any of this."

"Don't worry about it," she waves him off. "The attendant will be back in a minute with a whole rack of clothes for you to look at. If you don't see anything you like, we'll ask for more options."

"I can't, it's too much," he shakes his head before fully chugging the remainder of his nearly full glass. "I'll just browse with you."

"Yes you can. In fact, I demand that you do," she assures him. "Think of it as necessary wedding costs. I need a dress, too. Or maybe a fancy suit of my own; I haven't decided yet. Anyway , I'm not letting you leave until you find something."

"You just live like this?" He asks, eyes widened in awe. "Every day?"

"I indulge sometimes," she shrugs. Usually only once she's worn her clothes till they fall apart, but still. She remembers how much of an adjustment it was at first, when she realized she didn't have to check the price on things anymore, and then how she slowly allowed herself to open up to the idea of a little treat every now and then.

"Okay, I'm trusting you," he says, still cautious. "Don't make me regret it."

I could say the exact same thing to you, she thinks as the attendant pulls two racks of formal wear into the room.

Another bottle of champagne later, the idea to request the most flashy outfits they can find sneaks its way into their heads, and the two of them commence into endless hysterics.

Adora marches out of the dressing room holding the gigantic skirt of her dress up to reveal her ankles and prevent any dragging.

"I've decided to attend my wedding as the cake itself," she announces, dropping the thick layers of silk and netted fabric to the ground again.

She and Bow both burst out laughing. The dress poofs out and over her legs like a Victorian royal, cinches her waist like a burlesque dancer, and wraps lace around her arms like a vintage wedding Barbie.

"No eating at the reception. Save that for the honeymoon," Bow makes a dirty joke that she catches right onto.

"Tell Glimmer the same! You look like a fruit cup," she counters.

He went with a crazy color-blocked tux in an array of red, blue, and yellow. One of his pant legs is red, the other one half blue and yellow. The suit jacket is an abstract mix of patches where the three colors never touch each other.

"I do, don't I?" He hums, turning to get a full view of himself in the mirrored wall. "Banana, strawberry , blueberry," he points to each swatch of color as he names them, then gasps dramatically before sharing his epiphany, "Y ou should have fruit cups as a dessert option!"

"Honestly , I don't hate the idea," she admits, sending them into another fit of giggles. It's mostly champagne induced, but also, Bow is fun and she's actually enjoying herself.

"Honestly , don't hate the idea of me picking this suit either," he admits.

"It' s yours if you want it," she of fers. "In the spirit of honesty , everyone could show up wearing garbage bags for all I care. I'll still be married to my best friend either way."

She meant to say it, but she didn't mean for it to feel so true.

Why, though? Marrying Catra not only means she gets to keep her spot as CEO, but also that her life is legally tied to her favorite person on Earth forever. Not necessarily in a romantic way, just in a *happy to have such a solid bond with someone* kind of way.

Yeah. That makes sense.

Even after the inevitable divorce, they'll still be each other's ex-wives, a title with connotations that can never be downplayed. And that's what Adora's excited about. Being Catra's ex-wife, for some reason. Whatever.

"A www," Bow' s eyes do that soft admiration thing they did the other night when Catra kissed her cheek. "I know she hates me, but I love you both so much already."

Oof. Shot just like an arrow aimed right for her heart.

"She doesn't hate you," Adora says, "She just takes her time warming up to new people. Took her like, a full year to stop side-eying Glimmer every time she walked into the room, so really you've already got a head start."

"Seems like you guys have been inseparable since you met, though," he smiles, admiring.

"That's different. We're soulmates," she grins. She's just parroting the word Mermista used to describe them; it hasn't really left her mind since it was said. It does kind of feel like her and Catra were always meant to find each other, but soulmates can be platonic too.

"So cute!" Bow continues to gush. "I simply owe it to your love to offer more than this ridiculous crayon suit. Next round?"

"Sure," Adora chuckles.

"I also feel like I owe you another apology," he adds with a sigh, after the attendant leaves to prepare another two racks.

"For what?" She quirks her head to one side.

"Glimmer and I got in a fight before she went to set up in your office," he blurts, "I told her it was a horrible plan and begged her to consider the consequences, but she was hell-bent on going anyway. She was so mad that I refused to support her, I think it might have made her more determined to prove me wrong. And now she's even worse off, and you two aren't talking, and I just feel like it was partially my fault."

It is nice to have some perspective outside of Catra. Comforting to know that she can't actually be as crazy as she feels, if even someone who's supposed to have Glimmer's back thinks she's out of line.

It's also suspicious. How can she be sure he's not a double agent? It's not entirely impossible that this is all part of his and Glimmer's

counter plan to get what they want in the end. She and Catra very clearly have devised a plan of their own, and it seems to be working exactly as they want it to. Maybe it's too good to be true.

And maybe she's just letting Catra get into her head.

"There's one person who's largely at fault for this, and it isn't you," Adora says. "Although, I do appreciate that you seem to care so much about the state of our relationship."

"I know I mentioned how important family is to me, but I don't know if you really understand how much I meant it," he says. "My dads and I are really close, and I always wished I had siblings to share that with. It's kind of breaking my heart so see you guys fighting like this."

"Mine, too," Adora nods. She has to be careful with her words now, because although a part of her does mean it, there's another, bigger part that's still so defensive over the company it could flare up at a moment's notice. And she doesn't want that to derail whatever she has growing here between her and Bow.

"Besides actually needing a suit, it's really the whole reason I invited you out today. I wanted to make sure you know that you're still welcome in our lives, and that I'm trying to help her see how this is driving a wedge between you before it's too late."

"Thank you for saying that," Adora says, sinking further into the couch. "I can't really blame Glimmer entirely... my parents are the one who put the wedge there to begin with. I never thought I'd get another opportunity to be this mad at them again, but I just keep wondering what the hell they were thinking."

"It's common for deceased relatives to divide things unevenly between adult siblings based on the individual needs of each," he nods, "I have zero advice for how to deal with it, but I'm sure some kind of insightful tidbit can be found in there somewhere."

Adora snorts a laugh. "Maybe, but I'd rather have more champagne than dig for it right now."

"Now that, I can help with," he beams.

She really, really likes Bow.

*

"Good morning, dearest," Catra breezes into the of fice the next morning, much more sprightly than usual as she places Adora's coffee on her desk and glides across the room to her own.

Apparently they're calling each other pet names now, even when no one's around. Apparently her heart finds that pretty exciting.

"T ake it down like four octaves, please," she reqests, thoroughly hung over. Throbbing headache, nausea, fatigue, the works.

Her and Bow went to an early dinner after shopping, and then the rest is kind of a blur of cocktails and appetizers and waving goodbye as he climbed out of the car outside mom and dad's house, then the driver making sure Adora got to her apartment safe and sound. By sheer miracle, she managed to get herself out of bed this morning, though she's wearing jeans and it' s not even casual Friday.

"This is my normal speaking voice," Catra chuckles. "So I'm guessing you had fun with your new bestie then?"

Adora nods as she reaches for her drink to suck down a long gulp, cherishing the bitter chill as it spreads through her veins and settles in her chest.

"I wish you would've been there. He' s so cool, Catra."

"I bet he is," she hums, "You don't break down someone's defenses by being a bitch."

"I'll admit I was a little suspicious after talking to you yesterday, but it seems like he's genuinely on our side," she gushes, "He's just a sweet family man who doesn't want to see this tear us apart. He and Glimmer have even fought about the way she's acting."

"Mhm," Catra spreads her fingers to play with her ring as she asks, "And did he ask you anything about us while you two were pounding back the beers or whatever?"

She honestly can't remember if she said anything incriminating or not, but she can bet there would've been a few choice words bouncing around her brain if he did end up figuring the two of them out.

"I don't remember all the details," she shrugs, "I did say something about how marrying you is all I care about at the end of the day? And I managed to casually mention that you're my soulmate, so I think he bought it."

Catra coughs, interrupting the sip she was in the middle of and spilling a few droplets on the front of her blazer. It's black today, but she still reaches for a napkin and tilts her head down to wipe it off.

"Word for word? That's fucking romantic," she says.

"Oscar-worthy?" Adora waggles her brows with a grin.

Because it's just an act.

"I'll believe it when I see it," when Catra looks up again, her smirk is back. "I'm sure I don't have to remind you, but just in case, don't forget we have to leave the office at exactly 5pm if we're gonna be on time."

"On time for what?" Adora quirks her head.

"You, me, Double Trouble, and about 200 of their closest friends at their Crimson City mansion," she says.

"Ugh, Catra, I can't," Adora groans, "I'm still recovering."

"Because you hardly ever go out anymore!" Catra reminds her, "Your body just needs some time to readjust."

"Can't you just tell them I'm sick or something?" Adora begs, "Technically it's not even a lie. I feel like garbage. Who even parties on a Monday? And Crimson City is a whole two hour trip from here. I'll never make it."

"Puke on the plane for all I care. We have to go!" Catra counters.

"There's no way they'll notice if I'm not there," she insists.

"Oh, come on! You sound so washed up. Is this what our lives have been reduced to?" Catra scoffs.

"I'm fine with that," Adora says to her computer screen.

"Adora, need I remind you that Double Trouble is the billionaire investor who helped make this entire virtual reality project possible?" Catra asks, "This is already going to be a huge release for Bright Moon, but imagine the networking we can do at a filthy rich party like this!"

"You are perfectly capable of communicating the company's objectives to anybody who's interested," Adora reminds her.

"I know, I'm awesome," she says, "But I have no desire to attend this event without my partner in crime! Please?"

She knows how hard it is for Adora to resist her pouty face, so of course she pulls it out at all the exact right moments, such as this one. Her eyes go wide and sparkly, her bottom lip protrudes out and curls over, she holds for at least ten seconds before it's all Adora can take.

"Stop that," she says. Her head is pounding.

"Is it working?" Catra keeps her bottom lip stuck out.

"No," Adora lies.

"Pleeeeease," she draws it out this time. "I'm nothing without my soulmate!"

Adora refuses to entertain it any further, so Catra scoots her chair out and crosses the room, placing her palms flat on Adora's desk to lean into her bubble of personal space.

"You're so dramatic," Adora rolls her eyes.

"Sounds like a yes to me," Catra grins.

"You're taking care of me tomorrow when I'll be rendered a mindless, lifeless zombie from overexertion," is all she says to confirm.

"Yes! I knew I was marrying you for a reason," Catra grins. "Just please make sure you look hot. I can't be seen dragging around a lifeless zombie all night."

C

As if Adora could be anything but hot even if she tried.

With the exception of that one time she got food poisoning from eating a gas station sandwich on their cross country road trip after college. Catra will always remember the briefest moment where she reconsidered whether she was still attracted to her best friend or not, while watching her puke her guts out on the side of the road. And then Adora looked up at her from where she kneeled in the grass as Catra held her hair back, smiled and asked, "You'll never look at me

the same way after this, huh?" and Catra felt herself fall and hit the ground just as hard as before.

Maybe it's weird how often Catra falls in love with her, considering they're not actually together.

But when Adora hops in the backseat wearing a plunge neck black leotard under crisp white pants, topped off with a red pea coat, her classic red bottom heels, and somehow perfectly crafted beach waves in her hair, how could she not?

"Is this acceptable enough for you, ma'am?" She asks, turning in her seat to face Catra as if she hadn't already admired the entire outfit on her walk to the car.

"Ugh, don't call me ma'am," Catra avoids the admission that she looks good enough to eat. Literally, Catra could spread her legs and have a feast right there on the way to the airport.

"Sorry , babe? Honey? Sweetheart?" Adora tries. She leans over to nudge Catra in the side and waggle her brows when she says, "Soulmate?"

"Asshole," Catra quips.

"That' s not very romantic. I think it'll blow our cover," she laughs at her own lame joke.

"Y ou look phenomenal for someone who apparently feels like shit," Catra finally admits.

"Oh, I'm dying on the inside," she says. "But look at my competition!"

Catra's gone with a monochrome black look including a blazer over a lace bralette top, dress pants, and heeled booties. Her hair is slicked on the sides to create a faux mullet, she's got a pair of big gold hoops in her ears and even took the liberty of swiping on some

winged liner, mascara, and painted her lips a matte brown only a few shades darker than her skin.

She follows Adora's gaze as it drags from her head down to the cuffs of her pants, then comes back up to settle on her bare stomach. Or shoulders. Or something in between.

"Is staring at tits just free game now that we're engaged, then?" She calls her out. "I was trying to be polite."

"Why? Wouldn't be the first time I've caught you red handed," Adora shrugs as she tears her eyes away. "Or red-eyed in this case."

"You are such an idiot," Catra rolls her eyes to conceal the warmth radiating within her.

She is, though. What are they doing? Just joking about how attracted they are to each other all the time? Is it just that thing that women do, where they say these things without even realizing how serious one of them actually is about it? And then when that person tries to make a move, they just end up embarrassing themselves and ruining the friendship forever?

Catra will not be the one to do that.

An hour and a half later, they're making their way through the Crimson City airport terminal and into another private car. Then it's another twenty five minute drive to Double Trouble's mansion just outside the limits. They pass through the bouncer, security, and coat check, and then finally someone escorts them out to the back of the property where the party is in full swing.

Although they have made deals with them before, this will be the first time Catra or Adora has ever been to their home. Or the home of any billionaire businessperson, for that matter.

There's an infinity pool the size of a football field running down the majority length of the yard, a buffet table nearly as long down one

side, a fully stocked bar area under the building's left side attachment, a fire pit hangout on the right attachment, a live band playing smooth jazz on a stage off to the side of it all, and every single guest is equally dressed to impress.

Adora turns to Catra and sticks her elbow out. Her arms are bare now, and dammit if Catra isn't already salivating at the sight of them. As far as she knows, Adora does still work out at least twice a week around their busy schedule, and it shows.

She'll simply have to try her hardest not to think about being pushed against a wall or carried to bed or held down against a mattress by the defined muscles that have starred in some of the greatest fantasies of her life.

She loops her own arm through and they take the steps of the massive staircase slowly. It's awkward. Some of the people turn to watch their entrance out of reflex, so although they aren't the only ones there it feels like a spotlight analyzing their every move.

"Do we know anyone here besides the host?" Adora leans slightly in to ask under her breath.

"I don't know , probably. Guess we'll find out," Catra shrugs.

They make a beeline for the banquet table with a spread of classy food made of ingredients they can't even pronounce, but they do end up bumping into a few industry execs and super rich moguls of various types. People they only know by name, not faces. It's more of the same at the bar, but the strangest part is that their names are apparently recognizable now, too.

"Excuse me, but are you Catra Weaver?" Some guy asks while she's waiting in line for her drinks. He's tall and pale with striking green eyes, and the way his hair is slicked back gives the impression that he was some spoiled rich kid who made his name off daddy's money.

"Uh, yeah," she says, cautiously .

"Hector Hordak," he holds his hand out for a shake, "Good to meet you."

"Of Hordak T echnologies? I know you," She asks as she takes his hand. "Y ou're like, the pioneer of the modern tech industry."

"Ah, so you've heard of me," he chuckles. "W ell, you're making quite the name for yourself, too."

"Please," she scof fs, "Y ou're one of the reasons we've even made it this far. Your story about getting rejected like a hundred times before finding someone to fund your microchips is what inspired us to take it this far."

And now his company is the one who funds the groundbreaking products for small businesses. At some point before Bright Moon found its way, his team is one of those that she and Adora attempted to work with.

"I'm flattered that you're such a fan," he smiles, "I've been keeping a close eye on your work, too. Care to tell me more about how the virtual performance project is coming along?"

Catra happily gets lost in chatter as the line moves along. They get to talking about some of the lesser projects they both have going on, but it becomes glaringly obvious the deeper they get into it where she stands in hierarchy of the industry. His upcoming projects include things like opening a University and mining bitcoin, where Bright Moon's are introducing a new line of laptops and possibly exploring a gaming system in the coming years.

By the time they make it back to the table, she can tell Adora is restless.

He doesn't even seem to notice her at all, though.

"It sounds like you're one to watch out for , just as I've heard," he says.

"You have no idea what that means to hear from you," she says, scooting Adora's Shirley Temple across the table to her. Her hands move to accept it, but her eyes stay glued to Hordak the whole time.

"Well, I can't help but find myself intrigued by you." she can feel the distinct shift in energy as soon as his eyes settle into that hungry look. It sends a cold shiver down her spine.

"Thanks. My fiancé is, too," she nods towards Adora who' s literally sitting across the table, and yet it feels like he never would've noticed had Catra not pointed her out.

"Oh, you two are?" He looks back and forth between them now , no introduction necessary.

"Yeah, hi. Adora Bright, the other half of both Catra and the company," she introduces herself with a look in her eyes like Catra' s never seen before. Something just outside of a challenge, daring him to say the wrong thing. She doesn't offer her hand for a shake either.

Jealousy? Holy shit, is she actually jealous? Or has she just entered protection mode, sensing that his intentions are less than reputable and wanting to make sure he knows that Catra has a friend watching?

"Well, you're just as lovely , aren't you?" He asks, "I wasn't planning on a threesome, but I'm a pretty open guy in that sense."

"Not a chance in hell," she dismisses him deadpanned, the same way she does at work when something is past the span of her attention. She takes a sip of her drink and looks directly at Catra, eye contact with the invader intentionally severed.

So Catra isn't imagining it. Holy shit. She's right that he doesn't stand a chance, but still, Adora is jealous of someone' s interest in

her.

"Okay , so that's a no from you, then, I get it," he shrugs, turning back to Catra without a second of spared interest. "Ms. W eaver hasn't turned me down, though."

Adora pushes her chair back without hesitation, standing up and lunging towards him so fast anyone who didn't have reflexes as quick as Catra' s might not have even caught it in time to block her from doing something incredibly stupid and embarrassing, given the setting.

Hordak doesn't even flinch.

"What are you gonna do about it, blondie?" He asks, sipping on his own scotch without a care in the world.

"What exactly do you get out of this, huh? Besides a tarnished reputation," Catra scof fs. It's surprisingly less disappointing than she would've expected to find out that one of her biggest career inspirations is actually a grimy piece of shit. Most billionaires are. "W e're not gonna fuck you. Move along and find someone who will."

He looks them up both up and down once more, then before finally walking away he rolls his eyes and says, "Y ou're right. Not worth my time anyway."

"Y ou alright?" Catra checks with Adora. She doesn't think she would've actually hit the guy in a setting like this;she cares too much about professionalism. But then again, she'd usually have handled something like that with far more grace than she just displayed. A small part of Catra would've loved to see it.

"I cannot stand men like that," she practically spits.

"Y eah, clearly," Catra half-chuckles, "And you know I would've had your back, but let's try not to make a fool of ourselves at an event

like this. Just try to focus on business, okay? He's the one who's not worth our time."

"You're absolutely right," she nods, "Look at you, being the one to talk some sense into me for a change."

"Well, what the hell got into you?" Catra asks, "I've never seen you react like that before."

Please say she was jealous.

"We've never been engaged before," Adora finally sits back down, lowering her voice when she explains, "I know it's not real, but what kind of guy hits on someone in front of their fiancé?"

"That felt pretty real, Adora," Catra laughs to calm her own nerves. "Might've just earned yourself that Oscar."

"I heard someone's giving out Oscars over here," a smooth voice interrupts from above them.

When they look up, it's Double Trouble themself, with their olive skin and long platinum hair, wearing a checkerboard tuxedo like some kind of knockoff Beetlejuice cosplay.

"So good to see you two again," they smile, extending a hand for each of them to shake. Catra and Adora haven't seen them in years, since the one and only meeting when they managed to convince them their RR project was worth funding.

"Thanks for having us," Adora smiles, all business again like she wasn't just about to bash someone's face in mere moments ago.

"Oh no, thank you for gracing me with your presence," they smile back, "When I heard the news, I couldn't wait to congratulate you two in person."

Catra and Adora both share a look.

They glide their fingertips down the line of both Catra and Adora's arms in unison, caressing over their hands to hold them up and admire their rings closer.

"Y our engagement, dears," they clarify .

"Right! Of course," Adora chuckles.

"Thanks," Catra snatches her hand back in stark comparison to the way Adora slowly maneuvers hers away.

"Retract the claws, kitten," they chuckle, "W e're all friends here. Except maybe you and Hordak. Seemed like he might have been a bother?"

"Nothing we can't handle," Adora smiles.

"Good. Y ou let me know if anyone gives you trouble," they say . "I can't stick around long, many more guests to chat with, but I wanted to speak with you about a project I'm about to unveil. It' s a charity shelter for unhoused LGBT youth, and I want you two to be some of the many speakers at the grand opening gala next month."

"Seriously?" Catra raises her brows, intrigued.

"Y es, seriously," Double T rouble chuckles, "Y ou're a successful, high profile, openly lesbian couple. Sapphic? Please do correct me if I'm wrong, but either way, it would be great for people to hear a few uplifting words from someone who's been through it all and come out safely on the other side."

Besides the neglectful childhood, Catra's actually been pretty blessed to have such an unwavering support system to set her up so well in life. And Adora was the opposite, with her childhood being relatively easy until the whole dead parents and estranged sister thing. Together, they might be able to deliver something appropriately inspirational.

"T ake your time to consider it," they urge, "Y ou'll be receiving a formal invitation with more detail soon, you can RSV P then."

"Sounds like an amazing opportunity to help some lost kids like us find their way. We'd be honored," Adora decides with a gracious tilt of her glass.

"W onderful!" They clap their hands together once to dismiss themself. "Y ou ladies enjoy the rest of your evening, then! I'll be seeing you again soon!"

"Are we like, famous now or something?" Catra leans over to Adora when they're alone again, like it's some kind of juicy piece of gossip. It's so rare for people to recognize them when they go out, and when someone does it's usually because of an event they've scheduled for their own company. To know that so many of these people who started out as single-company owners like themselves actually know who they are is a buzz like no other.

"I guess so," she sips her drink. "So weird."

"Come on, let' s do some more mingling. I wanna see who else recognizes us."

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"I mean seriously , 'we're thinking of buying a summer home in the countryside for our own winery'? What was that?" Catra laughs out loud as they push open the door to their hotel room later that evening.

"I have no idea!" Adora chuckles with her , "Everyone was talking about their big worldly properties and early retirement plans or whatever. I wanted to sound like we fit in!"

"I'm so glad we don't," Catra says, "What a bunch of boring assholes. Sorry I dragged you into this."

"No, don't be," she says, "I'm glad we came. It's good for business, and after seeing the crowd I know you would've been miserable without me. Especially with that asshat Hordak trying to get in your pants."

"That was kinda hot, ya know. When you nearly knocked him out for me," Catra says. She's been drinking, so that's always an acceptable excuse to be a little bolder than usual. Besides, it's all just fun, friendly teasing anyway.

Unless Adora takes the bait.

"It was for all the women on earth who I'm sure had to put up with it before us," Adora maintains, playing along as she steps out of her heels and locks the door behind her, "And also because no one dares to look at my fiancé's cleavage like that while I'm around."

Except for you.

"Oh God, I just thought of something," Catra pauses, "If Bright Moon keeps doing this well, are we gonna become one of them?"

"Are you gonna start buying yachts and playing golf and only caring about your money once we hit a billion?"

"Do I look like someone who belongs on a golf field?"

"I think it's called a course."

"Exactly!"

They both burst into laughter.

"I do think it's nice what Double Trouble is doing, though," Adora says a moment later, "They don't seem so bad. Just a little bit of an eccentric personality."

"I imagine if there was something like that around when we were younger," Catra nods in agreement. She's gone to sit on her side of the bed while she removes her earrings and places them on the nightstand one by one. "I probably still would've preferred Micah and Angella's, but at least there would've been options."

"You really think you'd have stuck around if you had anywhere else to go?"

"Adora, I think I fell in love with you the moment I saw you approach my table with that cookie in your hand," she laughs it off, just like everything else, but she knows she fucked up when Adora suddenly goes quiet.

"You did?"

It's true, but why did she have to say it? Stupid, stupid, stupid.

"I mean, it was probably the cookie more than anything. You know I have a thing for snickerdoodle," she tries to keep the fun mood going, but it's already fizzled out. Adora is looking at her.

Really looking.

The way her eyes seem to scrutinize Catra's face would be uncomfortable, except it feels a little bit like...admiration? God, maybe she's just over the edge of tipsy where she's starting to convince herself she's seeing things that aren't really there. But there's no missing it when Adora's tongue flicks out over her lips once, like maybe she's about to speak or...something else. Catra won't let herself think it.

Just as she's swallowing the lump of hopes in her throat, Adora says something she never expected in a billion years.

"Would it be weird if I asked to kiss you?" She blurts it out quick, like maybe she's nervous. Maybe she was thinking about it all night, too.

Or maybe they both fell asleep already and Catra just doesn't remember it because she woke up in a fucking dream.

"No."

"Sorry , you're right, it's weird," Adora shakes her head, covers her face in embarrassment, and it's only then that Catra realizes how that must've sounded.

"No, Adora. I meant no, it wouldn't be weird," she clarifies. Calm. Cool. Collected. It's fine. She's only sweating and screaming and crying and dying inside.

But it's fine.

"Might be good to practice for when we inevitably have to sell it for an audience, right?"

Because it's just an act. A game. A prank. It doesn't have to mean anything.

"Right," Adora visibly swallows as her eyes settle on Catra' s lips, "Y eah. Practice."

Stupid, again! Just admit you want to kiss her! Who cares about this pretend shit! You practically worship the ground she walks on, you stupid, dumb, idiot, fool!

"Okay ," Catra clears her throat once, "Maybe, uh..come here, then?"

Why does she feel like a stumbling seventeen year old all of a sudden?

Adora nods as she takes her careful steps forward. She's glowing. She looks like a fucking goddess. Her eyes, her curves, her arms, her legs, the deep V that cuts all the way down to just above her belly, the exposed skin of her breasts between it. Catra's going to

combust. Literally burst into flames and they haven't even done anything yet.

She's already sitting on the edge of the bed, so Adora sits next to her.

And then her face is merely inches away and Catra's panicking. It's not like she hasn't done this a plenty of times with plenty of other women, so why does it have to feel so fucking different just because it's with Adora?

The corner of Adora's mouth turns up into a half-smile, probably trying not to laugh like she often does when she feels awkward, but knowing that it would ruin the moment. Which must mean there's a moment she's afraid of ruining.

Catra reaches up to curl her fingers around Adora's jawline like her hand has twitched to do for the entirety of their days and the edges of her world melt away as her vision hones into the soft shape of Adora's mouth, slightly parted in awaiting awe. Her thumb instinctively reaches out to trace the edge of Adora's bottom lip where it meets her skin in matched reverence, and she makes sure to check Adora's eyes one last time, muted blue as ever with a widened bit of wonder. There doesn't seem to be any hesitation there, but maybe she's just seeing what she wants to again. She really wishes her hopes weren't so goddamn high right now.

Because if this is just for practice and doesn't actually mean anything, then all she can do is paint it out to be as picturesque as it feels.

Every cell within her dances to life when Adora is the one to close the gap between them.

She just presses their lips together and it' s everything. The way they're so soft yet curious, the way they mold around the shape of Catra's own, the way they move to fill the cut of each other. The way she tastes like the eternity of a summer bonfire, that feeling of

perfect peace that you wish you could hold onto forever. How Catra can feel the hairs on her body stand at attention and her ribcage suddenly struggles to contain her heart behind it.

The way Adora breathes into it, how her hand reaches up to snake its way through Catra's hair by the bottom tufts of her scalp and the other lands over Catra's shoulder to guide her in closer.

How she doesn't hesitate when Catra's tongue finds hers and then they're moving together, like if they work hard enough maybe they could suck every bit of air from the other's lungs.

And then Catra leans a little too far over, and Adora falls onto the mattress, head against the pillow, and that spark travels all the way through her veins and turns to a pulse between her legs, and then there's a hand against Catra's chest as Adora mumbles something into her mouth.

They split apart, labored breathing in each other's faces. She's hovering inches above Adora with her hair splayed out around her face and every bit of Catra scurries to snap a mental photo and hang it up at the front of her gallery for most Earth shattering moments of all time.

She wants to ask how that was, why they stopped, how Adora feels, what this means. But all she can do is blink back, waiting, frozen.

"We should be careful,"Adora finally breathes out, biting her bottom lip into her mouth.

Fuck.

"Right,"Catra agrees, using every last bit of her willpower to push herself up and back to sit on the edge of the bed again.

"I just mean, like,"Adora sits up, too. She reaches to place a gentle hand on Catra's knee when she explains, "We want to stay friends

after all this, you know? So we probably shouldn't do anything to mess that up."

Every word feels like a dagger aimed at each separate chamber of her heart.

"Yeah, you're right," she nods in agreement, begging for some relief from this sudden nightmare of her own creation. "No need to practice any further."

"Catra, I wasn't—

"It's fine," she manages to toss out something of a convincing chuckle as she looks over with a smile. She takes Adora's hand and moves it from her thigh to Adora's own lap. "I got a little carried away, but you're right. Let's not do something we'll end up regretting."

Adora's brows scrunch together in concern. Her face falls into a frown, but she doesn't offer anything more.

So Catra just hoists herself up to head towards the bathroom and into a hot shower. She has to get the fuck away from this woman before she says something even stupider than before and ends up blowing her own cover.

Chapter End Notes

How are we feeling dearies?

If you're liking this story so far, maybe show it some love here, too. :)

Thank you, I love you, and stay tuned!x

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

This one is just anxiety and emotion and a bit of quality family time.

Enjoy!:)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A

She's still thinking about it a whole week later.

Why did she do that? Why would she say that? Why did she have to fucking panic? Catra was right there, they were so close, she could've just given in…

But it felt too real.

And Catra said it was just practice. More than once, she reminded her it was just for show .

Because they're not actually together, and Catra's not actually into her.

Catra's not reckless with her heart or her body, but she does have flings. Every now and then, some pretty woman will come along and sleep in her bed for a night or two, and that's fine. Adora has had her share of random hookups and date nights over the years, too. She just decided she doesn't like them. She wants something deeper , someday. Whenever that happens.

Except she doesn't date anymore, either, so it's been more than a while since she's been with anyone besides her own hand or the toys in her bedside drawer.

Maybe that's becoming a bit of a problem, because it took barely a minute of just a little making out with Catra to feel like she was ready to pounce.

Holy shit. She made out with *Catra*.

Maybe it would be less weird if they weren't pretending to be engaged. But then, without the engagement Adora may not have ever found the opportunity to kiss her like that in the first place. God knows she's imagined it enough times over the years.

For now, she's left to imagine all the other women who've gotten to kiss her like that;the ones who didn't chicken out. Every other woman who's been lucky enough to let her bring them over the edge, everyone who's had the opportunity to inspire that rush within her in return. How many times and how far did it get them? Did they lose themselves around the smooth of her curves, the heat of her breath, the sigh of her pleasure;does she scream, does she squeak, does she whine? What as Catra the one to trace along their edges, were her hands the ones to wander further, how well would her tongue know how to dance between Adora's legs?

She should not have kissed her like that, because now all she wants is more.

She's trying to focus on signing off the stack of documents to approve the new proposals from the marketing team when her personal cell lights up with a call from the old woman and raspberry emojs.

"Hi, gran!" She answers, latching onto the distraction from her tornado of Catra thoughts.

“Adora, dearie, how are you?” She can hear Grandma Razz’s smile through the phone.

“Good, I’m doing alright,” she says, honest as she can muster. “How are you?”

“Oh, wonderful! I was just thinking of you as I pulled your favorite pie from the oven.”

“Spiced pear?” Adora perks up with memories of helping her gran pick from the fruit trees in her yard to bake together when she was a little girl.

“Unless your favorite has changed without my knowledge!” She laughs, “Oh, your aunt and I miss you. Have you got time to come visit after work tonight?”

Adora can’t think of a single thing to better soothe her soul than an evening of homemade pie and hopefully a good old fashioned Aunt Casta sweater, hand knitted with love. Maybe they’ll pull out the old board games or card games, maybe she’ll get to learn some new natural recipes for manifesting some goddamn peace back into her life. Either way, she could really use some quality time with the more manageable parts of her tiny family.

“For you two? Absolutely. I’ll swing by as soon as I leave the office,” she smiles.

“It’s alright, dearie, you can admit you’re in it for the pie,” gran laughs.

“It certainly doesn’t hurt,” she jokes back. “I’ll see you guys later, okay? Tell Aunt Casta to prepare to have her ass handed to her in Clue again.”

“See you soon!” She sings, clicking the line dead a moment later.

“Razz?” Catra perks up from across the room.

"Yeah," Adora simply nods, pairing it with a polite smile.

Things have been weird between them since the hotel. Probably because she made a total fool of herself by asking for a kiss and then stopping before they could go too far, like some kind of awkward high school virgin.

Stupid. It was all right there in front of her and she panicked. She could've had it but she panicked. And now exactly what she tried to avoid happening is happening.

"Wanna come with? She made my favorite pie," she adds after a moment of pause.

"Sorry," Catra says it almost too quickly. "Perfuma's been making me sniff all these different flowers to figure out my favorite. It's so annoying. I already told her I don't care what she picks, but she won't have it."

"Oh," Adora says, "isn't that something we should be doing together?"

"I mean, we already know your favorite," Catra shrugs. "I'm not choosing arrangements yet. She just wants to figure out which one to pair with yours, so she can create something that's uniquely ours, whatever that means."

"I'm sure it'll be extremely over the top for no reason other than her complete dedication to the art of nature," Adora inflects her voice at the end to sound just like how Perfuma would say it.

Catra laughs in the cute raspy way she always does. God, Adora misses her. She's right there, but it doesn't feel the same. If only she could rewind to the moment right before she asked that stupid question that ruined it all.

But would she have been able to resist if she knew what it would bring? Catra looked incredible that night, with her effortlessly styled

hair and the black on black and that distinct edge of coolness she has that suggests she knows she's the hottest person in the room. Nevermind all her bare skin and the way her lacy bralette held her tits up like an altar offering to the heavens. Adora kept her hands to herself all evening, but as soon as they were alone it was like a switch flipped and she had to do something about it.

Does she regret it, or does she just regret ending it before they went too far?

"I should just pick something random to get her off my back about it," Catra sighs, pulling her out of her head again. "We've been through like fifty different kinds already. I really don't think I have a favorite."

"Well, if you had to pick from all the ones she's made you try so far, what would it be?"

"No, Adora, you don't get it. I really don't care," she deadpans. "What use are flowers to me anyway? All they do is look pretty."

"Not true! They smell nice, they help bees pollinate and make honey, you can turn them into teas and stuff." Adora trails off before teasing, "They're the perfect gift to surprise your wife with."

She waits for Catra to take the bait. Give her a little joke, a smirk, a quip about how she'd prefer chocolates or jewelry or something. She just needs to know that Catra still cares about her. That their bond is still strong even when it feels like something is off between them.

Catra rolls her eyes.

"Fine. You want me to choose something I wouldn't mind you picking up on our shared car ride back to our shared home after a long day in our shared office? In this future married life of ours."

There it is.

Adora smirks. "More than anything."

"She showed me one yesterday that was like, deep purple with a bunch of white spots, like paint splatters or something. I thought that was kind of cool," she shrugs.

"Oh, galaxy flowers?" Adora guesses.

"Sure, probably ," she says, "What are you, a secret florist or something?"

"The way Perfuma talks about her work is kind of nice. It' s easy to get sucked in sometimes," she admits. "Also, like any other semi-sane person on Earth, I actually do enjoy flowers."

"T ake my place tonight then, please," Catra begs.

"Sorry , I'm booked," she chuckles. "I am curious though, since I wasn't invited to begin with. What are you both so sure that my favorite is, anyway?"

The brow over her blue eye rises in acceptance of that challenge.

"Lillies. Specifically tiger lillies," she says. "But you prefer the smell of asmine."

An expertly framed answer. Adora has definitely mentioned the lily thing before, but Catra probably assumed the other part based on all the candles and lotions throughout her home, and she's not wrong. The fact that she pays such careful attention is comforting. You don't just forget someone you have that kind of specific knowledge about overnight.

"So you do still like me," she says it with less playfulness in her voice than usual, because this time she's only half teasing;the other half genuinely awaits the verbal confirmation that she hasn't messed things up between them.

Catra smiles. Close-mouthed, without a word of banter to accompany it. It doesn't even touch her eyes. It feels hollow.

Then she turns her attention back to her monitor and the silence stretches miles between them again.

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She tries not to think about it, so of course it's the only thing on her mind the whole way to gran's house.

Does Catra mean to be so distant and withholding? Is she trying to make it explicitly clear that the hotel was a mistake and she doesn't want Adora to get the wrong idea about how things are going to be going forward? It's probably much smarter to keep some boundaries between them anyway, if they're going to have a successful fake marriage. That's the entire reason why Adora didn't want to take it too far that night.

But should there even be a wedding if it's going to be awkward between them forever?

She has to swallow all of it down before going up the sturdy wooden steps to Grandma Razz's cottage on the outskirts of the city. She'd take one look at her and know something's on her mind, and Adora couldn't possibly risk telling her anything near the truth about what's going on.

I kissed my fake fiancé and I think it ruined things between us and now I don't know what to do about it, she imagines, laughing to herself as she knocks on the door.

"Adora! Welcome home!" Her aunt is the one to answer, holding her arms out wide for a hug.

She's tall and lean and her long, jet black hair engulfs Adora with the scent of lavender and sandalwood from the herbs she uses in her

spells.

"Hey , Aunt Casta," Adora smiles into the breezy fabric.

"Come on in, we're just gathered by the fire," she quickly breaks away, jittery almost, as she closes the door behind them and ushers her through the kitchen to the living room on the other side.

Grandma Razz is sitting in her favorite cushioned rocking chair and she looks up with a smile when Adora makes her entrance. She's just as sweet and vivid as ever , with her coke bottle glasses, grass woven jewelry , and heavy pink garments draped over her frail old body, all carefully knitted with love just like she passed on to her daughter.

"Adora, dearie, so good to see you," gran's arms are spread in greeting, so Adora allows herself to be pulled in for another hug.

Meanwhile, her gaze settles onto Glimmer, who's made herself comfortable on one end of the couch, reaching for a sugar cookie from the spread of freshly baked goods on the table in front of her. At least gran wasn't lying about making her favorite pie. She just conveniently left out the part about making her sister's favorite dessert, too.

They haven't seen or spoken to each other in at least two weeks. She looks a little thinner in the face and the pinks and purples in her hair seem dull, like maybe she hasn't been eating or taking care of herself properly? Bow said her final rejection has been hitting her pretty hard, and he mentioned the other day that he's starting to worry about her, but he must have downplayed the details to spare Adora the image of her like this.

Despite everything, she still feels bad. She never wanted to end up hurting her sister. She pictured their reunion going a lot of different ways over the years, but nothing could've prepared her for the amount of destruction between them now.

“Grandma Razz,” Adora smiles, slightly disoriented by her surroundings, but trying to stay present. “I missed you.”

More than she could’ve expected. It’s true that work does keep her busy, but maybe she’s also sort of been using it to run from reality in her own way. When she left home shortly after Glimmer skipped town, she stopped calling as much and tried to push her remaining family to the side in avoidance of all the traumatic memories they came with. Most people would want to cling tighter to who they had left after such a tragedy, but Adora reached out for the future and used all the promise of that to pull her out of the hole filled with ghosts of her past.

Now that she’s here for the first time in well over a year, it actually feels like home again. The dimly lit room in the light of the crackling fire, the outdated furniture, the knitting basket in the corner and the old throw blankets draped over the back of the couch, even the pictures hung on every inch of space on the walls. Dad’s smiling face, all the way from his and Aunt Casta’s childhood up until his last few years. Her and Glimmer and even some featuring Catra;two or three of them playing in the yard and on the beach, among an array of awkward school photos. Wedding photos and baby photos and family photos featuring mom, too. A whole lifetime of memories, smacking Adora across the face like an ice bath in the middle of winter.

“W ow,” she lets out a deep sigh as she drinks in her surroundings. “It really has been a while.”

There’s so much to take in, so much surging inside her all at once.

“The birthday before last, but who’ s keeping track?” Aunt Casta jokes.

“W e missed you too, dearie, but we know how busy you are,” gran says, “And Catra. How is she?”

"She' s good," it feels like jello sliding of f of her tongue, tainted with the taste of what's to come. "W e're um, engaged? Sorry I forgot to tell you. It's just been a whirlwind."

"So we've heard," gran hums, glancing over at Glimmer in a way that seizes Adora's throat shut tight. "Congratulations, though! I'm so happy for you both," she continues, while Adora' s mind scrambles to make sense of that look.

What did Glimmer tell them? Exactly how much did she say , specifically about her and Catra? How has her coming back into Adora's life managed to shake up absolutely everything she cares about, including the relationship with their last living relatives, something she hadn't even thought to worry about until now?

"It' s just about the best news on Earth! T ook you two long enough! Let's see the ring," Aunt Casta waves for Adora to come closer and show it off. She sticks her hand between the two of them to admire, but it's robotic, emotionless. Her gaze stays glued to her sister the whole time. She must not have shared her completely correct theory about it being a fake engagement, seeing as how they seem just as excited as everyone else her and Catra have managed to fool.

Their fawning and chattering turns into background noise and Adora feels like she's submerged underwater. Everything sounds distorted and it feels impossible to breathe normally all of a sudden; like her lungs will fill up and she'll drown if she even tries.

Glimmer only holds eye contact for a few seconds before she chomps off a bite of her cookie and chews too fast, staring into the flames of the fire instead.

"Have a seat, get comfortable, cut yourself a slice," gran gestures to the only empty seat on the other end of the couch, snapping Adora back to attention. She forgot all about the pie that lured her here in the first place. Probably couldn't even stomach it through the thickness in the air, never mind after she settles into the cushion next to her sister.

"So what' s this I'm being told about you two fighting over Bright Moon?" Gran presents the question casually , maybe not fully understanding the weight it carries. More likely, deciding to dive recklessly into it, and yet she somehow always manages to be graceful with her ways of malleating the world to her liking in the end.

Adora and Glimmer both look at each other, silently wondering how specific they should be.

"Where did you hear that? And is this the whole reason you invited us over tonight?" Glimmer asks. She seems just as bewildered by the situation all of a sudden.

"Someone has to get you back on speaking terms," Aunt Casta says. "Bow seemed so concerned when he dropped by the other day ."

"Y ou've been talking to Bow? That traitor!" Glimmer shoots up out of her seat, outraged, "How does he expect me to trust him with anything when he keeps doing this?"

She must be talking partially about how he decided to hang out with Adora, too.

"Shh, it was just that once, dearie," gran says, extending a hand to motion for her to sit back down. "Don't be mad at him. The man loves you so much he's doing all he can to make sure you don't mess up your life for good. Be grateful."

Glimmer grumbles. Her face scrunches uncomfortably, like she wants to keep objecting but can't think of a logical rebuttal. She sighs and sits reluctantly back down.

She's probably just looking for any excuse to get the fuck away from this conversation, which Adora can fully relate to.

"She' s right. He's also really sweet. And cute! T rust me, you want to hang onto him," Aunt Casta gushes. "In any case, he filled us in on

this whole situation, so we brought you both here tonight to share some vital insights that we can only hope will bring some clarity."

Adora crosses her arms. It would have to be completely life-altering information, like the fact that her parents actually had a hidden will where they left Bright Moon completely in Adora's hands or something, but that's just unrealistic to expect from anyone.

Glimmer chuffs. "I really doubt it."

"Now hold on, honey , let's approach this from a place of kindness," gran advises. "You two have to stay open to this. You must be willing to hear each other out and take the necessary steps to move towards a better relationship. Namely, forgiveness."

"You guys used to be the best of friends. Try to remember that,"Aunt Casta reminds them with her gentle tone, so reminiscent of mom even though there's no blood relation between them.

They did used to be inseparable. Before Catra, there was only Glimmer.

Adora was adopted as a baby, so she has zero memory of her birth family at all. She doesn't even know why they left her, and even with all the money and power she has now, she was never able to track down anything about them. Which she ended up being grateful for anyway, because she was always sort of holding her breath at the possibility of finding them someday. She wouldn't know what to say, or if she'd even want to meet them should they have been located, for that matter. All she's ever known is her mom, her dad, her sister, and Catra. And once upon a time, they gave her everything she needed.

Mom and dad weren't perfect, but they were there for every step of her life and development, as long as they could be. And they were happy. Glimmer was born when Adora was just a toddler , so she never even had the chance to treat her like the horror stories of adoptive families where the new kid is just an outcast. The earliest

memory she has of her sister is holding her hand as a toddler, helping to keep her steady as they practiced Glimmer's waddling up down the hallway. Followed by a thousand other images of them laughing, playing, hugging, cuddling, crying, and just growing together.

Of course she remembers. Of course she wants that back.

She sighs, too. Keeping her arms crossed, she turns to acknowledge Glimmer face to face. Glimmer only looks back with a side glance through her peripherals.

"What's the news, then?" Adora prompts their parental stand-ins to go on. She doesn't have high hopes, but whatever their plan is, she's ready to get it over with.

"Your parents didn't divide their assets in the hopes of pitting you two against each other. They wrote it with your individual well-beings in mind," gran says.

"How?" Adora and Glimmer both blurt at the exact same moment. They seem to be completely in sync tonight, so if nothing else at least they'll have that to walk away with.

"Adora, you've always shown more interest in Bright Moon than Glimmer ever did. When they were still with us, it seemed like you were the only one who wanted to follow in their footsteps," Aunt Casta explains. "So they left it to both of you at first, figuring only time would tell who was more committed to living out their dreams of family ownership."

Adora blinks.

So it was always meant to be for her after all?

"If that's true, then why didn't they just write it that way? I have a name! They gave it to me, for Christ's sake!" She practically growls

through her teeth. So many questions and frustrations buzzing around her head all at once.

"They worried about limiting you, dearie. They had all the hopes in the world for you both, but they never wanted you to bear the pressure of those expectations, should you end up deciding differently," gran says.

"Are you serious?" Glimmer's tone comes with an edge of delirium laced through it.

"What's the deal with the whole part about marriage, then?" Adora's still stuck in her own confusion.

Now Aunt Casta looks at gran for her approval to elaborate. Grandma Razz nods.

"That was their way of including Catra, too," she says.

"What?" Now it's Adora's turn to stagger in disbelief. "You're joking, right?"

"Not at all," gran says.

"Of course, they still wanted to give you the freedom of choice, and they didn't want to force you into a lifelong obligation with someone who isn't family. Things happen, you know? Friendships fall apart, relationships don't always work out," Aunt Casta explains, "But they saw you as more of the settling down type, and wondered if you'd eventually pick her."

"But we weren't even dating when they—" Adora trails off. Technically they've never dated, but they're the only two who know that for sure. Has everyone around them just assumed they've been in love all this time?

"No one can really predict the future," gran says. She pushes her feet off the floor to start rocking now, slow and calm as if she's not

delivering exactly the kind of axis shifting news Adora assumed she couldn't possibly have access to.

"It's also important for you to understand, Glimmer, that you were considered in all of this, too," Aunt Casta says. "They saw you try to take interest in the business, but they could tell it wasn't necessarily what you wanted. At the time they were organizing these things, they didn't know what you'd choose to do with your life, but they wanted to give you room to figure it out for yourself."

"Please remember that all of this was based on nothing more than *their* ideas of what was best for both of you," gran adds. "Had they been around longer, I'm sure some appropriate revisions would have been made over time. But they always had faith that in the event of their absence, whichever paths you ended up choosing for yourselves, you'd at least be able to come to a mature decision about what to do with Bright Moon together."

"Their worst case scenario was that you'd choose to put an outsider in charge, but that's only because none of us ever dreamed you'd end up hating each other someday!" Aunt Casta quips, shifting uncomfortably in her seat.

A hush settles over the room as the two of them are given a moment to absorb everything.

How ironic that with the amount of faith their parents apparently put in them, all they've been doing is showing how unfit they both are to handle it. Not to mention the fact that she basically had her parents' blessing to marry Catra way before she even knew she wanted it, and instead she chose to do it as a sneaky way of getting exactly what they wanted her to have along. She ended up completely dishonoring everything they ever taught her about marriage and family values. Everything.

Instead of her and Glimmer sitting down to have that mature conversation their parents wanted, they each chose to viciously pursue their own selfish desires at the expense of their sisterhood.

Glimmer shouldn't have left in the first place, but maybe if Adora tried harder to understand her motives and explain her own side instead of letting anger consume her, Glimmer might have been more willing to listen. Maybe they could've compromised into sharing ownership even after the wedding, Catra included. Marriage or not.

Maybe it never had to go this far after all.

A sudden sob bursts out from Glimmer and she covers her face as it quickly crescendos into something nearly inconsolable.

"Glimmer , dearie! What' s the matter?" Gran' s eyes widen in surprise. Adora and Aunt Casta just share a glance, not having the faintest clue how to react to such a sudden burst of emotion, even from one of the most expressive people they know.

"Everything! Oh my God," she wails out through her tears, removing her hands to wipe some from her face. "The only reason I was trying so hard to force my way into Bright Moon is because I thought that's what mom and dad wanted! All these years, I thought they'd be disappointed in me for running, for not even trying to step up beside Adora, for pursuing my passions instead, and I-I was so mad at them for not understanding me!"

Adora blinks.

"What the fuck," she says, "So you don't even really want Bright Moon?"

"Fuck no!" Glimmer 's crying turns into a burst of laughter, making her sound more than a bit unhinged. "I have an art degree, for God' s sake! I don't want to work in an of fice for the rest of my life."

She kind of knew that Glimmer was doing this as some misguided way of feeling more connected to mom and dad after being away for so long, but this is the first time she's approached it from the right frame of mind. The first time she's genuinely felt willing to open herself up to the realistic possibility of working on their relationship,

not just shutting down every time she talks and hoping to magically manifest it back into one whole piece again.

She hadn't realized how deeply Glimmer had been beating herself up about this, feeling like she wouldn't be able to live up to mom and dad's expectations without it.

There's not a shred of doubt in Adora's mind that she would've fought just as hard and acted just as desperately for that semblance of worthiness, had the roles been reversed.

"But even after being angry for so long," she sniffles, "I still felt guilty. And I just missed them so much. I thought that maybe I'd feel better if I tried to get at least some little shred of my old life back. If I did everything I could to honor their dying wish. And all I ended up doing was pushing Adora and I even further apart."

"Oh, dearie, no!" Gran coos. "Of course they understand you! So much that they tried to give you space to spread your wings, even in their absence."

"Clearly it turned out to be an incredibly misguided attempt," Aunt Casta mumbles, "But with good intentions, nonetheless."

"So all of this was basically for nothing. If we would've just listened more instead of trying to trample over the other on our way to the top," Adora realizes. The arguing, the shouting, all the low blows and snide remarks. All the crying and wondering how they would ever be able to fix the things that never even had to be broken between them in the first place.

Her and Catra's whole engagement…

Adora's amusement starts as a tickle in her tummy, slowly morphing into an audible giggle, and then growing into a full on laugh attack, doubling in proportion to the amount of weight that floats off her shoulders.

"I'm sorry ," she holds her abdomen as she continues cracking up, "It' s~~it'~~ s really not funny. It's just~~so"~~—

It's ridiculous. Out of all the good times they've shared over the years, there were at least as many times when they've almost killed each other in their petty arguments, and it was always mom and dad who managed to talk some sense into them. Now that Glimmer's come back, this is the first fight they've had since their parents' death, and it nearly demolished their whole relationship.

"No," Glimmer grins so hard it looks like it hurts, as she wipes the salty moisture off her cheeks. "I definitely get it."

"W e're the worst!" Adora just laughs. "Y ou don't even want to own Bright Moon! And yet, here we are!"

"I don't!" Her sister joins in her joy , letting herself rejoice alongside her, "It' s so liberating to finally admit it. Fuck that place!"

"Seriously ," Adora agrees.

She loves Bright Moon, of course. And she'll be able to appreciate it so much more now that she doesn't have to worry about it being the downfall of her and Glimmer's sisterhood. But her love for that place is so intense that it's almost a detriment, to the point that she was willing to burn this bond into ashes; this warmth, this understanding, this similarity, just to protect it.

And Catra~~fuc~~k. She' s not even ready to tackle the depths to which she might have ruined that, too. All in the name of Bright Moon. She still has to figure out how to muddle through whatever that kiss changed between them, but in this moment, in this little bubble of buffoonery that her and Glimmer have created together, it feels like maybe all hope hasn't been lost just yet. Maybe everything will be okay.

"I don't see what' s so funny," Aunt Casta says as she watches the two of them doubled over in glee.

"Shh," gran whispers, though not low enough. "They're healing."

"Adora, I am so sorry ," Glimmer finally says, sighing away the last of her giggles to be as sincere as she can again. "Sorry I left, sorry I tried so hard to take the company from you, to undermine your relationship. sorry it took me this long to realize what a bitch I was being. I hope you can forgive me."

"Y ou're already forgiven," the complete depth of her love begins to sting behind her eyes. She reaches out to take both of Glimmer's hands in hers and gently cradle them while she addresses her directly, letting the sensation of recognition bleed between their gaze. "All I wanted was my sister back, that' s it. I just wanted to understand each other and be on each other's side again. And now it feels like we can finally get past this. I just want to forget it all and move forward."

Glimmer smiles, breaking their hold to pull her in for a hug.

She smells clean and pure, like fresh laundry and coconut shea butter. A stupid metaphor for the stupid fresh start they're finally getting.

"Now , aren't you glad I remembered your favorite snacks to lure you here with?" Grandma Razz hums happily , making the whole room share in the laughter this time.

*

They stayed for a little later than Adora planned for. They ended up breaking out the Uno cards, and she only won three out of about fifty rounds. She also ended up having a cookie and a single piece of pie, and then got sent home carrying the rest of it. Gran insisted she was going to make her own favorites the next day anyway, so it would

only end up spoiling in their kitchen. And Aunt Casta didn't have enough time to prepare new sweaters or potions on such short notice, but she did let them each take an old blanket for their own homes and promised to have some new goodies ready for their next visit. Not that it's necessary for either of them, but her primary love language has always been glaringly obvious.

And Adora made a vow with herself to visit more often.

Since mom and dad died, she's been so afraid to revisit anything that could remind her too much of them. It's probably some kind of blessing in disguise that Glimmer came back, because through all the mess, it also forced her to reach a healthier place in her healing. Now, after so much time has passed, spending some quality time with her remaining relatives has led her to a better understanding of her parents, too.

No one ever warned her that their life being over didn't mean that her relationship with them would end, too. She's still alive, still learning and growing, and it's jarring to confront the fact that that means the way she feels about them still fluctuates all the time.

She'll never stop loving them, of course, but it feels so harmonious to *like* them again after weeks of carrying around resentment. At the end of the day, all they wanted was for their children to have everything they needed to begin the perfect lives they imagined for them. Sure, it didn't turn out to be such smooth sailing to get there, but at least it finally makes sense. The intentions they had trickle down into the cracks of her chest and settle into a melty warmth.

"Hey , so," Glimmer stops her outside of her car when they've said their inside goodbyes. "I didn't want to say it in front of them, but I'm also sorry for what I said about you and Catra, you know, not being a real couple. It was completely inappropriate and I should've kept it to myself."

She stiffens.

Some part of her aches to tell her sister how right she is. More than anything, she craves exactly two things right now;someone to talk with about all the complications that come with when you decide to fake marry your best friend, and to build on the rediscovered closeness with her sister. Exposing her secret would fulfil both of those bullets, except it would also probably brew up a whole other storm of grievances, too.

And if Glimmer is really ready to let go of Bright Moon, do they even need to get married anymore? If her sister and Bow were to become the legal company owners, is it safe to assume they'd be willing to transfer the rights back to Adora and Catra anyway?

That would only happen if she and Catra called off their wedding, though. And if they did decide to do that, then they wouldn't have to spend years acting like a married couple, but would theoretically still get to keep their business.

So should they call off the wedding?

"It' s okay," she clears her throat, trying not to choke as she weaves through her own web of lies. "It' s honestly water under the bridge to me."

"It' s not to me, though," Glimmer insists, "I don't want you to think I don't support you guys. I've honestly been rooting for this to happen since like, forever. So I need you to know how much I love you both, and that I'm ready to be there for you on your big day."

"Glimmer , I know," Adora assures her , "Neither of us have exactly been acting like ourselves since you got back, so really. You're forgiven. We love you, too."

"Thanks for being so understanding," she smiles. "I'm probably gonna spend the rest of our lives trying to win Catra over again, though."

"I wish I could argue with that, but we both know how she is," she shrugs, earning a synchronized chuckle that quickly fades out in the next instant, leaving them with the emptiness of the night around them.

"Well, I'm gonna get going. Fiancé waiting at home and everything"…

"Yeah, yeah, me too," Adora nods, swallowing the lump in her throat. "I'm really glad we did this tonight. Don't be afraid to reach out, okay?"

"You too," she says, waving as she heads up the driveway to unlock her own car.

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As soon as Adora steps through the doorway of her own apartment, she kicks off her heels, shrugs out of her blazer and lets it drop to the floor, then tears the elastic out of her hair to take her ponytail down and shake her hair out. The dark, marble tile cools the soles of her aching feet and the air conditioned chill lets her scalp breathe again.

It doesn't really help as much as she hoped, though, so the pin keeping her bangs held in their classic poof atop her head comes next. And then she unzips her pants to untuck her shirt and unhook her bra, tossing that to the floor too.

She still doesn't feel any better, so she wiggles her pants down and steps out of those, then kicks them out of her way.

She looks around her big, empty apartment and wants to scream.

So she does.

And then when she rids her lungs of all the breath in them, she sighs and drags herself to the bathroom for a hot shower.

When even washing her hair doesn't help, she steps out into the steam and dries off, tying a towel under her arms. She goes through the motions of her nightly skincare, brushing her teeth and turning off all the lights after. Then she pulls on a pair of lounge shorts and snuggles herself into a cozy cinnamon bun under the duvet comforter on her bed.

And then she calls Catra.

It's 11:54 pm and the whole world feels soft and quiet, so she may not even answer.

It rings four times before she finally picks up.

"Hey , Adora."

And just like that, she feels like herself again.

"Hey , Catra. I, um," she hesitates. She doesn't really have a reason for calling. All she wanted was to hear her favorite person's voice. She could've waited until they saw each other in the office tomorrow, but that felt too formal. Too much like coworkers, not enough like best friends.

Who is she trying to fool anymore? They're not just friends.

She's pretty sure she's been in love with Catra all this time.

"Just wanted to see how it went today . Did you end up picking a flower to match mine?"

"Yeah, I ended up going with the galaxy thing. They're called Night Sky Petunias, by the way, and apparently they'll pair best with white lilies? So that' s what you're stuck with to represent you," she says.

"Sounds lovely ," Adora smiles.

"After smelling about a hundred more flowers, anything sounds lovely to me. I think I have allergies now," Catra chuckles at her own joke. Adora could just wrap herself in the sound of it and live there forever.

"You know what I've heard helps with that? Apple Cider Vinegar," she offers.

"Gross. I'll take my chances," she can picture the way Catra would scrunch her cute little nose as she says it.

The line goes silent, but Adora aches to hear her talk for just a little bit longer.

"How'd your night go? How is everyone?" Catra asks after a moment. Maybe she's on the same page?

"Good," Adora simplifies. She's pretty sure that telling Catra about Glimmer's breakthrough now would only stress her out, making her say something about how fake it is and that they shouldn't trust her. But Adora wants to trust her. And she still wants to marry Catra, anyway. Even if it's not a real marriage. Even if that kind of makes her a terrible person.

So she'll keep it between her and Glimmer for now, and just enjoy what time she may still have left with Catra before it possibly crumbles to pieces.

"They asked about you," she adds, "They send their congratulations and best wishes. Also, I have nearly a whole pear pie here that I need you to help me finish."

Come over. It doesn't have to be tonight. Just come back to me.

"Bring it in tomorrow," Catra says, smoothly swerving around it. "It won't last ten minutes in any of the breakrooms."

"True," Adora breathes a tiny laugh through her nose just to humor her.

More dead air between them.

"Well, I should get to bed," Catra says.

Adora nods against her pillow. When the line cuts out, she might let herself cry into it, but for now, she just squishes her head further into the fabric and down.

"Yeah," she agrees, even though she doesn't really agree. "Goodnight, Catra."

"Night, Adora," Catra sounds like she's in a hurry to press the end button.

When she's alone again, Adora buries herself deeper and sighs into the darkness.

Maybe things will be better tomorrow.

Chapter End Notes

> As always, I want to know every single thought in your little heads, no matter where it may fall on the coherence scale.
>
> Thanks again for tuning in, and I hope you stick around for more!:) x

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

Catra contemplates. Adora stumbles. They both learn to let go.

Enjoy!:)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

C

It's killing her to do it, but the only way she can hold herself together is by wearing a mask around Adora. A mask of politeness and indifference, because if she actually said anything on her mind out loud, it would ruin everything. Their whole engagement. Their friendship. Their work partnership. Catra would have nothing left without Adora.

So no, she can't let Adora know how much it destroyed her to hear the word *friends* from her mouth seconds after her lips had been on it. Or how much it pains her to pull away, how deep it carves to see that struggle on Adora's face every time Catra dodges one of her attempts to bring them closer again.

It's hollowing to admit even to herself, but that kiss changed everything. It was supposed to be for practice, but none of this has ever been an act for Catra, so it was naïve to think she could handle it.

Maybe if she were a better person;someone a little less selfish and a lot more kind and loving. Someone like Adora.

Before, it was normal for all of Catra's little fantasies to stay just that: fantasies. It wasn't easy, but she'd grown used to it. Friends was all they could ever be. But now the taste of Adora's tongue is in her head. Her strong arms and the curves underneath her clothes are a ghost on Catra's fingertips. The way their mouths moved together and how easily their bodies leaned into it and everything it could've led to is *reality*.

There was something there. She didn't imagine it. She's not crazy.

Adora just doesn't want to do anything about it. She'd rather stay friends.

And knowing that is so much harder to stomach than just fearing the possibility of it.

So, Catra hides. She fills her days with things beyond work and engagement obligations. She plays the role when they must, with wedding planning and client outings and reluctant family dinners with Glimmer and Bow.

Apparently Adora and her sister have been working their shit out, so Catra's playing along. She doesn't get how Adora can be so willing to give Glimmer chance after chance, but maybe it's because she's never had a sister of her own. Regardless, it's a good fiance's duty to be supportive, right? Like Bow . It feels like Catra's playing many different roles these days, drawing inspiration from those around her who appear to be more stable than she feels.

Dinner is fine. They talk and laugh among them, and with Adora and Bow having gotten close enough to have developed their own little inside jokes now , it feels like less of a hostile family standoff and more of a genuine family hangout. Everything is fine when she and Adora are around others. It's only when they're forced to be alone that Catra grows quiet as she stuffs all her emotions back into the indestructible little black box deep in the back of her chest.

Glimmer traps her in the foyer on their way out one evening.

"Catra, wait," her voice calls, just as Catra's hand is about to twist the doorknob.

Both her and Adora turn to look over their shoulders, but Glimmer waves her sister off to get Catra alone. For what?

"I just wanted to, um," she clears her throat, "Well, I know Adora and I are on better terms now that we had that big heart to heart or whatever, but it doesn't mean that everything is cool between you and I, ya know? So I feel like we should talk."

Catra blinks. What on earth is she talking about?

"You and Adora had a heart to heart," she says it like an observation, not something she already knew. Because she didn't.

"Yeah," Glimmer tilts her head to one side. "A couple weeks ago, at gran and Aunt Casta's. She didn't tell you?"

Catra purses her lips. She doesn't have to admit it out loud.

"Is everything okay?" Glimmer asks, her brows scrunching together in concern. As if she's given a single shit about any of Catra's feelings since she got back in town. "You two have seemed a little off lately."

"What did you tell her to make her magically decide to like you again?" Catra deflects.

"Well, maybe I shouldn't... if she kept it from you…"

That phrase skewers right through her. *She kept it from you…*

Her and Adora have never kept secrets from each other. Except for one. Adora used to tell her things she'd make Catra swear not to ever tell Glimmer, and now she's just decided to replace her all of a sudden?

"Sparkles, if this is your way of trying to make up with me, it's not getting you anywhere," Catra snaps. The way Glimmer visibly recoils at her tone automatically compels her to try a softer approach instead. "I mean...if Adora is hiding something important from me, please keep me in the loop. Wouldn't you want to know if it was Bow?"

Glimmer sighs.

"It's not anything huge, I guess. We found out that our parents intended for you and Adora to run Bright Moon all along," she says. "So I apologized for acting like a psycho and we laughed about it and it finally feels like everything is good again. I never really wanted the company anyway, I just—

"What?" Catra interjects, her brain having barely processed the information dump. "How is that not anything huge? What exactly did they say?"

It's completely huge. It changes everything.

"Oh," Glimmer starts, "just that I guess my parents were pretty open about discussing this stuff, so gran and Aunt Casta said that they divided their assets based on what they wanted for us, but not in a way that was too limiting. Which is why the company was left to the daughter who marries first, because they figured it would be Adora."

"To *me*?" Her eyes feel like they're about to bulge right out of her skull.

She always felt accepted by Micah and Angella, but certainly not to that extent. They considered her in their dying will? They wanted her to marry their daughter? And to run the company long term? And Adora didn't think any of this was completely vital to mention?

Catra feels hot. The edges of her vision begin to blur. She can't tell if she's angry or hurt or if she wants to run, for some reason? Like she could just sprint out into the middle of an empty field and scream at

the sky until her lungs bleed. At exactly what point did her life become such an ugly, convoluted mess?

"Oh, yeah," Glimmer smiles. "They approved of you all along. I guess that is pretty big news. I mean, to nobody except the two of you, apparently."

"No shit!" She growls. "Why wouldn't Adora want me to know?"

Glimmer shrugs. "I honestly have no idea. I wouldn't have brought it up if I knew you two hadn't even talked about it yet."

It would set Adora free. They wouldn't have to keep pretending like this marriage plan isn't quite possibly the biggest mistake they've ever made. Why wouldn't she want out of that? Is she using it to pretend like they're closer than they actually are right now? Does she not trust Glimmer to fully back off and wants to keep up the charade just to make sure?

Or.

Allowing herself to consider it just leaves the door open for further disappointment, so Catra treads carefully.

But is it possible that Adora doesn't want to call off the engagement?

Catra shakes her head, turning on her heel to get the fuck out of there.

"Okay , well, I just wanted to say I'm sorry for everything!" Glimmer shouts after her, but Catra's mind isn't even on that anymore. Her heart is racing. She's wondering if the woman she's been in love with since before she even knew what love was could actually have feelings for her, too.

Feelings that, for whatever reason, she's too afraid to confront.

So should Catra just admit to her own, then?

Why does it feel like the most daunting thing on Earth to just talk to her fucking best friend all of a sudden? They used to talk about everything, especially related to Bright Moon and even more especially Glimmer trying to take it from them. They would've celebrated this a few weeks ago. Maybe even laughed at the idea of her parents thinking they were meant to be together.

"You okay?" Adora's voice bursts her out of her bubble and back to the moment.

"Huh? Oh," she forgot she was in the passenger's seat on the way home already. "Yeah. Fine."

"Are you sure? You seemed a little off tonight," she says.

"Why does everyone think that?" Catra huffs. "I'm fine. As long as we sold the engagement that's what matters, right?"

She looks over through her peripherals to gauge Adora's reaction.

The way she visibly swallows, her grip tightens ever so slightly on the wheel, and she becomes extra concentrated with keeping her focus on the road.

So Glimmer wasn't lying. Not that Catra thought she was, but it's something to be considered until evidence such as Adora's abrupt tension could clear her name.

Is this her attempt at pushing Catra away, then? Why does it hurt so much to find out that exactly what she's trying to accomplish is working? Catra used to think it was only a matter of time until they drifted apart or something came between them. Maybe their time is finally up. Maybe Catra's inability to contain her feelings are the thing to come between them.

"Right," Adora's voice comes softer this time as she tries once again to coax Catra back into the friend she used to know. "But you matter,

too. I'd be happy to stay over and make you soup or something if you're sick."

"No," Catra doesn't even attempt to keep the strain out of her voice. If Adora is so hell-bent on hurting her, then two can play at that game.

The rest of the ride is silent. Catra stares out the window for the full twenty minutes, swirling in a stormy sea of her own making.

Who even is she without Adora? She screwed herself with that one, blindly choosing to build her life so thoroughly around this person that it feels impossible to untangle herself now. How would she attempt to run if they never end up working this out? Where would she go? How does anyone learn to live without someone who's been ingrained in their life for more than twenty years?

It sparks this ugly desperation inside her, some feral creature clawing at its cage to seize the opportunity to reach its talons towards Adora and hold her close, devour her too quickly for anyone else to get their hands on her. Not Glimmer or Bow or even her deceased parents would ever see her again. Just Catra and Adora, existing as one entity, ditching the world they know to live somewhere secluded and safe from all the outside forces working against them.

She doesn't have anything else to say before the car ride ends, she hops out of the car, and scurries up the driveway to her own house.

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Things feel so much less desolate the next morning and the days that follow. Before she even knows it, the wedding is only a couple weeks away and Catra's just trying not to panic. Although it has

occurred to her more than a few times, she can't call it off the wedding because then she loses the only thing she has left;Bright Moon. But there's a tiny voice yelling in the back of her head that she might not even want that anymore, either. Not without Adora. Not if they're going to have to keep up this dance for the rest of their lives. This secretive, fragile thing awkwardly floating between them.

Double Trouble's gala is the first time they're forced to spend an extended amount of time together since the last event. And of course they were only booked one hotel room. With one bed. How generous of their host to provide the accommodations for each of their honored guests out of town travel.

All of the speakers got to invite a plus one, so even though Adora picked Glimmer first, her sister insisted she preferred to stay out of the spotlight in relation to Bright Moon at all, which is a complete change of heart that Catra never saw coming. Something about being too nervous around so many rich people and being content to stay out of the public eye for the rest of her life. In any case, Bow was happy to take her place, so he and Entrapta end up finding that they get along just fine once all the tech talk blossoms between them.

"Should we practice our speeches on the way there?" Adora turns to Catra and asks after the plane has leveled in the air.

Catra can't help the smirk from spreading. It is so like her to be overprepared.

"You can deliver yours to me if you want," she says, closing her eyes and melting into the back cushion of her seat. They've got about a six hour flight ahead of them and the only way Catra's going to survive it is by sleeping. "I'm just gonna wing it."

"You didn't write anything at all?" She can practically hear the way Adora's eyes widen in worry.

Catra shrugs. "I figure I'll just talk about how my useless mom fueled me to make something of myself, maybe sprinkle in some gems about your parents helping me along the way, then end with some corny line about how it gets better or whatever."

"You're the bravest person I know," Adora says.

"Thanks," Catra laughs at the irony. If she were brave at all, she would've confessed her feelings long ago instead of letting them fester into this big, formidably consuming monster that she's now so afraid to face that it may just end up winning after all.

They lapse back into silence. She tries to focus on the hum of the plane passing through endless sky around them, but she can feel Adora's anxiety rolling off of her in waves.

She sighs. If nothing else, her friend needs her right now.

"You'll do great, ya know," she opens her eyes and turns her head to face Adora, stuffing down the way each little look they share these days feels just on the brink of earth shattering. "You're good at this diplomatic stuff. Don't psych yourself out."

Adora smiles weakly. "Thanks."

"Just think of it as a board meeting," Catra encourages. "The two of us at the head of the table, addressing our faithful room of well paid staff slash secret admirers."

"I guess that's not too far off," she chuckles. "Our board meetings don't have press at them, though. And they focus on way less personal matters. Plus, it feels so much easier to be a big fish in a little pond than a little fish in a big one."

"You're still the big fish," Catra says. "We're all big fish. That's why Double Trouble asked us to speak in the first place."

Adora scrunches her brows together like she's really trying hard to absorb that message.

"You're right," she finally nods. "This is why we make such a good team."

Catra forces herself to smile. Then she closes her eyes and forces herself to disappear again.

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Adora has gone with a white jumpsuit composed entirely of a shimmery, glittery fabric. Spaghetti straps, cuffed just above the ankles, and fastened with a metallic gold belt around her waist. Matching gold heels, dangly gold earrings, a golden chain that settles perfectly into her collarbones, finished off with a pop of red lipstick and a bright red clutch to accentuate the look. Her hair is tied in one long, loose braid that she pulls over her shoulder when she asks, "How do I look?"

Has her stylist always been this good, or does it just feel extra impressive because Catra barely knows her anymore?

"Incredible," she'll always be honest about that. "I wouldn't have stuffed myself into a dress tonight if I knew pants were an option."

She thought galas were supposed to be the fanciest of the fancy, so she let Scorpia and Perfuma pick something totally out of character for her. It's an evening gown that comes up to her neck, save for the diamond cut out in the middle of her chest and an even larger one to expose the skin from her shoulders down to the dip of her back. Her skirt is long enough to drag on the floor behind her, and it's stitched with golden embellishments swirling around her sides and halfway

down its length, so it turns out that they ended up matching despite the lack of coordination.

"Well, you look," Adora gives her a careful evaluation from head to toe. "Hot."

Why don't you fucking do something about it, then?

"So, as usual," Catra shrugs. It's cool. She will not let Adora get to her.

"Seriously," Adora chuckles, "What's with the boob window? Don't get me wrong, I love it, but who are you trying to impress?"

You, stupid. It's always you.

"All the little lesbians who think they'll never get their chance with a babe like me," Catra coos. "You're really the inspirational story here."

"Feisty tonight, are we?" Adora picks up on the subtle jabs in her voice.

"You're one to talk. Did you get into the mini fridge already?"

"I needed something to settle my nerves before we take the stage," she admits.

Catra rolls her eyes. "I told you, you're gonna be fine. Just follow my lead."

"Follow mine," Adora counters, holding her elbow out for Catra to lace her own arm through it as they leave to collect their crew and head to the event downstairs.

Per usual, Double Trouble is nothing if not extravagant. They've reserved an entire five star hotel for the evening, and the building itself is an architectural masterpiece. It's an extension of a more famous one in Paris, so it was designed to replicate an old European

experience. High ceilings, intricate structures, large windows overlooking fancy gardens, pools and outdoor space.

The dining hall is filled with rows of round tables adorned with floral centerpieces, crystal table settings, and candlelight flames. There's a bunch of fabulous golden chandeliers hanging from the ceiling, not to mention the twinkle lights to set a cozy mood and the spotlights aimed at the stage setup at the head of the room. An usher asks for the names of their group at the door, then leads them to the corner nearest the stage, where all the speakers and their guests have been assigned seats at private tables.

"Okay , this is so cool!By far , the fanciest party I've ever been to," Bow gushes.

"Stick with us and that might not be the case for long,"Adora beams.

"It' s true. Based on the amount of wealth someone like Double Trouble has hoarded in their time, I'd expect something much more private and elaborate,"Entrapta observes, "But I suppose it' s also a smart move in terms of public appearance to keep it at least a little bit reasonable considering that the event is in celebration of a shelter for unhoused youth."

Catra has such a high amount of respect for Entrapta. Her near complete lack of social skill often leads her to say things most people wouldn't dare consider, like calling out a billionaire's exploitative methods and lack of taste at the dinner table of said billionaire's expensive event. She simply smirks and takes a sip of her drink, admiring her very correct decision to invite Entrapta instead of Scorpia, who, on the opposite end of the spectrum, would've spent the whole night with stars in her eyes like a total fangirl.

"More private?More elaborate?"Bow' s eyes bulge. "Adora, please feel free to invite me to any and all work events that include a plus one in the future."

"T otally. You're way more fun than Glimmer would be," Adora laughs. "Y ou should be my new sibling."

"Brother in-law is still a brother , right?"

Adora giggle-snorts, and that's what gives her away.

"Adora," Catra hisses, "How much champagne have you had?"

"I dunno, like two or four ," she waves her hand ambiguously around the air.

"Four glasses?" Catra' s eyes widen.

"I'm kidding," Adora rolls her eyes. "Just one. But I did sneak those two nips from the mini fridge before we left the room."

"Christ, okay , that's enough. Drink some water now," Catra says.

"Fine," she groans, reaching for her glass to chug it halfway down. When she places it back on the table, she asks, "When did you become the lame one?"

When you ruined my life, you idiot.

"T rust me, I'll get my fill after our speech is done," she snaps. She could use a drink or four herself, honestly. Especially when Entrapta starts to showcase the functional forklift she created using the entire table's disposable napkins and some stems she picked from the centerpiece. Bow and Adora's eyes both go all sparkly as they fawn over her invention, and Catra realizes she actually is surrounded by idiots.

Somehow, they make it through dinner. Adora seems more in control of herself once she has some food in her belly, but still Catra prays she doesn't make a fool of herself on stage. When dessert is finally cleared away, Double Trouble takes the stage to formally welcome everybody with some speech about what inspired them to do

something for the greater good and why this cause spoke to them specifically.

The invites said to just share your experience;it was supposed to be all about the many different ways queer people exist in the world, the different paths they take, how everyone's story is valid, and how success is achievable regardless of those origins or how lost and hopeless it may feel sometimes.

They announce the first speaker, and the next, and the next. It all begins to drone on after that. Story after story about how so and so started with not much to their name and how they wish they could've had somewhere like this to retreat to, but it's okay because now they sleep in crystal castles and have staff to do their grocery shopping or whatever.

By the time Catra and Adora's names are called, she's almost sure they could get on stage and just scream into the mic for twenty minutes and the crowd would still erupt in applause. It's a good thing, what they're doing;Catra just doesn't understand what the point of this glorified party is when Double Trouble clearly has enough to fund at least three-hundred LGBT shelters across the nation without scratching the surface of one single bank account.

"So great to be here with you all this evening," Catra starts off, waiting for the welcome claps and the initial snapshots of their arrival to die down before continuing. "I'm not one to sugar coat things, so I'll just get right into it. My earliest memories consist of a mother who was rarely around, and when she was, I often wished she wasn't. I was never close to any of my family and struggled with my own self-worth for a long time, even after finding my place within my then best friend's home."

She looks over at Adora, who's eyes are already on her. She doesn't even bother to face the crowd, just nods for Catra to continue. The spotlight does make her a little nervous, but she clears her throat to push through anyway.

“Adora and I met when we were like, eight years old. It was eight, right?” She pretends to check, only because people eat that flirty-fiancé shit right up. Of course she knows when they met, but it’s all part of the performance.

“Six and seven, hon,” Adora corrects, placing a gentle hand on Catra’s forearm. “First grade, remember?”

“Of course, of course,” Catra nods. “Sorry, guess we’re getting old already. But how could I forget the day my life was forever changed?”

The crowd awws, predictably. Catra swallows the lump in her throat, tearing her eyes from Adora’s to address the crowd again.

“I often wonder what would’ve become of me, had I not been gifted with the support of her late parents to lead me here today,” the same parents who wanted her to have everything Adora does. The parents who wanted her to have Adora. “And my lovely fiancé was right there cheering me on with them. Of course, at the time, we were only friends. But the way her and her family believed in me and encouraged me is what led me to become someone capable of nurturing the legacy her parents left behind. And I stand before you today as someone who has proudly helped turn Bright Moon Inc. into a company on the brink of becoming a global household name.”

Catra could use a shot right now, honestly. Adora may have been onto something, but at least she has a script to stick to. Catra’s just left rambling, trying not to say something too incriminating while still making their love seem believable.

“It turned out that we were both lucky in many ways, but probably the most important being that we get to do our whole lives together. All the way from growing up to growing old,” Catra smiles, letting the ache of it drain the life from her. “And to me, that’s just about the greatest success I could ever dream of asking for.”

An appropriately timed round of applause rewards the two of them with a moment of unspoken coordination. Adora smiles ever so slightly, like she understands all the facets of complications layered throughout that notion far too well. Then it's her turn to face the room as she taps the edge of her stack of notecards against the podium.

The clapping dies down and a hush falls over the hall. It drags on for a few seconds and then a few more. Someone coughs in the far back, a bunch of shuffling feet can be heard from different directions. Catra turns to check on her, but Adora refuses to make eye contact. She just places her notecards face down and clears her throat. A few more camera flashes go off before she finally leans into the mic.

"Catra speaks of me like she's the lucky one, when in reality I feel like I'm the one who's blessed by her every day," Catra watches her profile as the words tug the corner of her lips up into a smile. "I was lucky to have a pretty normal childhood, until the death of my parents about five years ago. And then my sister and I struggled to find each other again after that, so for a long time, Catra and Bright Moon were all I had."

Either she's completely memorized her speech or she's decided to ditch it and go with her gut, but either way, Catra is immediately fascinated by her every word. That kind of blind confidence coupled with the way the spotlight captures her aura could make Catra believe she's an actual angel.

"Everybody copes with loss dif ferently, but I'm sure many of you in this room understand how easy it is to throw yourself into your work after something like that," she earns a somber sound of agreement for that one. "All I can say is that for everything my parents left behind, Bright Moon still never would've made it this far without Catra, because I never would've made it this far without her. And it's that kind of teamwork and that kind of love that continues to fuel and inspire every move we make to this day."

It's genuine. It's all genuine. If there's one thing on this earth that Catra knows without a shadow of a doubt, it's Adora with all her

walls let down. One of Catra's favorite sights to witness. Adora when she allows herself to be goofy, when she opens up, when she cries. It sounds so twisted to think that, but there's something about her when she lets go of all the pressure she places on her own shoulders and occasionally exists as a normal human being;not some perfect princess who has to have her shit together all the time. Spotlight Adora vs. Real Adora.

"All this to say that even when things suck worse than they ever have, it can always get better," she rambles on. "Sometimes you have to work hard as hell to get through it, but that can always be made easier with a good support system in place. Whether that looks like a warm bed and some food in your belly under a roof full of others just like you, or getting blessed with an amazing wife to help carry you when you can't do it on your own."

Did she just say wife?

To anyone else it shouldn't be noticeable, but Catra's studying her so closely that the way she scrambles to compose herself is obvious.

"Sorry , fiancé Whoops! I'm just so excited, you know!" She quickly corrects, the next part tumbling out of her mouth just as clumsy and reckless as she is. "At the end of the day , Catra really is my best friend and I can only hope she feels just how much I love her . God knows I'm ready to spend the rest of my life proving it."

Again, the crowd awws, completely eating it up. Only Catra knows how bullshit it is, only she can hear the frantic pounding in her ears, the way the spotlight suddenly feels like the flames of hell have come to consume her. She glances towards their table, where Bow and Entrapta are smiling in support. Her purple haired friend gives her two thumbs up and widens her grin when Catra catches her eyes.

But it's all a lie. None of it means what she wants it to mean.

"Thank you, sweetheart, that' s enough about us," Catra chuckles awkwardly as she reaches for the mic, edging her way back in front of the podium to put an end to this now. She forces a smile as she adds, "Many thanks to DT for having us tonight, and for all the generosity they've demonstrated by establishing such an amazing program that's sure to help a lot of lost kids find their way someday, just like the rest of us have."

The clapping starts up and she doesn't wait to grab Adora's wrist and lead her backstage, past all the hidden equipment and staff, down the stairs on the side to finally return to their table.

"You guys were amazing!" Entrapta stands to wrap her arms around Catra's torso in a lung-crushing hug.

"Honestly , you did great," Bow agrees. "I've never actually seen Adora sound so professional before, and even still she couldn't keep from gushing about you, Catra. It's so sweet."

"Yeah. Adorable," Catra says through gritted teeth. "I'm gonna grab a drink. Anyone want anything?"

She doesn't wait for an answer before starting off towards the bar against the very back of the room.

*

Tequila works. She watches from afar as the rest of her table continues to enjoy the few speeches that are left before the dance floor opens up.

Catra's never been big on dancing, but as she begins her second Smash even that starts to seem more inviting.

Adora said she loves her. On stage and for an audience, but still. Once upon a time Catra would've been nothing but grateful to have someone think so highly of her. She loves Adora in a lot of ways, but friendship comes first. Or it should. It used to.

They have to be able to get that back, right? They can't just fizzle out like this.

"Hey," Bow's voice is the one to interrupt her pathetic brooding by the bar.

She turns and raises a single brow at him. She hadn't noticed how nice he looks all dressed up until now. He's got this adorable pale blue short suit on with a purple bowtie and some high end loafers that Glimmer or Adora probably insisted on. The three of them have been growing into quite the cute little family since the sisters made up, so maybe it's time for Catra to get on board, too.

"Hey," she says back.

"How are you liking the festivities?" He asks, conversationally. "You should come dance with us."

"Thanks," she honestly tries to be more accommodating than she feels. "I don't know if I've had enough for that just yet, but give me another hour or so and I'll get there."

He chuckles. "Do you mind if I join you here, then?"

Catra looks over at him again, curious.

"Why would you want to?"

He blinks like it's an absurd question to ask.

"I don't know if you realize what a big part of my life you are...or, will be," he shrugs. "Of course I'm interested in spending time with you."

"I'm not exactly a part of your life, though. Just hers," she nods towards Adora who's currently got both of Entrapta's hands as they attempt to do the twist to some bubblegum pop song that's currently blasting through the room.

"And Glimmer's," Bow acknowledges. "If you'd rather not, I can leave."

She sighs. She's just being difficult because everything in her head feels so difficult right now.

"No, it's fine. Sorry," she says.

"You know," he folds an arm on to bartop to lean his weight against it. "If there's something on your mind, I've been told I'm a pretty easy person to talk to."

Maybe he doesn't deserve to be let in quite so easily, but watching Adora work the room without her has made Catra feel desperately torn. One part of her wants to be by Adora's side, but the other feels like a kid cowering in the corner, afraid of nothing but her own imagination. So it's more of her own selfish need to have a venting bag combined with the minor intoxication that leads her to blurt the next part out.

"I used to be so sure I wanted nothing more in the world than just to marry her," it's not even a lie and that's what hurts the most, but it's going to keep eating her alive until she fucking does something about it. "But lately I've been wondering if there's even a reason to anymore."

Another not-lie. She takes a quick gulp to make the vulnerability slide down just a bit smoother.

"Is she still your best friend?" Bow asks it so automatically, as if he read her mind and came prepared with an answer already.

"Of course," she says, though her voice feels too tame.

"Then that' s your reason," he says simply . "Forget what anyone has to say about it. Forget anything that isn't you and her. If she's your best friend and you don't want to imagine life without her, then that's enough."

"It' s just so much easier said than done," Catra sighs.

He hesitates for a second, before his next words nearly sap the life from her.

"I know about the agreement you guys made," he says. "And before you get mad, Adora didn't tell me. I figured it out."

She purses her lips, turning to stare directly into his big brown eyes. If that's true, then what the hell is he doing here and why hasn't he exposed them already? Why even bother acting like he cares about whether they get married or not, if he already knows it's not a real marriage anyway? Who in their right mind would support that?

"How?" She asks, treading carefully .

"I'm just observant," he shrugs. "I know you don't live together , for one. You never talk about future plans beyond the company, and you still seem... nervous around each other , almost. Like you're comfortable, but only to a certain extent. You're both still afraid of saying or doing the wrong thing, because that romantic line has never been crossed before."

Catra sweats, biting her tongue as she lets him continue.

"Plus, now that I've also gotten to know Adora a little better , I can tell she's a terrible liar," he grins. "She gets so flustered. Even when she thinks she's selling it, there's always a little bit of tint in her cheeks like she can't believe she's not getting caught."

Catra smirks. Any attempt to argue that would be laughably futile.

She definitely underestimated him. She thought he was just some happy-go-lucky dude, ready to follow Glimmer to the ends of the earth. But Adora has been saying all along that he seems to be on a different page than his fiancé, at least when it comes to the two of them. Maybe even more than she knows.

"Well, you also have Glimmer planting seeds in your head, so it's not like you're some genius mastermind for figuring it out," in a surprising turn of events, she finds herself actually admitting to it. "Plus, no one will believe you if you tell them based on any of that."

"I'm not going to tell anyone," he always sounds so earnest when he speaks, it's hard not to be naturally compelled to trust him. "Not even Glimmer. I don't think she'd understand why it doesn't bother me."

"Why doesn't it?" Catra takes another quick sip. "We did it with the sole intention of stopping you two from getting what you want."

"I never wanted the company . I only wanted Glimmer to be happy and to have a chance at getting her family back in her life," he shrugs. "She thought she wanted Bright Moon, so I went along with it at the time, but it's so clear how horribly misguided she was."

"Well," Catra clears her throat and sips her drink. "What's the point of you telling me all this, anyway?"

"To say that I still think you two should be together," he says.

"Why does everyone say—

"Oh, come on. I figured out that you guys faked a whole engagement with barely any context clues. You think I can't tell how you feel about each other?"

Catra blinks. He is indeed way smarter than she gave him credit for.

"Each other?" She asks, casually swirling the ice in her glass.

"Yes," he says, staring her down this time, willing her to believe that maybe it's not as one-sided as it feels, because he knows Adora in a way that she doesn't.

Maybe she knows Adora a little too well, to the point that convincing herself there's nothing there has become too ingrained for her to consider anything else. Maybe at one point it was just pure friendship, but that's not the case anymore. And her new smart and observant friend is so sure of that that he's ventured all the way over here to push Catra back into her arms.

"All this to say , I don't think that you two going through with the wedding regardless of how the proposal happened is the worst idea in the world," he continues. "I know it can be hard to properly gauge these things when your own feelings are so wrapped up in them, but I think you guys are good together. And it seems pretty clear to me that Adora does, too."

She swallows.

Marry Adora. For real.

"What are you, her new best friend or something?" She huffs, realizing again how easy it was for him to work his way in, far too deep for her liking.

He chuckles, lighting up with a smile so bright she can only think of one person who beats it.

"I really like Adora," he says, "And for the record, I think you're cool too."

Despite her best efforts, she actually likes him, too.

Not enough to admit it out loud just yet.

"Thanks," she raises her glass in cheers, they clink, and she tosses back the rest of her drink.

Then she sets the empty on the bar and bravely marches over to where Adora's busied herself chatting up some pretty blonde lady to drag her back onto the dancefloor instead.

*

She hadn't noticed a slow song was playing, but it becomes glaringly obvious when the two of them fall into a closed position step. The few inches Adora has on her make it slightly awkward for her to be the one leading, but Adora just smiles and greets her as if nothing ever changed between them.

"Hey , Catra," she beams. Her body glides across the floor , seeming like she's floating in her head, too. Why does looking into her eyes feel like it's been closer to a few years since they've really gotten to connect? And why is it always so fucking easy to let her back in even when Catra swears she's had enough?

Maybe she is just as dramatic as Adora' s always teased her for.

"Hey , Adora," she allows herself to smile back.

"How' s your night going? I missed you," she' s clearly had another drink or two as the evening progressed, which is fine. It makes it easier for Catra to relax, too.

"Good. Bow and I bonded," she says. "Did you know he knows about us? Y ou know, the engagement."

"I didn't," she giggles, "For real? Oh my God."

She's laughing. It's funny to her. She must have some kind of trust in him already to be so amused by this potentially damning reveal.

"Yeah. He said he figured it out somewhere between us not living together and you being the worst liar on Earth," she teases, coaxing Adora's grin to hang around a bit longer.

"It couldn't have been helped," she shrugs. "You seem less bothered by that than I'd expect."

"I threatened to ruin his life if he tells anyone," she jokes. "Scared the pastel shorts right off him."

Adora's cute little nose scrunches and the light glints off her earrings when she laughs at that one.

"It's good to have you back," she settles into a warm smile and lets their next few steps carry their wordless conversation.

"I've been here all night," Catra says.

"No," she hums, tilting her head to rest her cheek against the top of Catra's forehead. "You haven't been here for a while."

Does she know why that is, though? Is she ever going to address it? It seems like that stupid kiss happened years ago at this point, like it's silly for Catra to still be so hung up on it. Maybe she should play dumb. *Oh, that kiss? Yeah, I remember. I thought we moved on from that already…*

"Sure, cause I've been by the bar trying to erase that mess of a speech from my mind," she jokes, "What were you thinking, ditching your cards like that? You practiced for a reason."

"I know," she groans, "I had a moment of bravery and decided to shake it up instead. You inspired me."

"Did I?" Catra's brows rise in intrigue.

"Yeah, I mean, you did great with just speaking from the heart," she nods. "I wish I could be more like that. More carefree. I've always admired that about you."

Now it's Catra's turn to chuckle. "You? More carefree? I'd love to see it."

Adora pauses, her glossy eyes staring curiously back at Catra. They do a couple more steps like that, hands together, circling around their little area of dance floor with the music and lights in the background. She has the same look on her face that's been haunting Catra's continuous replays of their last night at the hotel for the past few weeks.

Then Adora leans in and kisses her. It's soft and sweet, just like she remembers. And it fucking shatters Catra to pieces because it feels so familiar already, and last time ended in disaster, and she's supposed to be stronger now. She's supposed to be swimming away from this unrequited thing she's spent the entirety of her life drowning in, and yet all she can do now is dive deeper because Adora is everything.

It hurts to love her, but Catra will take what she can get. She'll kiss her now and she'll hold that close for later, bracing herself for when Adora inevitably changes her mind again.

It escalates into something with an edge that sends a shiver down Catra's spine because how can Adora not want this, too? How can she be so calm and so fine with just having a taste here and there, then walking away like it hasn't completely shifted the axis her world spins on?

Catra is the one to end it this time, breaking away amidst her fuzzy mind, slowly clouding with anger and resentment. Adora doesn't get to just jerk her around like this. Real friends don't do that to each other.

"I'm not gonna be some fun little experiment for you," her voice cracks, god fucking dammit. It feels like her whole world is cracking, too.

She wants so badly to let herself give in, but instead she wiggles out of their dance and ducks off into the crowd. This will be the second time she's kissed Adora and felt like she needs to put at least fifty miles of space between them to collect herself afterwards. One more time and it'll be a pattern. Like a serial killer, stabbing Catra into a victim again and again.

"Catra, wait—

Adora calls after her, but Catra's already too far away to hear the rest. She can't say all the things she wants to in here, not with everyone watching. They're supposed to be engaged and in love and yet it feels like Catra barely knows her anymore.

She's not sure where she's going, only that she has to go. She holds her stupid fucking dress up as her legs carry her down empty hall after another, passing a person or two here and there, until she couldn't find her way back to the banquet hall if she even tried.

"Catra." Adora's voice somehow still finds her.

"No. No! Don't you even think about begging me," she turns to point a sharp nail in her face, stopping Adora in her tracks before she can begin to weaponize those big blue eyes and try to win her over. "I can't—you can't just—

"I'm sorry! I didn't mean it that way!" Adora interrupts, the panic rising in her tone, "I just meant that I'm trying to worry less about things. About what could happen if we...if. I just let go for a minute and stopped thinking about the worst case scenario."

The way she trips over her own words suddenly shines a blinding light on the fact that she's never going to admit it on her own. She's completely out of her element. Treading water in the middle of the ocean without a single strip of land or floating salvation in sight.

Adora's not the risk-taker here, Catra is. She's the one who convinced Adora they could run Bright Moon without Glimmer, the

one who suggested straying from the business plans her parents prepared to create their own, the one who pushed her to venture into virtual reality tech, the one who suggested this whole fake engagement to begin with. The last time Adora took a risk, she babbled about love and friendship in front of a room full of people and regretted it a moment later. The time before that, she overthought it to the point that she stopped kissing Catra and decided to hop right back into the safe lane again.

But Catra doesn't want them to be in the safe lane anymore.

"Why didn't you tell me about you and Glimmer making up?" She asks instead, voice softening now. Her own fear tastes like metal in her mouth. What if she's wrong? What if everyone around them is wrong and Adora doesn't actually feel that way about her? What if she's about to ruin everything for good? "We were supposed to be in this together."

"We are," Adora nods. "I'm sorry. I didn't tell you because I didn't think you'd believe that she was done, or maybe you'd worry about me believing too much, or that you'd want to call off the wedding."

Why do you care if I call off the wedding?

"Why would you think I want to do that, Adora?" She frames it that way instead. Maybe some part of her is still hoping Adora won't make her be the one to say it. She's seconds away from just fucking saying it.

"Because without Bright Moon, why would you want to marry me? That's the only reason we're doing this."

She didn't want the engagement to end. She wants to marry Catra with or without it. It might crush Catra's world to find out something else tomorrow, but for now, it's the only thing that makes sense. Why can't Adora just say it?

"No, it's not. Of course it's not," Catra doesn't allow herself another moment of critical thought before she finally lets the dam burst. "Don't you get it? I love you! I always have."

She might've just taken a wrecking ball to everything they've built. For a few seconds as Adora's eyes go wide and she blinks back at her, Catra stands alone in the smoldering rubble of what her words have caused to crumble around them. There's no going back to *just friends* after this.

"You love me?" Adora practically whispers it, like her brain is still processing, like she had no idea despite it being the most obvious thing ever. Probably everyone on Earth knew except for her.

"You're such an idiot," Catra mumbles, teetering between anger and freedom.

Whatever happens, at least she doesn't have to exhaust herself trying to keep it concealed anymore. It's relieving and terrifying and completely fucking bizarre to feel all of it at once.

Adora just stands there with her mouth hung open and her eyes wide like a deer in headlights. So stupid, and so heart wrenchingly beautiful. Catra wants to wrap her arms around her and kiss the top of her sweet, dumb forehead.

"I love you, too," she finally says; like she's confused, like maybe she can't believe the words came from her mouth just as much as Catra can't.

"No, you don't," Catra shakes her head. She would've said it sooner, right? She would've answered automatically.

"I do," she insists, nodding her head as if to ground it back to earth again. "I love you. I've been trying to work up to telling you all night, I swear. And then I fucking blurted it out on stage like an idiot, you're right. I am. But I thought I hurt you again, so when you came over to dance I was just so happy that I didn't want to risk ruining it. again."

She did ruin it. She had so many chances to say it, even before tonight. Why didn't she just admit it the last time they were in a hotel alone with each other? Why did she say practically the complete opposite of what she's saying now?

"Adora," Catra can't let herself believe it just yet, because she's just the friend in this story. The really good friend who Adora loves. As a friend.

"I'm pretty sure I've loved you since we were kids, and this whole time I've been convincing myself I don't, like it's normal to have this stupid, constant craving for your best friend," Adora babbles on, frantic in her own jumbled thoughts as she lets her supposed *craving* take over. She takes a step closer, and then another. Catra wants to crash into her and fuse into one person. She wants to cling to every word. "Like it's normal to think about you and dream about you and want to share every minute of my life with you. But it's not normal, and I want it anyway, and that's why I didn't tell you when I found out that my parents wanted to leave Bright Moon to us all along, because it would mean that we wouldn't have a reason to do this anymore. And I... maybe I still want to do this."

The way she's pushing it so hard, willing for Catra to take the bait is breaking her down.

Maybe it doesn't matter if Adora wakes up tomorrow or two weeks or thirty years from now and realizes she changed her mind. Maybe any tick of the second hand that Catra gets to let herself feel loved by her is worth it.

"Maybe just wanting to have a reason is enough," Catra says. She gulps. Adora is standing so close now, barely an arm's length away, she smells fruity and floral and sharp and soft and Catra could just…

Adora surges forward and grabs her face again, this time mashing their lips together to prove she means it. There's no hesitation, no fear, no worry. It's just hunger. Strong and passionate and, and…

Catra gives in.

A

What starts in the hallway leads into the elevator and carries them to their floor, all the way down another hallway until they reach their room. It's Catra who brackets Adora with her back against the door as she struggles to swipe their key card behind her back. Catra who kisses her like the world will end in fire and ice tomorrow, like if she doesn't push herself close enough a simple gust of wind could tear them apart. Her body is engulfing;the way her chest sqishes against Adora's own, seemingly beating in synch. The promise of what's hidden under her clothes, how she slides her thigh between Adora's leg and presses it up in an eager frenzy. Her arms, her hands, her lips, breath, tongue. Her.

They stumble around each other's feet and into the room, slamming the door shut behind without ever coming up for air. Adora is about ninety nine percent sure the oxygen would kill her at this point, anyway. Anything that's not Catra isn't worth it.

She manages to get Catra against the wall inside, where her nimble hands start to pull Adora's sleeves down over her shoulders, nails scraping over the skin as the fabric stretches to move to her liking. The air feels frozen against Adora's skin, the way it steams at the touch of heat between them. Some part of her wants to slow down and savor this, wants to let Catra look at her and accept her in this moment, half naked and exposed in ways beyond it too. That maddening, fluttery feeling like this is the very first time and she's got no idea what she's doing.

The other side of her can't bear to stop their hungry smacking and tasting, like if they just don't pause or think or breathe, maybe they'll

be able to melt into a new dimension where they only exist for each other.

The top half of Adora's jumpsuit hangs around her waist and she wants to get at Catra too. Her hand finds where Catra's zipper is at the back of her neck and gracelessly yank it down, allowing the tight fabric to loosen and slide off the rest of her dress with ease.

She's got to pull away for just a second to admire. Catra' s sienna skin, the freckles scattered across her chest and shoulders like the stars spotting the sunset sky. The perfect round of her breasts, the cinch of her waist leading into the curve of her hips, thighs, calves. God. Adora bites her bottom lip into her mouth, trying not to scream at the holiness of the moment.

Catra's double colored stare catches hers and her mouth hangs open, panting to catch her breath already. They sit in that breathy silence, drinking each other in, not daring to break the unspoken awe of the simple fact that this is actually happening just yet. And then Catra reaches out to pull Adora back in with a hand on each side of her face and all coherent thought leaps out of the window again.

Adora ventures down the side of Catra's face this time, over her jaw to gently scrape her teeth across the skin at her neck, warm and pulsing against her lips. Catra's hands find their way to tangle in Adora's roots and she sighs her name like she's tired and weightless, and Adora aches to carry her to the moon.

She grabs a handful of the boobs she's imagined in plain sight since the dawn of time and Catra leans into it, urging with her moan and hiking her left leg up on Adora's hip for more. Adora automatically grips underneath her thigh to hold it in place while her lips continue their journey across Catra' s collarbones and over the swell of her chest, circling her tongue around the most sensitive parts. Catra sucks in a sharp breath and she hums a little higher this time as she arches into the touch, earning a dangerous throb between Adora's legs.

Her free hand continues downward, tracing her fingers along the edge of Catra's lacy black panty line under her tummy, around her thighs, until Adora finally palms at the front, her fingers just teasing through the fabric.

The way Catra rolls her hips into the touch as she fully whines this time awakens something desperate and filthy inside Adora. She wants to see her fall apart. Needs to be the one to make her come undone.

She can feel how sticky the fabric is as she varies the pressure of her hand, making Catra's nails scrape Adora's scalp in her urgency.

"Adora, please, just" her voice sounds scratchy and used already; the desire in it amplifying that natural rasp that drives Adora crazy on a normal day, let alone here and now. She's rubbing herself against Adora's touch and Adora can feel the racing pulse of Catra's heart against her mouth as she smiles into her skin.

Catra's so impatient. Adora can't get enough.

She pushes the lace aside to trace her fingers over the gift there, admire its fur and learn the slick folds and find the spot to make Catra scream. Catra gasps, tilting her head back to give Adora clear access to bury her face in her neck. She smells like remnants of her rosy Tom Ford perfume and something distinctly her, that familiar crisp scent of a breezy autumn afternoon. It's paradise.

Adora plants tiny, soft kisses on the tender skin there while her fingers work the woman underneath her, playing in the warmth of Catra's wetness, savoring each little sigh and whine and swivel of her hips. Catra's grip feels like it might rip the hair clean off Adora's head in a way she never thought to want.

They move together seamlessly, like platonic best friends do when one of them has her fingers inside the other who's so lost in trying to ride them to completion that she can't be arsed to control the volume of the sweet little cry that takes her over the edge.

“Adora,” she breathes quick and heavy on her descent, her voice still higher and needier than usual as she tugs Adora up by the roots for a sloppy, stabilizing kiss.

She lets herself go limp, so Adora takes it upon herself to carry her to the bed. And even though Catra’s barely had time to return to a solid person, she’s pushing Adora onto her back and climbing on top to straddle her hips, their kissing becoming hurried again already. Like her orgasm did nothing to calm her and instead made her even more restless to return the favor.

She wiggles the rest of Adora’s jumpsuit down her legs, rushed and hungry, like she has to squeeze every ounce of enjoyment out of the evening before the clock strikes midnight and their carriage turns back into a pumpkin. Her nails drag down Adora’s chest and over the contours of her abs as she quickly sinks lower , her lips smoldering a magma path right down to where Adora needs her.

She pauses her mission to brush her nose along the length of Adora’s inner thigh and she could swear it’s like her skin only exists where Catra touches it.

Then Catra’s mouth is on her spot and Adora’s body lights up like a firefly flickering in time with the knowing strokes of Catra’s tongue, like she’s been here a thousand times before and already knows the way to lead Adora into the sun.

She hooks her arms under Adora’s thighs, pressing her palms on her hips to hold her there, and Adora groans at how hot that is; as if she’d want to move anywhere but right here, with Catra’s face buried between her legs as she discovers how to put the stars in her eyes.

Catra moans into her and the vibration strikes a nerve that sends Adora’s hips bucking upwards, except they can’t actually move while Catra keeps them in place and doubles down her mouth efforts instead. She’s so strong and focused that it only pours more fuel on the fire her tongue is blazing right through Adora’s whole body.

She eats like it's either this or sleep for dinner. Like there's genuinely nothing on Earth she'd love more than to keep at it forever. She slurps and sucks and Adora's fists clench at both the sheets and her hair, lost in the thrilling fog of her own shouts and simultaneous sighs.

"Catra, fuck, yes, oh~~my~~ . God."

Forget sentences, what are words? What does anything even mean? What else in the entire universe could matter even half as much as the coil in her gut tightening too quickly and yet still just out of reach, using Catra's tongue as the vessel to guide her across the cavern towards it.

Her body wants to arch and then flail, but Catra won't allow it. What Adora gets instead is intense and dull, loud and soft, calm and rough all at once. It's the way Catra's nails digging into her hips somehow feels like melting butter as her weight sinks down into the mattress, bubbly in her own bliss.

She's vaguely aware of Catra lifting her head, wiping her mouth, and crawling up the bed to kiss her again. Once, twice, three or four or sixteen hundred times;who even fucking knows how to count anymore?

And then she finally collapses next to Adora and they lay like that for another minute or a year before Catra breaks the barrier between them.

"Is it completely out of line to say that you taste even better than I imagined?"

Adora snorts a laugh. Guess all that holding it in for so long has made her bold. Adora kind of feels like she could lift a tank at this point, too.

"I'll take it,"Adora smiles, turning her head to stare into those coveted, absolutely angelic blue-gold eyes as she scrambles to

compose something that at least slightly resembles a coherent thought. "That was.you're"…

So hot. In ways I couldn't have imagined. And trust me, I tried.

"Yeah," Catra simply agrees, chuckling lightly .

"Why haven't we ever?" Adora lets the thought trail of f into the air, still floating like the rest of her. "So much wasted time."

Catra fully laughs now, bursting into a cute little fit of giggles that quickly becomes contagious, until they're both curled into each other , loopy in the soft warmth of each other's bodies.

"Let's not waste anymore," Catra says after their glee subsides, leaning in to smash their lips together again.

Chapter End Notes

I am going to admit that the only fandom I've ever written smut for before this was mlm so, oof. I can only hope to fit in here on the sapphic side too hahaha.

As usual, I want to know where your little heads are at as we head towards the final chapter, so feel free to leave a comment below!And come befriend me on Twitter as well :)

Thanks again for reading, I love you all. x

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

Two dumb lesbians finally stop being so dumb.

Enjoy!:)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

C

Catra wakes up the next day convinced she must be on some kind of prank show. Not because there's anything wrong, but because opening her eyes to Adora's smiling face, propped up by one of her arms as she admires Catra in her sleep just feels like something written in a movie script rather than her actual reality.

"Creep," she teases, yawning as she rolls over and reaches her arms up and legs out as far as they'll allow, stretching her limbs into the morning.

"What? You're cute," Adora smiles, soft and adoring.

"I'm not cute," Catra grumbles.

Adora's hair is wavy from the braid she undid somewhere between the first and fourth time last night. Her lips are stained a darker shade than usual thanks to remnants of the makeup Catra kissed off of it. And she's still bare chested in the golden light of the morning, God bless.

"You're cute," she adds after a moment of pause.

Adora grows a grin when she says, "I had a thought this morning. I had a lot of thoughts, actually. About...things."

Catra's mouth twists to a frown to reflect the way her throat drops into the pit of her stomach.

Here it comes.

"Just say it," she snaps.

"Hey , hey," Adora quirks her head to one side. "What' s the matter? What do you think I'm going to say?"

"I don't know , probably some bullshit about how last night was a mistake, you want to stay friends, you didn't actually mean anything you said before your tongue just accidentally slipped into my mouth again."

"Catra, no," Adora visibly recoils, then reaches a hand out and pauses midair, like her reflex was to comfort but she isn't sure if it will be well received. "God, no. I meant every word. Last night was everything to me. Do you think I think this is all some kind of game?"

"Oh," Catra deflates as she admits, "I mean...yeah, kind of. The last time we almost got this far, you basically friend-zoned me. And I know that's not a real thing, but I just felt like, kind of, like maybe you knew what you were doing? So I guess I don't really trust this to last long."

Adora's brows scrunch together, distressed.

"I am so sorry ," she says, fully extending her reach to gently caress Catra's cheek. "I didn't realize my hesitation had hurt you this much," she leans in for a kiss, pouring the depth of her apology into it. Then she presses their foreheads together when she reassures, "I love you. I meant it. I'm not going anywhere this time."

Hearing her say it again is evil. It's evil the way Catra so easily melts into mushy, moldable, putty at the sound of it.

"Promise?" She whispers. For as tough as she pretends to be, she sometimes feels like a synthetic animal stuffed with cotton. Nevermind how much that's amplified when she's looking straight into Adora's eyes after the most romantic night of her life. It can't just end like this. She can hardly bear the idea of it ending at all.

"Promise," Adora nods.

This time, Catra kisses her forehead before looking her in the eyes again.

"Well, if you're not planning to break my heart again, then what were you thinking about?"

"I was thinking about when you suggested we should elope," Adora says, watching her closely.

Catra swallows. Even though Adora just said she loves her again, there is no goddamn way on this goddamn motherfucking planet that this conversation is going where her heart hopes it is. She's going to stuff all those ideas into the deepest trench in the ocean before they can even stand a chance at carrying her away.

"Sure," she says cautiously, slipping in the reminder of why that idea crossed her mind to begin with, "Back when there was an urgency to beat Glimmer and Bow to the punch."

"Right," Adora nods in acknowledgement. "And even though we're in the clear now, it's suddenly all I can think about. And I tried to talk myself out of it—

"How long have you been up?" Catra chuckles. This simply can't be happening. Things like this do not happen to her. "You couldn't have been trying that hard."

“About an hour before you,” Adora says. “But it was on my mind last night, too—

“You were snoring pretty much as soon as we finished,” Catra reminds her. Really, it was kind of miraculous the way she’d barely begun the last breathless giggle she could muster before trailing off into her sleep. To be fair, they’d been at it for a while, so Catra didn’t take long to join her anyway. But unless Adora meant she’d been thinking about it for a while before last night, she couldn’t have put much thought into this. It couldn’t actually be happening.

“Catra, will you let me finish?” She huffs. “I’m trying to say I want to marry you! For real.”

Catra blinks, stunned. This simply isn’t happening. She waits for Adora to regret the words.

“Sorry!” Instead, her voice goes all high and rambley like it usually does when she’s become nothing more than a ball of nerves. “It’s just that I can’t think of a single reason why we shouldn’t anymore. But I can think of plenty reasons why we should; namely you being the best friend I’ve ever had and the only true constant in my life, never mind that I’m just now realizing I’ve been in love with you all this time, but that’s barely even scratching the surface of it.”

Catra listens carefully to her blubbering.

“I mean, we work so well together, in the office and outside of it, and who knows me better than you? Who knows you better than me? Who could take care of us better than each other? What else could we possibly be looking for in anyone else? I’m not even looking for anyone else, because why would I when I have everything I’ve ever needed right here? Don’t even get me started on the sex, because if it stays this good then we’d be crazy not to marry each other, you know?”

She sucks in a long gulp of air before continuing again.

"But then I also realized that I don't want to marry you as part of an act, or for anyone to see or judge or whatever. And I know our friends love us and of course they're in full support and no one besides Bow even knows for sure that this started as a performance, but," she shrugs, "I don't know. I really like the idea of just scrapping all the lies and bullshit and turning this into something for just you and me. No one and nothing else."

Catra has to resist the urge to pinch herself. Her beautiful, glowing best friend and the sweetest, most loving and kind person on the planet is finally saying all the right things; things she dreamed but never imagined she'd actually hear even if they managed to live a million years on this planet together.

She starts to wipe at the wetness welling in her eyes.

"You're crying," Adora gasps, "Oh my God. Did I just ruin everything? Fuck. I am so... forget it! Shit, forget I said anything! I thought... but you... and we... shit. Shit! I'm sorry!"

"No," Catra sniffs, pouting her bottom lip out, "I'm not crying. Do I look like a baby to you?"

"Oh! Jesus Christ," Adora puts a hand over her chest to sigh her relief at what's actually happening, "These are happy tears. Of course. Don't scare me like that!"

Catra lets the laugh burst from within her. Her heart is soaring. Adora just proposed. To her.

"Are you serious?" She double checks. "If this is just some kind of pity gesture, you really don't have to. We can call off the fake wedding too, for all I care. I mean, someday I do want to be someone's wife, but it doesn't have to be so soon. We haven't even dated yet, technically, so we should probably figure that out before you make the huge mistake of tying yourself to me forever."

"I don't need any more time to figure anything out," Adora says, strong and sure. "Do you?"

They kind of already are tied together forever. Between their childhood memories and their present business ventures, it's not like Adora will ever not be in her life in some capacity, right? Why not make it the max capacity? Their friendship has always been pretty smooth sailing besides the minor conflicts created along the way by their refusal to admit there was anything romantic between them, but now that that's out of the way, it should be easy to find happiness here again, right?

Right?

"I don't need more time, either ," Catra says.

"Okay , then," Adora' s hands find Catra's left one to hold limp towards her as if she had a ring to replace the sharp black engagement stone with. "Catra Applesauce Meowmeow W eaver, will you marry me?"

"Adora!" Catra pushes against Adora' s shoulder in another burst of elation. That nickname came from when they used to play imaginary superhero games in the Bright's backyard. The fact that she even remembered it after all these years is impressive, but that she decided to use it as part of her spur of the moment proposal has Catra feeling loopy in ways she can't explain. Her stupid, silly, perfect best friend. Soon to be her stupid, silly, perfect wife.

Adora chuckles with her.

"Is that a yes?" She asks.

"Of course it' s a yes," Catra reaches for Adora' s cheeks to pull her in for a kiss full of every warm and happy feeling that's ever existed in the entirety of human life.

"Cool," Adora grins when they part.

"Don't start thinking this means I like you, though," Catra teases.

"Oh, of course not," Adora shakes her head. "You just let me kiss you and touch your naked body and lick your—

"Okay, okay!" Catra laughs again. "Fine. I like you. Whatever."

Adora grins. She knows what it means when Catra pretends not to like her. Maybe she's known all this time, on some level.

"I *love* you."

It's terrifying how easily she can get used to hearing that.

"Get me down the aisle and I'll shower you with that word for the rest of our lives."

"Shower," Adora nods, "Good idea."

The shower is soft and sweet, exploratory in stark contrast to the night before, which was all hurried hands and hot heavy breaths.

This morning, they get to drink each other in. They get to trace over curves and carefully caress each other and savor the slow reverence of their kisses, taking turns pressing the other against the tile wall and the cold glass pane to have their way entirely. They get to lather and sink into the suds and the scent of one another and the promise of forever.

*

Turns out it's not as easy to elope as the movies would have one believe. There's still just as much paperwork involved, only it has to be compiled quicker rather than later. And maybe it all seems so much more hectic when you run a million dollar company that can't

be left unattended for a couple weeks while you jet off to god knows where with your beautiful wife and co-CEO for said elopement slash honeymoon.

For day to day operations, the head of each department can be trusted to keep things running smoothly, and there's always the rest of the board to address bigger matters, but they're still gonna be swamped when they come back. Catra's already making mental plans to hide Adora's electronics to keep her from working while they're away, but if she won't listen to reason from her best friend, then hopefully she'll be willing to bend a little more for her wife.

Wife. Holy shit.

She's going to be Adora's *wife*.

Adora is going to be her *wife*.

It suddenly clicks why Scorpia practically salivates whenever she finds a way to slip the word into every casual conversation, even after two years of a solid marriage. And her and Perfuma didn't even grow up together like Catra and Adora have, crushing on each other from afar for so many years before finally getting to make the switch. Catra's going to combust the first time she gets to say it out loud.

"Adora," she calls her name to grab her actual fiancé's attention from across the office.

"Hm?" Adora looks up, clicking a pen in her hand while she leans back in her chair, waiting on hold with the bluetooth speaker visible in her ear.

"I love you," it's been one single day since they left the hotel, so she's nowhere near even being used to saying that just yet.

Adora's smile spreads fondly.

"I love you, too," she says it automatically, with a conviction that speaks to her commitment to ensuring Catra believes it. Like she really has been waiting her whole life to let it out. "Which is precisely why I've been on the phone all morning, trying to find out who exactly I need to pay what sum of money to help get this marriage license expedited as quickly as possible."

"Let's just do it," Catra blurts it before she can even consider thinking anything through. Call it her gut feeling taking matters into its own hands.

Adora pauses, holding her gaze in wait for the punchline that never comes.

"Oh, you're serious?" Her eyes widen slightly. "But we can't just—I mean, there's like, red tape and stuff. And we have to make sure Bright Moon is taken care of. I thought that's why we decided on spending the week here to get everything in order before we head out?"

"Screw it. Isn't eloping supposed to be just two people dropping everything to run away without a care in the world?" Catra asks, her mind fully racing with the idea now. "We can literally hop on a plane tonight, find an officiant, say some cheesy vows, kiss on a beach somewhere and then it's done. Forget all the legal shit, we can handle it when we get home."

Adora takes another moment to ponder, and then she allows her grin to grow.

"You wanna marry me so bad."

Catra can feel the way her cheeks redden.

"What? Ish—hut up!" She scoffs.

Adora laughs. "You can't even wait a few more days to make it official."

“We’re already official,” Catra reminds her, holding up her left hand to waggle the rock on her ring finger in the air. She might have picked it herself, and it might be a symbol of the fake marriage that fell through, but Catra kind of likes their wacky engagement story exactly as it is. Even if only certain people can know about it.

“Official official,” Adora waggles her brows, teasing.

“Oh, whatever,” Catra huffs, crossing her arms as she pouts, “You proposed to me, but somehow I’m the sap who can’t wait to be with you forever?”

“Technically you proposed first,” Adora counters. “Way back when you convinced me that the only way to keep the company was obviously for us to tie the knot.”

“That didn’t count!”

“I dunno, I think on some level, it did,” Adora hums like she’s unlocked all the secrets of the world and decided to keep them for herself.

“How about this? No wedding at all. I murder you instead,” Catra threatens.

“Aww, our very own true crime documentary? You shouldn’t have,” Adora fawns.

“Fine, whatever! We’ll do it your way! The boring way,” Catra rolls her eyes, averting them back to her desk monitor to put an end to the stupid, embarrassing discussion.

“Catra, I’m just messing with you,” Adora laughs. “I love it. The kissing on a beach at sunset, not the murder plot.”

Catra pauses, waiting for a follow up.

“So you’re picturing a sunset ceremony now?” She seizes her opportunity to poke some fun right back.

"It can be in the middle of the night for all I care," Adora is still grinning. This stupid dork is genuinely so excited to marry her. *Adora* is just as excited to marry *her*.

"Really?" She double checks.

"Yeah," Adora nods. "This is the new, carefree me, right? So let's do it. Bright Moon will be fine without us. I've already notified the company of our impending absence, so I can't think of a single other reason not to."

Catra gulps. "Do we even know where we're going?"

"I've been thinking about the Maldives," she suggests, "I could use a week at one of those luxurious water villas."

"Sounds great. I could use a week of you in a bikini," Catra revels in the tint that springs into Adora's cheeks. To be completely honest, Catra would have happily agreed to wherever.

"Or, oh! What about a treehouse in Bali?" Adora adds a moment later. "We could stay at one of those places with the huge pool overlooking the jungle canopy. What do you think? Beach or jungle? Or, what if we do a week in the Maldives, come home for the reception, and then Bali for the honeymoon?"

"Adora," Catra chuckles at her scatterbrained rambling. "You really want to fly all over like that?"

Not that it's uncommon for them to spend a weekend in other cities every now and then for business purposes, but they just got back from Double Trouble's event in LA less than twenty four hours ago, and now they're planning to leave again tonight, so to do all that back and forth yet another a week from now seems excessive.

"Our friends would kill us if we didn't celebrate with them at all," Adora keeps thinking out loud. "But we planned on a month of travel

after the wedding anyway, right? That might've been a little ambitious, but we can swing a couple weeks at least."

"Okay then. Maldives for the wedding," Catra decides. Seeing how excited Adora is getting kind of makes any jet lag or burnout seem worth it. "Bali for the honeymoon. And then I promised to take you swimming with whales in New Zealand, didn't I?"

"Or Australia," Adora grins. "I'm fine with either. I just can't wait to run away with you."

"Now who wants to marry who so bad?"

*

Dear honored guests,

While the parties Weaver and Bright are no strangers to making executive decisions throughout the length of their business partnership, this will be the first to have a direct effect on you all. This message has reached you today as a formal notification of discontinued afternoon activities on the date of September 2nd, 2017. The Bights have instead chosen to appear as a newlywed union at the reception beginning promptly at 6pm at the previously disclosed address as planned.

With love,

Catra and Adora.

A

It’s heaven.

Clear blue skies, even clearer blue water, pristine sandy beaches and the sticky tropical air on their sun-warmed skin. From the moment they step into the airport it’s surreal to even have made it so far with her soon to be wife by her side, never mind the amazement as the seaplane reaches their island, or the continued awe as they carry their bags through the villa to their bedroom for the week.

It’s all shiny hardwood and funky furniture with an entire back wall made of glass to fill the space with natural lighting. The bed is a big king sized fluffy thing that feels like a fairytale with the way the canopy flutters in the breeze from the open window.

“Adora, come look! There’s fish in our bathtub!”

The way Catra’s voice bubbles with amusement tickles her inside. She’s already smiling when she follows the sound of it to find her fiancé pointing at the tub made of glass to let all the the brightly colored fish swim up through the floor. It is something to rave about, but Adora’s finding it hard to be as excited for anything as she is to just stare at this woman and soak up the fact that they’re getting married later that very same day.

“That is pretty cool,” she says, leaning against the doorframe with an amused grin.

Catra looks back over her shoulder. “Stop looking at me like that.”

“Like what?”

“I dunno, like you suddenly think I’m the most precious thing on Earth or something,” she rolls her eyes as she breezes past to head back into the bedroom. “I’m still the same person you’ve always known.”

"Yeah, but now I *get* to look at you like you're the most precious thing on Earth," Adora chuckles, again following her lead. "I've spent the last twenty years trying not to let that show, so I think I've earned the right to indulge."

"Twenty years," Catra hums as she slings her bag into the corner and goes to sit on the edge of the bed. "In all that time, have we ever been on a vacation like this before? Just the two of us, I mean."

"Hm. There was that time we ran off together on that family trip to Disney World when we were like, fifteen," Adora snorts. "We did manage to lose everyone for a whole afternoon, which was pretty impressive considering that we know exactly where I get my obsessive organization habits from."

"So, no," Catra snorts, lightly bouncing up and down on the mattress. "This is a first, then. Just the two of us, alone for the fun of it."

Adora pauses, drinking in the sight of her very soon to be wife. Unable to hold back any longer, she crosses the room and climbs onto Catra's lap, stradling her waist as she drapes her arms over Catra's shoulders and leans in for a kiss. For all the shit Catra talks and how hard she still tries to downplay her feelings, her hands automatically find the contours of Adora's back and travel downwards, settling into the dip of her waist to rest there hesitantly.

"More," Adora whispers into her mouth, detaching for just a second to kiss the corners of her lips instead. She can feel the hurried way Catra's heart pounds in the space between them, like she's still nervous to cross those physical boundaries, even as her hands continue their trek to spread over the curve of Adora's backside.

"Don't we have an impromptu ceremony to attend in like an hour?" Catra asks, voice low and scratchy in her tizzy.

Adora simply lifts her shirt up over her head, swiping her seamless bralette off with it, and tosses them both to the floor, following Catra's

eyes as they land on the swell of her bare breasts, now presented directly in front of her face.

"Screw it," Catra says, earning a satisfied giggle as their lips magnetize again.

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Seeing as how it's only a short walk down the boardwalk to reach the beach, they do end up making it on time to meet the local officiant they scheduled ahead of time for the big moment. They decided before they left that they'd already waited long enough to be together, and didn't want to spend a moment of their trip as anything besides a married couple. So once the ceremony is complete, their vacation can really begin.

Catra stands across from her in a thin black button down tucked into a pair of denim shorts, because who even cares about appropriate wedding attire when the whole point of this elopement is to do things their way? Adora went with a simple white cotton sundress, fluttering in the ocean breeze. They're both barefoot in the white sand, hands held and eyes locked as the officiant begins the setup speech. Golden hour is in full swing, washing everything on the island out with the warm colors of endless bliss.

The event is quick and quiet, a sweet little secret shared between the two of them. Adora already said everything she needed to at the hotel and the days in between, but Catra is naturally more guarded, so it takes Adora by surprise when she clears her throat to say the vow she'd apparently come prepared with.

"All our lives, it's been you who makes the plans. You know how I prefer adapting to things as they come, which has led to some crazy schemes over the years; most of which usually land us in situations

we've never been before,"Catra swallows, her grip tightening around Adora's fingers in her nerves. "And I've definitely outdone myself this time."

Adora lets the laugh rise up from her belly. A fake engagement leading to an actual engagement and then an actual wedding the very next day could certainly be classified as a circus act of impressive proportions.

"I have no idea how I'm going to top this one, but I'm still in shock that you'd allow me the chance to spend every day from here on figuring it out,"her cheeks darken as she goes on to add, "Adora Happysmile Rainbowfist Bright~~if~~ you tell anyone I still remember that, I will not be held accountable for any disappearances that may occur afterwards~~th~~ank you for making me the luckiest woman alive."

Adora's face just might break in half from how hard she' s grinning. She logically knows that weddings are meant to be the happiest moment in a person's life, but nothing could have prepared her for the way her chest soars like a spaceship wouldn't even stand a chance at besting the heights she could reach right now.

She can't help it if she has to wipe away a stray tear or two as she clears her throat to speak next.

"I didn't prepare anything this time. I'm trying to learn from you, but it's hard to speak from the heart when all it's giving me right now is an incomprehensible scream,"she smiles. Dammit if she can't stop smiling. "All I can do is thank you for following me halfway around the world to live out my childhood dream, you complete and total sucker. I'm the one who really lucked out."

It's Catra's turn to laugh now, her freckles scrunching cutely underneath her eyes as her face elates in the aura of the evening light.

The officiant smiles too, as he looks back and forth between them, waiting for his cue to continue.

"Do you, Catra W eaver, take miss Adora Bright to be your lawfully wedded wife? T o have and to hold, for rich or for poor, in sickness and in health, till death do you part?"

"I do," she says, giving Adora' s hands a quick squeeze.

"And do you, Adora Bright, take miss Catra W eaver to be your lawfully wedded wife? T o have and to hold, for rich or for poor, in sickness and in health, till death do you part?"

"I do," Adora returns the gesture of assurance.

"W ell alright then, I now pronounce you two ladies a very happily married pair," he says, motioning for the two of them to come together. "Go ahead and kiss your bride."

Adora is caught off guard again by the way Catra grabs her and swings her around, dipping her down to suspend them in a dance move that has Adora's leg naturally finding support between her wife's thighs.

When they kiss this time, it feels like the sun sets over the horizon just for them.

*

"So when did you know?" Adora asks as they lie in the afternoon sun on their balcony the next afternoon, matching Mai Tais on the table between them. She's in another one of the many breezy sundresses she packed for the weather and has one of those big straw hats on to keep the sun off her face, while Catra sits topless in only a pair of tiny swim shorts to tan her skin.

As if Catra could ever be the luckiest woman on Earth when Adora actually is.

"Huh?" Catra turns to look at her , squinting in the light.

"When did you know we were meant to be," she clarifies.

Catra smirks, turning to close her eyes and face upwards towards the sun again.

"When did I know that I was in love with you or that I actually wanted to marry you?"

"Ooh, I'd love to hear both, but I was asking when you knew you had a crush on me," Adora says. "I'm just wondering exactly how long we could've been together, had either one of us had the guts to make a move."

"Well, when I actually had a crush on you vs when I *knew* I had a crush on you are very different moments," Catra says. Again, she looks over to smirk at Adora, reaching for a sip of her drink before turning forwards. "I wasn't kidding when I said I fell in love the moment you walked over to me with a cookie in your hand. I was definitely too young to know it at the time, but I remember thinking you were so nice and pretty. I couldn't get you off my mind the whole rest of the day, and couldn't wait to see you again the next day."

"Me too," Adora nods, "Besides the part about you being nice. You were kinda rude to me for someone who was apparently so smitten."

"I was a troubled kid," Catra shrugs. "If I trusted every pretty blonde who approached me with sweets, who knows where I would've ended up in life?"

"Fair enough," she chuckles. "For the record, I interpreted it as you just being awkward around new people, so I was determined to get you to like me for some reason."

"For some reason," Catra smirks.

"I don't think I actually realized I liked you until seventh grade," Adora muses, sipping on her own drink as she recalls, "Remember when we went to the homecoming dance together as friends? And that guy asked you to dance. Of course you turned him down, but I distinctly remember feeling jealous at the very possibility that you might've said yes."

Catra laughs in her cute, raspy way.

"Wanna know why I remember that so clearly?" She asks, turning to look at Adora again, "Because it's my moment, too. I remember hoping you'd ask me, and being so upset when he beat you to it."

"Really?" Adora snorts. "Is that why you seemed so annoyed for the rest of the night? I thought it was just because of the male attention."

"I was annoyed by everybody's attention except for yours, which I wasn't getting."

"So you thought," Adora smirks as she shakes her head somberly. "God, I can't believe we were so dumb for so long."

"So dumb," Catra agrees, pausing for a moment before she gets curious, too. "When did you first, um. Feel like it could be... more than just a crush? When did you first think 'wow, I might actually be in love'?"

Adora immediately has an answer for that.

"Remember my first breakup?"

"Octavia. Sophomore year. Mhm," Catra nods. "She got me suspended for two weeks. How could I forget?"

"She got you suspended, or you got yourself suspended when you kicked her ass for me?"

"She called you a slut, Adora. *You*. After she's the one who cheated! The nerve," Catra huffs, crossing her arms over her chest. "I'd finish the job if I ever saw her again."

Adora vividly recalls crying in Catra's arms on the front lawn of their school after she found out that her very first girlfriend had been texting other girls, and Catra was so personally offended by the news. Octavia tried to apologize later that day, while Adora was at her locker between classes. Apparently the girl had been jealous of her relationship with Catra from the start, so seeing them together triggered something within her and that little comment slipped out, which is when Catra lunged at her so fast it seemed like instinct.

"Yeah, it still sounds like you're the one who got dumped," Adora chuckles in fond remembrance of the whole event now, "And even back then, I was so impressed. It was so hot. Ha. It's probably inappropriate to say, but I got off to that for many nights afterwards. I remember lying in my bed at night, thinking it had to be love. There was no other explanation for the way I couldn't stop thinking about it."

"No way," Catra giggles. "For real? That's what gets you going?"

"You defended my honor," Adora shrugs. "It would have the same effect to this day."

"Yeah? Careful what you wish for, I'll knock out the next person who looks at you if it guarantees you'll put out," she jokes. Adora reaches over to playfully shove her arm.

"I wanna know when you knew," she diverts the attention from herself.

"That I was in love?" Catra hums as she sips again. "You know I'm stubborn. I didn't want to admit it for a long time. I think I finally accepted my fate that night we stayed up till sunrise studying for the SATs."

"I remember ," Adora nods. "Y ou were worried because you didn't want to disappoint my parents by being anything less than perfect after all they'd done for you."

"And you insisted they'd be proud of me no matter what, because I'm awesome and hot and flawless and you were totally in love with me," Catra nods.

"Now *that* is not how I remember it," Adora laughs.

"W ell, looking back with the knowledge that you apparently fell first, I can see where that little motivational speech came from," Catra shrugs.

"Oh, so now I fell first?"

"Y ou just admitted it!"

"I admitted to confusing my sexual attraction with love," Adora says, "When did you first notice me that way?"

Catra pauses. Adora can't tell if she's blushing anymore or if her cheeks are just red from baking for too long. She lets her eyes wander the length of her wife's body, searching for any other sign of a burn but mostly just admiring. Catra is so lean and smooth and her golden brown skin absolutely glows in the sun. Not to mention the confidence she exudes, knowing how good she looks with her tits out and the flat of her tummy and those legs that go on for days. Adora would very much like to lay back and prop Catra up for a ride on her face if she didn't also care so much about what she has to say.

"When we had gym together , eighth grade," Catra finally admits. "The locker rooms were life changing for many reasons."

"Oh no," Adora half-groans, but there' s a lightheartedness laced throughout it, "Don't tell me you're owning up to being that yearning little lesbian all the straight girls are afraid of."

Catra definitely blushes this time. "I didn't see anything more than anyone else did. I can't help it if I happened to like it more than most were willing to admit."

Adora knew herself pretty young, too. She noticed how casual other girls seemed around each other, whereas she had to struggle to seem normal, like her palms weren't sweating and her heart wasn't racing every time one of her pretty friends was around. It was comforting when she found the guts to tell Catra she was crushing on a classmate, and Catra's response was to reveal the girl she had a crush on at the time, too. Adora remembers the relief of knowing that they truly were safe to be their full selves around each other, at least.

"I'll admit it," she says easily, sucking down a big gulp of her drink. "Only to comfort my wife, though. If you try to tell anyone I said that, I'll deny it to my grave."

"No one will believe you," Catra says.

"What is that supposed to mean?"

"Adora, baby. Honey. Sweetheart. Your cheeks are pink just talking about it," the way Catra delivers the series of pet names like it's something they've been doing their whole lives sets Adora's whole body on fire.

"They are not," she denies as she sucks down another big gulp. How is it that even now that they're married, she can still lose her mind so easily?

"Mhm," Catra's eyes get that amused little glint in them as she stares right through Adora. "You know that's how you blew our cover? Bow also noticed you can't hide it."

Change of subject, please.

"Should we tell people how it all really happened?" Adora asks. "Now that we're actually married, I don't think anyone can be mad, right?"

Catra shrugs. "I think we'd have a harder time convincing people it was a scam than the other way around."

"You're probably right," she agrees. "I'm worried about Glimmer, though. She knew the whole time and we tried to make her seem crazy. Isn't that gaslighting? You don't feel bad?"

Would she be mad at Glimmer, had things been reversed? It's so hard to tell, considering a lot would have to change for that situation to even be viable. Glimmer is a lot more hot headed than Adora has ever been, though.

Catra shrugs. "She started it."

"Catra," Adora groans, suddenly scandalized by her own oversight. Maybe Glimmer will be mad, but she can't hate her anymore, right? It's against the family rules. Gran and Aunt Casta would never allow it. "We should call her."

"What? Now?" Catra sits up to look over at her this time.

"Oh, come on. Don't you want to share the news? Can't wait to talk to Scorpia or Entrapta about the romantical recklessness of it all? I've already compiled a list of about five hundred things I simply need to share with my sister since landing," Adora urges.

To be fair, most of it is just squealing about how perfect their ceremony was and how hot her new wife is and that she can't believe that new wife is *Catra* and they all get to be a happy family again, except this time with Bow when the two of them get married and maybe most of that excitement is just the alcohol buzz talking, but it's gotta go somewhere besides the woman she loves for the fiftieth time since they arrived.

"Fine, let's get it over with, then," Catra rolls her eyes.

C

When the call connects, Glimmer's face takes up about fifty percent of the screen, with Bow's head peeking out from behind her to fill the remaining space. Catra is very careful to keep her own image above the shoulders, too, to avoid flashing her new in-laws barely a day into the rest of their lives.

"Guess what we did yesterday?" Adora holds her newly adorned hand up with a grin, showing off the tiny gold band to compliment her engagement stone.

"Uh, obviously got married without even a maid of honor to walk you down the aisle!" Glimmer practically shrieks. "Ah, I'm so happy for you guys, though! And so bummed I couldn't be there! But I love you both so much! This is monumental!"

"I can't believe you guys actually eloped," Bow gushes. Even through the screen, Catra can see how his eyes genuinely gloss over with the beginnings of teariness. The biggest sap of them all. "That is the cutest, most romantic thing I've ever sort of witnessed."

"Where did you guys go?" Glimmer wonders.

"Heaven. Check it out," Adora presses the button to flip the camera and show off the view of the crystal clear water surrounding their system of connected villas.

"Oh my God. What I wouldn't give to be there right now ," Glimmer sighs.

"W e'd be honored to book it for you guys's honeymoon. As a wedding gift or whatever," Adora of fers as she flips the camera back

again. No doubt trying to butter them up for when she has to drop the bomb that may or may not set Glimmer off.

"Oh, Adora, we couldn't—

"Shut up and take the trip, Bow," Catra interjects, helping along her wife's agenda. "We'd have no idea what to get you otherwise, and we can already vouch that it's fucking perfect here."

"Yeah, shut up and take the trip, Bow," Glimmer agrees through gritted teeth. "We don't deserve you two. Best sisters ever!"

Catra rolls her eyes, but for once it's affectionate. Glimmer's clearly making a joke now, as opposed to before when she was using that word as a war tactic.

"I know," Adora simply beams. There's no room for fighting in their world anymore.

As if it were planned, Catra's own phone lights up with Scorpia's contact picture. She's got on her leather pants and jacket and she's doing two thumbs up outside the Two Door Cinema Club concert they went to after completing their college degrees. Catra's never been able to bring herself to change it.

"You sneaky little vixen!" Scorpia yells her greeting, as per usual.

"That's not a very nice name to give someone, Petal," Perfurma chides, poking her head in from the side.

"Oh, it's not that bad, and she deserves it anyway!" The fluttery tone of Scorpia's voice suggests she's not at all mad anyway.

"Say hello to my new wife," Catra tilts the phone towards Adora, who waves excitedly towards the two of them.

"Congratulations!" Scorpia and Perfuma both shout at the same time.

"Thank you!" Adora beams back.

“Ah, isn’t it just the best?” Scorpia hums when the phone is turned back on Catra. “Two wives in love, being married and doing things married people do. Like vacation in paradise, apparently. Where are you two? Tell me everything!”

She has to admit, her enthusiasm is fitting to Catra’s own bouncy castle heart. She takes the phone inside where the air conditioning is extra cool against her sun tanned skin, to give Adora the privacy to spill all the juicy details to her sister, and maybe some of her own, too.

She fills the two of them in on everything from the mundane details of their trip (because of course they’d want to know things like how easy was the airport to navigate and did you get sleep on the way there or were the in-flight movies too good to pass up?) to the more intimate parts like how absolutely heart-stopping Adora looked in her wedding dress on the beach to all the breathtaking views of the islands. And of course, the cool fishy bathtub.

And then, because she’s feeling so open and endeared to the world and all the people in it, she decides to tell her dearest friend the truth. It’s not like Catra can be talked out of her fake engagement plan at this point, anyway.

“So, hey. There’s something I kind of want to tell you,” she starts. “Don’t make a big deal out of it, okay? I just don’t want to have to, like, tiptoe around it forever, so it’s better to just clear the air now.”

“Do you want me to leave?” Perfuma offers, sweet ethereal being that she is.

“No, it’s fine, I just—

Scorpia leans in closer to the phone, eyes widened in curiosity. “Did you kill someone? Get arrested? Are you two secretly on the run and that’s why you had to leave so suddenly? Say the word and I’ll come bail you out asap.”

"No, Scorpia, shut up," Catra rolls her eyes. "Adora and I just. Like, we faked the whole engagement, okay? It's real now, but. You know. That was just a pleasant surprise that came from this whole mess."

"Alright Wildcat, you lost me," Scorpia blinks. "Why would you and Adora lie about something like that? Especially when you're so clearly obsessed with each other?"

Literally everyone on the planet just unanimously decided to let them figure it out on their own, apparently.

"Long story short, it was to keep her sister from becoming the legal owner of Bright Moon," Catra summarizes. "So we did the only thing we could think of, which ended up leading to—

"To you two actually falling in love and deciding to spend the rest of your lives together?" Perfuma interjects, stealing the camera away to gush like a fan girl. "That. Is. So. Romantic! It's like the perfect lesbian rom-com, oh my god. I'd totally watch that. Except I don't even have to, because we got to see it play out in real life!"

"Well," Catra chuckles, "I'm glad at least one of you's okay with it."

"Are you kidding? Did you think I'd be mad?" Scorpia snatches the phone back. "Wait, but if the whole thing was fake since the actual announcement, then when did you decide to get married for real?"

"The morning after the gala," Catra says. Has it really been less than a week? Approximately 72 hours, at that? Holy shit.

"No way," Scorpia says it very dramatically, before bursting into an even more dramatic laugh. "So you mean to tell me that after all the shit you've given Perfuma and I for tying the knot in only a few weeks... you and Adora ended up doing it in only a few *days*?"

Oops.

"That is so dif ferent," Catra huf fs anyway. "Adora and I have known each other our whole lives. You two only knew each for like a month before you proposed."

"Oh, this is gold," Scorpia' s still laughing, letting Catra's objections slide right in one ear and out the other, for sure. She's never gonna let her hear the end of this.

"Okay , bye! I'm hanging up now!"

"Sure, sure," Scorpia cackles. "Go enjoy your honeymoon with your three-day bride!"

Catra clicks the line dead. She can hear Adora, Glimmer, and Bow all chattering on the sunbathed deck, so she shakes her head fondly and goes to join them again. It sounds like Glimmer might have actually taken the news well, too.

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The only thing standing between her and Adora and the rest of their lives now is the reception, and possibly another honeymoon. Catra's kind of exhausted after only one week away, but for Adora she'll keep going. She'd travel to every corner of the world for that big, sexy blonde lady she gets to call her wife.

So, she'll get through the reception and they'll head back out to Bali or Australia or the fucking moon for all she cares. They'll drink some more and laugh some more and fuck a lot more, and she'll hold these memories tight and hang onto them for when their regular work schedule begins again and those weeks where she can't even think clearly around all the things that need to be done start to pop up again.

They'll get back into the swing of things and really, almost nothing will have changed beyond the fact that they can take a moment out of their day to peck a kiss on each other's lips between meetings, and when they leave the office they'll be going home together in a much different way than they sometimes did when they tried to pretend they were nothing more than friends. Their individual homes will become their shared homes, their separate beds will become each other's beds, and their lives will become their singular life.

Glimmer and Bow will soon have a new married life, too. And they might all still have family dinners and Catra might have to make room for two more loves of her life, too. One of them an old familial flame, the other a new friendly face. So maybe things actually have changed quite a bit since before this whole fiancé fiasco began, and maybe that's miles more than okay. Catra would even dare to say she's thrilled about it all.

"You look tan," Glimmer interrupts her thoughts as she seeks a moment of reprieve on the sidelines of her own marriage celebration back at home. "Sorry, tanner? Is that weird to say? I'm nervous."

Catra tears her eyes away from the party happening before her to look at Glimmer directly. It's kind of impossible to feel intimidated by the soft eyes and round face she knows so well, but there is a pinch of apprehension in Catra's gut as she wonders what's on her mind.

"What do you have to be nervous about?"

Glimmer shrugs awkwardly.

"I dunno, because we used to be friends before I left, and then I screwed that up when I tried to take over the company, and now you're officially married to my sister, even though it started as a big crazy scheme to win the imaginary war we waged on each other, so now even though I'm still kind of upset about being tricked, I also extra want you to like me again, but I have no idea how to make that happen," she lets it all pour out in one big breath, squirming uncomfortably when she's reached the end.

Catra quietly sips her drink as she digests that. All this time she's been trying to establish that boundary between them, but maybe part of having a little sister and being part of a real family is being willing to forgive and forget. At least when the things you once fought about have started to feel inconsequential in the grand scheme of things.

"Wanna go mess with Adora?" Catra extends the olive branch to let her know she's ready to squash it if Glimmer is, too.

Maybe marriage has already started to make her a better woman or whatever. Maybe she's just feeling extra happy and grateful for her life lately.

Glimmer nods with an eager grin. "You know it."

Chapter End Notes

We've reached the end of our journey, my dears.

Thank you so much for following along, and for your patience in awaiting this last update. I can only hope it was worth it.

As usual, I'd love to hear your final thoughts. And please feel welcomed to follow me on Twitter for daily spop brainrot, along with all the other animated gays I adore, and the occasional update on projects TBA.

Thank you, I love you all!xx

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